

laura's dark side

**arnica
butler**

LAURA'S DARK SIDE

A Wife-Sharing Romance

By Arnica Butler

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CHAPTER 1

Laura had the menu up for a long time in front of her face. It was made of hand-pressed paper and printed with some kind of rough stamp and smeared ink. The menu seemed to have been designed, expressly, to be difficult to read.

It was the sort of hipster thing, which along with a lot of the other hipster things at this restaurant, was making Chris regret seeking the advice of the only young, female, “cool” person working at his company. He had asked Avery for a “good, sophisticated restaurant,” perhaps overestimating how much their definitions of “good” would overlap.

He had wanted something special for this, his and Laura’s first date in probably five years, a celebration of the end of summer and the fact that their eldest child could reasonably be expected to babysit on his own. Chris could have asked one of the guys where to go, and they would have likely done as he predicted and suggested a chain restaurant they deemed “sophisticated” because it served steaks.

And they probably would have been a lot more comfortable at a place like that.

There were a lot of mirrors in this place, Bourbon and Feast – referred to by Avery and other people her age as simply “Bourbon.” In many corners of his vision, Chris had a full view of himself and Laura. An out-of place couple, circling around forty, somehow simultaneously over- and under-dressed at once. They were glaringly out-of-place against the exposed brick, out-of-place in their slightly aged clothing, out-of-place with each other.

The choppy silence of a twelve-year marriage was between them on the table, like a cement block. Laura was trying to break through it, lobbing the occasional attempt at him, and he supposed he was trying as well. But it was tough going. It was hard to make a joke anymore: they didn’t share enough time together now to have private jokes. It was hard to talk about

something new and interesting: they didn't do anything new enough to be interesting.

The kids had been a good glue, for a long time. Interestingly, they had also served as a wedge between them. But now that the kids were older, had their own interests, and had returned some of the time they'd previously leeched away from their parents for so many years, Laura and Chris found themselves with not much left to talk about.

And lurking around every corner was the terrible thought, the one he liked to stay away from as much as he could: what if there was nothing between them anymore, or worse yet, there never had been? What if Laura had only married him because she had gotten pregnant, and there were no other reasons than Liam, and then Chris Jr., to keep her tied to him?

And then, looming just ahead of that thought, a terrible abyss: And what would happen once Liam and Chris moved out and started their own lives?

Laura let the menu fall away from her face. She was shaking her head slightly, a frown turning down the corners of her mouth. Chris smiled: the menu was probably giving Laura fits. It was too sloppy, too illegible, too disorganized for her.

"I can't read *anything*," she stated.

She looked up at him. His spirits buoyed. Here was something they could talk about, ground on which they could meet. Should he suggest they ditch the place and go eat at the Chinese restaurant across the street? It almost seemed more romantic, with its tasseled lamps and red interior, its menu of terribly photographed food and placemats with Chinese horoscopes on them.

Nostalgia seized him.

Laura was a monkey, and he was a horse. It was so long ago that they had huddled in a dingy Chinese restaurant, on the same side of the booth, reading the descriptions and laughing.

He was nothing like the horse of Chinese calendars, and she was nothing like the monkey.

"I... cannot... read anything... on this menu," Laura said.

It was not too late to suggest that they go. A light rain was falling outside, the yellow and red fluorescent sign beckoning them to the comforting anonymity of yet another restaurant named Jade Garden. They

could dash through the drizzle and pile into a booth together, drink some plum wine, share Kung Pao chicken and drop things with their chopsticks.

At Bourbon, where they were trapped instead, a waiter appeared. He looked not much older than their eldest son, and his presence made the distance between the present and the past yawn wider.

“Can I tell you guys our specials tonight?” he drawled, in the overly-casual, aloof and mildly incompetent voice that all kids from his generation seemed to use for all communication.

“Please,” said Laura, dropping the menu on the table. She tucked her dark, silky hair behind her ear.

Her hair was down, yet another oddity in the evening. It had been so long since she had worn it down that she seemed wildly uncomfortable with it, continually pushing it away or back, obviously wishing it was pinned up, as she did for work.

Her tucks and fidgets were endearing. Laura was a slight, dark beauty, with the sort of pretty features that occasionally soared to stratospheric heights in the right light, or at the right moment. She was taller than most women at 5’ 10,” which was not a problem for Chris, who was 6’ 1.” Laura had been a bit on the thin side when she was younger, and she had developed a set of gawky gestures and habits from her years as an angular, too-tall teenager. Her body had since filled out nicely to slender curves, her features had softened, and she was quite striking.

But she never played the part. She hunched over to reduce her height, brushed her hair from her face or bunned it away, and dressed in such a way that she gave off the distinct impression that she was a mousy-haired, bookish, average-looking girl. (She wasn’t: her hair was dark and shiny, falling in long waves if she let it; her eyes were light brown and glittering, and her figure was the sort that most women her age would kill for).

The waiter, meanwhile, seemed to instantly regret his offer to tell them about the specials, and to forget the specials completely, and to be quite annoyed at Chris and Laura for even asking. He picked up the menu and began to read from it, his voice a monotone best described as sarcastic. Then he let it flop onto the table as though it were diseased.

“You need some time to decide,” he half-asked, half-observed. “I’ll get you some drinks. Wine?”

Laura looked at Chris.

“Uh... white?” she said, timidly.

“I have a Pet-Nat, a Muscadet, and a white Merlot, but do you really insist on white? Because I have a Cinsault.”

Laura looked bemused.

“The Cinsault sounds perfect, we’ll have a bottle,” Chris said quickly.

The waiter looked pleased, then immediately disappointed. “It’s just... you’re not having the foie gras mousse are you?”

Laura looked at Chris, who had nothing to offer by way of opinion, and then she told the waiter – uncertainly - “Nnn...no.”

“It’s ethically sourced,” the waiter objected, suddenly defending the foie gras mousse.

Laura’s mouth hung open, and she widened her eyes, as though she could understand better if she did so.

“I don’t think so,” Chris said, smiling at Laura.

The waiter nodded, his faith in their choice completely restored. “The Cinsault, then. I’ll be right back with that.”

They leaned in toward each other. “What *is* that, even?” Laura whispered.

“The wine, or the waiter?” Chris retorted.

Laura smiled. “Both. Either. I have no idea what’s going on.” She leaned back in her chair, looking at the menu. “I feel like our waiter is really disappointed in us,” she said.

“I’m sorry,” Chris told her. “And... I’m sorry about this place. Avery recommended it, so I’m not really sure what I expected.”

Laura was holding up her water, a slightly tinted beverage in a strange glass, which had been served with dishes of gelatinous probiotics.

The time was ripe to ditch this place, to run back in time to when they were young, not successful, about to get married because of a pregnancy, and a time when nothing on any menu had been turned into a mousse...

“I think I’m going to order that mousse,” Laura said, smiling. “Just to vex him.”

This took Chris aback a bit: it wasn’t like Laura to be mischievous. Maybe she was in the sort of mood to go for Chinese, maybe she was in the kind of mood to be a little carefree, a little naughty... maybe even to have sex?

But it was too late: the waiter was coming back with the wine, the bottle was open, and there was no way back to a simpler time in a Chinese restaurant. It was 2018, they had been married twelve years, they had steady jobs and a mortgage, a financial adviser and new sofas that matched the rugs and the drapes.

There was no other life.

The waiter poured the wine and took their orders, which they both accomplished by pointing at the menu.

After the waiter left, Laura confided:

“I don’t actually know what I ordered.”

Chris shrugged. “Me, either.” He smiled at Laura. “I’m sorry, again. We should have just gone to Kelsey’s Steakhouse or something.”

Laura shook her head, bringing the wine to her lips. “No way, man. I’m glad we’re trying something different. I just... this place makes me feel a little old.”

They surveyed the dining room. There were a lot of couples, and they were all *very* young. Many were closer in age to their eldest child, than to Chris and Laura, an observation that was lost on neither of them.

“What do you think you got?” Laura asked, taking a sip of her wine.

“Bacon,” Chris said. “You?”

Laura was taking a sip of the wine. She held it away from herself and looked at it. “Pretty good,” she said.

She didn’t answer Chris’s question about her meal. There was another silence, a little less awkward, but still there. Chris lifted his wine glass to break it up, and they clinked their glasses together.

“All these kids are on their phones,” he said, looking around.

Maybe they weren’t so bad, maybe this was just the way things were. Maybe there was no such thing as a close couple after twelve years of marriage.

As soon as the thought occurred to him, Rob and Jenna surfaced in his mind. They were a counterexample, a couple who seemed as ignited as if they had just met -

“It’s Jenna,” Laura said, just at that moment.

Chris’s mouth fell open slightly, the coincidence of thinking about someone and then having them appear traveling murkily through him, slightly thrilling, slightly frightening.

Laura's tone was strange. It was almost as though she had begun the sentence as a cheerful declaration, and then ended it as a disbelieving question. Her eyes were narrowing, her mouth falling open. She was looking over Chris's shoulder, and he was recovering from the odd coincidence of thinking about Jenna and her almost magical appearance.

Had he not been slowed by that, Laura would not have had time to reach for his hand and squeeze it, meeting his eyes and giving a barely perceptible shake of her head. "Don't turn around," she said.

He wasn't sure why, but his pulse accelerated. Laura had a scandalized look on her face, and her long right incisor had crept out to bite on her lip. She returned her gaze fixedly to her plate, as though she were examining it. "Don't look now, wait, I'll tell you when you can."

At last.

Excitement.

But what was it about?

He heard a peal of laughter, and it was unmistakably Jenna's. Laura had her chin so close to her chest that she looked absurd, making it doubly difficult for him not whip around to see why. He tapped on Laura's hand. "Sit up and lean in and talk to me," he told her. "You look super weird like that."

Laura forced herself to turn her head up, and she fixed her large, almond-colored eyes on his rigidly. Her mouth was twitching, unsure of what expression to settle on.

"What is it?" he said, in a low voice.

"Do *not* look, I don't even know if I'm seeing what I'm seeing."

Meanwhile, Jenna's voice, a husky, room-filling, attention-grabbing voice that dripped with a carefree sexuality, was bouncing all over the place. She was having a great time, as Jenna often did, and Chris suspected she was also wearing something that was snug to her body but somehow loose and slippery, because that was the sort of thing Jenna wore: clothes that always had a strap falling down one shoulder, or silk grazing her nipples and promising to let them spill out, slits that revealed she had no underwear on, shorts that poured her out like a caramel latte.

"Is Rob here?" Chris asked, though from Laura's face, he could feel the pieces coming together. A flush went over Laura's cheeks from the hollow upward to her delicate cheekbones, bright pink and revealing of

deep embarrassment. She shook her head and her eyes headed to the plate again. “It’s definitely *not* Rob.”

Jenna’s voice was now to Chris’s right, and in his peripheral vision he could see snippets of her. The large movements unmistakable, a slippery white dress and her golden skin boiling inside of it, her long, golden tresses everywhere at once. Jenna had her hair down all the time; Jenna had a puckish smile and a bountiful body and she was messily, loudly, intrusively sexual. She was not necessarily beautiful: you would never use Jenna to sell perfume or make-up or pearls. It was even possible that Jenna was not pretty at all: she just oozed sexuality to the extent that one could not help but *think* she was beautiful. It could have just been a lovely lie everyone agreed on.

He let his eyes slide to the right as he squeezed Laura’s hand. “Look up, you’re being so obvious,” he said, though he didn’t have any idea what she was being “so obvious” about.

The picture sharpened as he brought it into focus, his eyes moving, scanning, pretending to look into the recesses of the restaurant where no one was sitting yet and the kitchen expelled steam and white-aproned children with trays full of plates.

Jenna’s long legs, crossed, nude shoes with tall heels, Jenna’s hair everywhere as always, Jenna’s arms folding and unfolding with her characteristic style, her breasts, her golden skin liquid and in perpetual motion, all of it folding over and stretching next to -

Black.

An ebony colored person – and by the squareness of the trousers, the hardness beneath the shape of an impeccably clean white shirt, by the shape of his close-shaven head – a *man*.

A dark man, almost as black as the night sky outside.

He couldn’t help it. Laura’s eyes widened in alarm, but it was too late to stop him: he turned, abruptly, and took the whole scene in.

Jenna. Her voice had left little doubt, but his peripheral vision could have been telling a lie. Now, head-on, he could confirm that it was not a lie at all: Jenna, indeed, was pouring out of the top of a white dress, overflowing from two white cups, and the slim shoulder strap had indeed fallen from her left shoulder. She was pouring out from the bottom of the dress, all rounded calves and thighs, slender and long, golden and inviting.

Her hair was cascading, as it did in perpetuity, from her head, and her lips were in their permanent, pillowy pucker, smiling, because Jenna was always fun. And all of her was crossing and uncrossing, fluttering and stretching, over and under and around the black man who was seated stoically as a stone statue – though with a smile on his lips – next to her on a bench against the wall.

They were facing the entire restaurant, but Jenna saw nothing, because she was so caught up running her fingers over the chest of the man she was piling her legs on. Or putting her mouth close to his ear and breathing something into him.

Chris watched, and then he snapped his face back to Laura, stomach roiling wildly, adrenaline pouring into his veins. “That’s not Rob,” he said, stupidly.

The waiter was between them and Jenna suddenly, and Laura came to life as he blocked the view. “I know!” she mouthed.

No it wasn’t Rob, and there was no chance it was Rob. Because Rob was not as tall as this man, Rob was not as young as this man, and Rob was *not* black as coal.

“I have the salmon,” the waiter was singing, setting a scoop of a substance that looked like ice cream in front of Jenna, “and the Dorset crab lasagna.” He set a plate in front of Chris, who, like Laura, did not look at it.

They were staring at each other.

The waiter frowned. “Not what you ordered?” he asked, his voice indicating it had better not be the case.

“It’s fine,” Chris said dismissively.

“Do you want a white to go with your fish?” he asked Laura.

She shook her head, still looking at Chris.

“Okay,” the waiter said, clapping his hands together so they understood he thought it was not okay. “Taste that and... I’ll be back.”

His apron gone, Jenna and the man were back in their view, and Laura put her hand to her head to block them out with a cascade of her hair. “What the... fuck?” she mouthed.

She looked down at her meal at the same time, and picked at it with a fork, so it was hard to know whether she was talking about her salmon ice cream or the scene to her left.

Chris stole another glance at the couple. Maybe it wasn't Jenna. Maybe it wasn't a black man. Maybe they were just -

But the lips of the black man were now against Jenna's puckish mouth, devouring them, sucking them right in, and his large hand was beneath her skirt, and there was very little doubt about what kind of relationship they had.

Chris snapped his eyes back to Laura, who was burning from the neck up.

"What do we do?" she whispered.

Chris did not have an answer. So he stared at her meal.

"Is that salmon ice cream?"

She shook her head, and made her eyes wide, but tasted the pink-orange scoop.

Her nose wrinkled. Then her face softened. "I guess so," she remarked.

"It's cold?"

Laura's eyes were drifting to her curtain of hair, peering luridly through it at Jenna. "Yeah," she answered, vaguely.

Chris poked the item on his plate, which looked like a sample of sofa material draped over a Styrofoam square. The whole thing disintegrated when he touched it.

Laura, who had returned her gaze to his plate, laughed through her nose.

"This is lasagna?" Chris said. "This is ridiculous."

Laura covered her mouth. Her eyes were wet. She was getting hysterical, as only Laura could, because the situation was stressing her out. She had also started laughing uncontrollably at their wedding, and while she was in labor with Chris, who had almost been born in the parking lot of the hospital.

"What the hell should we do?" she squeaked, from behind her hand.

She meant, of course, what the hell should they do about Jenna, and the fact that she would eventually see them there, and the fact that she was clearly having a very extramarital moment over there with a very large, hot, black man. Should they run away, Laura meant, or should they hide in their hipster meal and hope Jenna didn't see them? And afterward, did they tell Rob, or not?

But Chris, with his project manager's mind, knew when a situation was no longer salvageable, and had long deemed the situation a write-off. Seeing Laura's eyes about to brim over with hysterical laughter, and feeling the effects of the expensive wine he did not even like the taste of, he went for broke.

He stabbed the "lasagna" with his fork and lifted the plaid outer skin of the rapidly disintegrating dish valiantly into the air. "We eat, woman!" he said, a little too loudly.

And of course Laura lost it completely, and the lasagna fell from his fork, and wine sloshed on the table when her knee jerked involuntarily beneath it, and Jenna's mane shimmered to the right of him, and they were going to be found out, and it would all be a very big mess.

But for just one moment, as Laura's eyes welled over with hysterical tears, and her face went red, and she was laughing like she used to, her eyes on him – it was worth it.

Laura turned her face down to the table and sat, shaking, looking at her food, until the tremors of laughter subsided. Chris pinched his nose and faced the wall, grimacing.

There was just absolutely no way that Jenna had not noticed them.

The waiter appeared again, distress half-playing across his face.

"Is everything... okay?" he asked, though not as if he particularly cared. His eyes moved from teary-eyed Laura to Chris, who was still pinching his nose as he turned to him.

"Yeah," he said breathlessly. "It's... fine."

The waiter was blocking Jenna's view of their table, and he strained to come up with a way to keep him there. He asked about wine, not really listening to his own questions or the waiter's answers, and Laura looked at him gratefully. She flung a few questions out for good measure. The waiter kept looking at Laura's melting salmon ice cream with disdain, which amused both of them.

But at last, there were no more questions they could possibly ask about wines, and the waiter departed, promising to return with a bottle of something they had never heard of, and they were exposed, again, to Jenna and her black date.

They stared at each other across the table, hearts beating, afraid of what would come next.

But nothing came.

Jenna was still tossing her hair and laughing, and her plump lips were still smacking on the dark mouth of her friend, and they were drinking and murmuring to each other, off in their own little world.

Laura stole a glance and her eyes went so wide that Chris turned in a reflex action.

He caught only a glimpse of the scene before he whipped back to face Laura, but it was an image that would remain burned in his mind: the ebony hand, wiry and veined, straining against the skin of his forearm, buried between Jenna's legs under the table. Moving, in the steady, rhythmic pulse of a man who was playing a very precise instrument.

Laura blushed, but, Chris noticed: she had a hard time taking her eyes off the scene.

Jenna and her lover left less than five minutes after that, Jenna's full martini and the man's half-filled tumbler of amber alcohol abandoned at their table.

The waiter had come with a full bottle of wine, and Laura and Chris stared at each other over the top of it, the restaurant suddenly empty and feeling like an echo chamber after Jenna's departure.

"What the...?" Laura finally said.

Chris poured himself a glass of wine. The sight of the ebony hand between Jenna's white thighs would not leave his field of vision, it was superimposed over his wife's face now. It was wildly arousing, and he couldn't say why. He sipped the wine.

It was sweet, far too sweet for his tastes, and probably for Laura's as well. He poured her a glass anyway and she took it and began to drink it, her eyes unfocused and her thoughts elsewhere.

The alcohol stung his lips, burned in his throat – the wine was almost like brandy, and he hated it – but the faint citrus scent of it made him think of the taste of his wife's pussy. All thoughts, in fact, were leading away from thinking, straight to a primal drive for sex.

"I can't believe it," Laura remarked, staring at the seats the couple had occupied. She swirled the wine.

Chris wondered what Laura was thinking about. Her thoughts were elsewhere, but they were not busy: had they been, she would have been

talking non-stop. In fact, she would have been chattering away uncontrollably, to smooth over the situation. Instead, she was lost, her eyes big and dark, and a pink flush spreading over her cheeks.

They drank the wine silently.

Laura snapped her eyes to him suddenly. “Are you going to tell Rob?” she whispered.

He shrugged.

It was a bad situation. He knew he should be considering the question, thinking about what he would want Rob to do if he had caught *Laura* at a restaurant with a black man’s hand up *her* skirt. They were good friends: the topic couldn’t simply be swept under the rug.

Or could it?

But Chris wasn’t thinking about any of this. He was thinking about very little. The only “thought” in his head was of the thick forearm of Jenna’s friend, disappearing between her legs, and the intoxicating high it gave him. His cock was hard, his skin was electrified.

“How are we going to get home?” Laura laughed. She sipped her wine. “I’m so *drunk*.”

He was drunk, too. He had some more wine.

They sat there, drinking, the salmon ice cream melting into a puddle, the “lasagna” disintegrating into a strange, plaid mush. They said nothing, just looking at each other over their wine glasses, drinking.

But the air between them was electrified, and it didn’t take very long for Chris to intuit – a guess, at first, then something he was very sure of, though he could not say why – that his wife’s thoughts were just as primal and debased as his own. That swimming in front of her half-focused and yet laser-intense stare, was the image of Jenna’s legs and her lover’s arm, and all that was implied by the scene.

He paid the bill, and the waiter seemed to have given up on them, or a tip, and merely collected their plates.

“Come on,” he said, at last, reaching for Laura’s wrist.

They got up, and she followed him, smiling, something magically shared between them; she said nothing as he pulled her along with him, into a cab. She looked straight ahead, a smile on her lips, and said nothing at all when he told the cabbie to take them to the Hilton down the street.

They were not themselves. Laura was another woman, the kind of woman who sat with her legs deliciously crossed and her hair sexily astray in the lobby of a hotel, saying nothing of money or circumstances: just waiting, to go upstairs to a room she had to know would be rented for less than an hour.

He was not himself, spending \$250 on a room for one night. Meeting his wife's eyes and somehow getting her to go with him, to follow him, smiling coyly, saying nothing.

They were not themselves in the elevator, when he pushed her against the wall and skipped all pretense of foreplay, shoving two hands beneath her skirt and pushing it up to cup her between the legs.

She was certainly not herself, moist enough that he could feel her hot liquid through her panties. Their mouths met, and they kissed like they were two young people who had just met – mouths open, tongues darting, teeth biting gently, lips teasing more from each other.

They laughed dismissively when the doors opened and another married couple stared warily at them. They laughed, and Laura pushed her skirt down, then they made it quickly to their room.

The key card proved difficult to operate, and they tried several times and were denied, before Chris lost patience and pushed Laura against the door, his free hand wriggling again under her skirt. Her mouth was beneath his, wet and hot, and she was pushing against him, hungry for more.

How long had it been since he had felt his wife clawing at him like this? He lifted her thigh, and she wrapped it around his waist, forgoing her usual modesty. His hands traveled over her ass, under her panties, into the gentle indentation between her buttocks, down to her pussy. His fingertips found her wet, hot, delicious. His cock throbbed against her lower abdomen, maybe her pubic bone.

He broke off their kiss and looked down to try and open the door one last time. She smiled as he leaned in to kiss her when the light went green.

Not thinking, he pushed the handle down, and the door gave way, sending them careening into the room.

They laughed, the door swung closed and they were in pitch blackness, but they pushed into it, going into the dark, careening into a bed, the light of an alarm clock the only thing they could see in the room.

Sex was wild that night, and Laura came like a rocket. A real genuine orgasm: Chris hated to admit that he thought she sometimes faked it, and he could tell by how wet her pussy got (or didn't), and by the telltale quivering deep in her channel when it was real.

It was so dark that he couldn't see her face. Her mouth seemed to be smiling under his lips when he kissed her.

So he could be forgiven for not seeing that Laura was staring rather vacantly into the darkness while he fucked her, and for not knowing that Laura – his sweet, straight-laced Laura – came so fast because she was playing out a fantasy in her own mind. A fantasy where Jenna's date put his hand up *her* dress, and worked his way between *her* legs.

And on from there.

When Chris turned the light on, Laura snapped back to their reality and smiled at him.

"That was hot," she told him.

CHAPTER 2

“My head,” Laura complained, staggering into the kitchen.

Chris set a cup of coffee in front of her. “For you, my lady.”

Laura grimaced, but slid the cup toward herself across the counter.

“Why did I drink so much?” she asked the coffee.

“It was fun though,” Chris said, hoping to keep the spirit of the previous evening alive.

Forever.

For the rest of their marriage, at least.

For one more night, if that was all he could get.

Laura smiled into the coffee and blushed. A smile played across her lips, and then it faded. Chris felt a heaviness descend upon him as Laura’s expression changed, her lips turning down, her forehead furrowing.

It was clear: they had not been themselves last night, but now, Laura felt they should be themselves again. Anchored to the earth, to responsibilities, to adulthood, to their marriage and all of its blandness.

“What the hell are we going to do?” she asked.

Chris sighed. It wasn’t hard to know what Laura was talking about: Jenna. He took a sip of coffee and absorbed the harsh slam of being redirected back to reality. “Do we have to *do* anything?” he asked.

Laura set her coffee down and twisted the mug in slow semi-circles, pulling it by the handle, a childish expression on her face. “I mean...”

“It’s none of our business, really,” Chris said.

Laura’s frown increased. “I know, it’s just... I don’t know if I can, like, pretend I didn’t see that you know?”

Chris knew, though he suspected his thoughts on the matter were of an entirely different nature. He resisted the urge to lean across the counter, take Laura’s hand, and say “I *know*,” in a smarmy voice.

He couldn’t pretend he hadn’t seen it, because it was the sort of thing he would masturbate to in the shower for ages.

But Laura, he knew, was talking about loyalty and honesty, two qualities she possessed in such great quantity that it was almost a fault.

“Look,” he offered, though he didn’t put much effort into his argument, because he knew already that he had lost. Laura was simply not the type to let this sort of thing go. “We could have *not* been there, right? We could have *not* seen any of that, and it would all just happen the way it would happen, and that’s out of our control.”

Laura looked up at him. He could tell from her expression that guilt was already eating away at her. She probably felt guilty for having a wild, delicious fuck after seeing a black man finger Jenna, feeling guilty for enjoying someone else’s infidelity.

“We *did* see it, though,” she said quietly.

She pushed her hair from her face, but did not pull it back as she almost always did. It fell around her shoulders, pretty and messy. She let out a sigh and looked at the ceiling. “I mean, I don’t know if I can just... *hang out* with them and know about that and not... say something. And what if it comes out later, and Rob finds out you knew all along?”

He looked at her, imagining this possibility.

“If *you* were having an affair,” she said, “I’d be mad about *that*, but if my friends all knew about it and didn’t say anything? I’d feel betrayed by *everyone*.”

Chris stared into his coffee mug.

He sighed.

What Laura was really saying was that he, Chris, needed to tell Rob. There was no equal burden on her to tell Jenna, because Jenna, of course, already knew she was having the affair.

He sighed.

“If you don’t tell him,” Laura said, predictably. “I think I’ll have to.”

He knew she would make good on this threat. He also knew that there was no way of talking her out of it.

“I feel like you should talk to Jenna first,” he found himself saying. He swirled the coffee and swallowed the last swig, before turning to make some more. It was perfect timing, he could feel the iciness of Laura’s stare at his back as she folded her arms across her chest.

“Why’s that?” she said, and her voice was brittle.

He shrugged. “I don’t know,” he said. “It just seems... fair.”

There was a silence behind him. He had been aware that wading into these waters was going to make his wife mad, though he wasn’t exactly sure

why. There was something about lack of brutality in honesty that made Laura feel it was still dishonest.

“Why, do you think Jenna deserves a heads-up when she’s out skanking around with some... some...bl- *guy*?”

Chris shrugged again. “Just seems like a courtesy,” he said.

Laura made a noise.

He turned around. “What? Don’t you think?”

Laura was getting worked up.

“I don’t think people who cheat on their husbands deserve any courtesy at all,” she said flatly.

And then her eyes got wet. “And I can’t believe that you do.”

Chris approached the table. He was sorry that this had all veered so far off course from where it had been the night before, sexy and dangerous, new and exciting. He reached for Laura’s hand. She looked away, annoyed with herself that this topic was making her cry.

“I didn’t mean it like that,” he said. “I meant it like... you could give her the chance to tell Rob herself. That kind of courtesy. It’s kind of more for Rob than for her.”

Laura closed her eyes. She wiped a tear impatiently away, suddenly annoyed with herself for having gotten so emotional that she hadn’t seen the good in the solution. “Oh,” she said. “Yeah. Okay. Of course.”

Chris was very impressed with himself, because he had only just come up with that idea, and it was a really brilliant one. It sounded better the longer he thought about it, like the right thing to do, and all that.

And it very neatly, very squarely, put all the onus on Laura to do the hard work, and took it off of him.

“Okay,” Laura said, taking a deep breath. “I’ll talk to her at work -”

She cut herself off, her face going pale. “Except...”

They both remembered at the same time: Jenna was off work this week, and the next time they would see her was Friday, for a party at their house.

Laura waved her hand in front of her face. “Oh God,” she said. “I can’t... I have to think about this later.”

They drove in silence to the party.

Outside the car, the suburban strips repeated themselves remorselessly: Bed, Bath, and Beyond, Chapters, Starbuck's, Kohl's. Repeat, slightly shifted, a few blocks down.

Jenna and Rob lived in a development much like their own: large houses crammed tightly together, a central swimming pool and a park, both used rarely. The hum of central air units constantly in the air.

Rob and Jenna, Laura was thinking. She didn't know why it bothered her so much, why it stung and left a strange taste in her mouth, to have seen what she had seen at the restaurant. It wasn't like she was some kind of sheltered Baptist, after all. Her own parents were divorced, her dad had most likely had an affair. It wasn't outside her ability to imagine someone doing that, and it wasn't outside the realm of logic to call it none of her business.

She *did* feel that she needed to tell Rob, or pressure Jenna to do it. That instinct was genuine: her own mother had been horrified by the "friends" who had known about her father's affair and kept silent, and when Laura imagined the pain of Chris cheating on her, it was infinitely multiplied if she pictured a situation in which her friends knew what was happening and just pretended not to. That kind of betrayal really ticked her off.

But the feeling inside of her, the really disturbing feeling, didn't have anything to do with whether to tell Rob or not: she was completely unconflicted about that. The feeling came from somewhere else.

The image of the man's hand between Jenna's legs would not leave her.

And it hadn't left her – though she preferred very much not to think about this fact – that night at the Hilton. She didn't even want to *circle* the real, true thoughts that had been going through her head that night, the real reasons her pussy had been so wet, the real things she had been thinking about while she and Chris had fucked so wildly for the first time in... well, ever.

Laura blinked the thoughts away. They were coals, too hot to touch, things she didn't dare to delve into. Her stomach was queasy, she felt like she was about to take a hard test or perform in front of an audience. Cold sweat was forming at the back of her neck.

“Don’t overthink it,” Chris advised her, calmly reading her mind.

She squinted and flapped the sun visor down, frowning. “I can’t help it,” she said.

What would happen to *them*, Laura was wondering. She was second-guessing her commitment to doing the right thing, to playing any role in disrupting Jenna and Rob’s marriage.

Stupid Jenna, she thought bitterly.

It wasn’t just the couple that got hurt in this kind of situation. It was everyone around them. Laura found this profoundly unfair.

She nodded to herself. This was likely the source of her conflict, she decided.

Rob and Jenna had become good friends, fun friends they could do things with, after the company Christmas party where they had discovered the interesting little quirk: Jenna, who worked in a different department than Laura but at the same company, was the wife of Chris’s buddy at work, Rob.

They had never been close enough friends to share all that much about their lives, and while Laura had known that Jenna’s husband was named Rob (and Chris had known that Rob’s wife was named Jenna) - there had never really been any reason to piece the puzzle together.

“Wait,” Jenna had said, her big mouth grinning sexily, her long fingers swinging from Laura to Chris. She had been falling out of a glittering sequined dress that night, and only too delighted to be the one who figured it all out. “*You’re* Chris,” she had declared to Chris. “Chris is *Laura’s* Chris!” she had shouted at Rob, smiling. “I know all *about* you!”

For Jenna delighted in things like that. Coincidences, “fate,” playing things by ear.

Laura had marveled at it all, too. She had met Rob several times at other company functions, or at a job site. Buried deep inside, she harbored a vague attraction to him – not one she would ever act upon, but one that tugged at her somewhere. A playful attraction, one that injected their friendship with a little spice, a private secret. She liked to imagine flirting with him, though she never actually did it.

She had also heard Jenna mention “Rob,” though Jenna was the kind of woman you simply assumed to be single. She was so flirtatious, so sexual in her every expression and gesture, that no one jumped to the

conclusion that she was married, even though she had an enormous diamond on her finger and wore it all the time. Laura had simply never thought of putting Jenna's Rob, and Chris's Rob, together.

At the Christmas party where they had finally put it all together, several years ago, they had gotten incredibly drunk, so drunk that Laura – ordinarily reserved, and never the life of the party – had hijacked a piano in the lobby of the hotel where the party was held and begun playing songs with her long-buried piano skills, while Jenna had done a sexy rendition of Marilyn Monroe, to the great delight of the scattered businessmen in the lobby who were being tortured by the soft jazz the actual pianist had been lifelessly playing for them in fifteen-minute intervals.

Chris had been amazed, Rob had rubbed her shoulders enthusiastically, and Jenna had thrown her arms around her and taken her to the bar, where men bought them drinks and gave them the sort of looks that Laura never got from men at bars, or men anywhere. The kind of hungry, appreciative, sexual looks that Jenna probably got all day long, every day.

It had been fun, wild, exhilarating.

And then they had gone back to barbecues and football games, occasional karaoke or quiz night, and Laura had been fine with that, because she wasn't really the kind of girl to hijack pianos and accept drinks from strange men. She just liked having the one-time memory of it, the badge of honor in her memory.

And she had Jenna for a friend. She liked watching Jenna move, and laugh, and tell stories, because Jenna was the kind of woman Laura knew she would never be, and it was fun to live...well, vicariously, through her.

In the car, Laura closed her eyes. Why was any of this surprising? Jenna was far too sexual, too charming, too flirtatious, to *not* end up having an affair.

"They just seemed so in love," Laura said quietly, and it was only after she said it that she realized she had spoken out loud.

She turned to Chris, startled, to see what his reaction would be. He had his index finger pressed to his lips, resting along the lower lip like a shelf, and his eyes were on the road but just barely. He was miles away, thinking.

Laura turned to watch out of her own window.

*

“Hey-ye-ye-ye!” Jenna shrieked, arms open, her body moving in a way that gave the impression that she was dancing when she was not. It was how she greeted everyone, whether it was a Saturday night party or a Monday morning.

Her long blonde hair was flowing, as usual, now crimped into waves that made it look like she had come from surfing. Her skin was flushed, and slightly damp, because she *had* been dancing. She had on a white shirt that might have been a leotard, tight to her skin and likely to show the outline of her nipples. Over this she had draped a flowing, see-through cape, which slipped and twisted but never let anyone see the curve of her breast and the hard nub of her nipple in full. And quite literally all eyes gravitated toward her chest, waiting for the opportunity. The shirt was tucked into tight jeans, expensive-looking in their faded wash and ripped knees. As always, Jenna had on 4-inch spindley stilettos, lifting her average frame to just below Laura’s natural height.

Today, Jenna was going for her casual look, and she had the body and fashion of a celebrity, which carried her face convincingly along with it. “What would you like to drink?” she asked, kissing Chris on the cheeks and taking Laura by both hands. “Tell Rob, though, I don’t feel like making it. Laura, come dance with me, everyone is being very lame.”

Laura let herself be pulled by Jenna toward the living room, where Jenna had cleared a dance floor that most people were using for talking. She knew better than to argue about it, and she also knew that eventually she could stand off to the side, and Jenna would let her stand there while she danced by herself.

Laura swept her eyes over the scene at the party, scrutinizing more than usual.

Looking for Jenna’s friend, the tall black man -
She stopped herself.

The usual people were there: some coworkers, some old friends of Jenna’s, some neighbors. No one unusual. Nothing unusual.

The party was revving up, but no one had had enough to drink yet – people were still talking at a normal volume, asking about trips and vacations. Laura looked behind her to see that Chris had disappeared, likely

into the kitchen to get some drinks. She suddenly wanted a drink very badly. Her stomach churned.

Jenna set her own drink on the brick mantle and turned wildly to Laura. Her eyes went wide and her mouth twitched mischievously: it was Jenna's "I-have-to-talk-to-you" face.

Laura's stomach leaped in her gut and she felt her skin get cold. God. Jenna had seen them, of course she had, and now she was going to ask Laura to keep her secret. And she couldn't do it. She would have to confront her, which was something Laura hated, but unfortunately hated only slightly less than being dishonest.

Jenna reached for her forearm and grasped it, eyes still growing, mouth still twisting. She swallowed the swig of whatever her drink was and said, breathlessly:

"Oh. My. God. Have you *seen* the new guy in underwriting?"

Laura had been bracing for something else entirely, so she stared at Jenna dumbly, uncomprehending. "Huh?" she said at last, but Jenna was already talking over her and coming in to speak very close to Laura's face.

"He's Australian," Jenna said. "So he talks like... I mean, you know. His accent is..." Jenna's sentence was completed by an orgasmic sort of flutter through her body, and then she moved on. "He's a rock climber, so he's got these hands..."

Another orgasmic flutter.

Laura's face felt hot. There was nothing unusual about this conversation: Jenna loved talking about new guys whenever they showed up in her life, but Laura had always thought it was just sort of an act, one that all the women in the office did playfully.

Now it seemed dark.

Jenna noticed nothing. She took another swig of her drink. "I invited him," she said, as she tipped the glass. "He sits like two desks down from me so I get to look at him all day."

She looked at Laura, and laughed. There was also nothing unusual about this, because Jenna was always laughing at Laura's buttoned-up awkwardness. She claimed to find it endearing.

Laura looked back at the kitchen while Jenna fiddled with the stereo. She really needed that drink.

“So what have you been up to?” Jenna asked. She made a murmuring sound as she assessed her music. “How was the office all week?” she teased, not really wanting the answer. She rolled her eyes, and made a selection. Then she stared thoughtfully at the ceiling as she listened to the first few chords. It was R&B, which Laura knew almost nothing about.

“Jenna,” Laura found herself saying. She reached for her arm. “I need _.”

But the music was suddenly loud, and Jenna’s attention was suddenly snapped up from the direction of the kitchen, and her arm was lifting to beckon someone over. Laura turned to see Chris and Rob heading toward them with drinks.

“Here you are,” Chris said, handing Laura a small glass that looked like it was a Rum and Coke – he had even put a cherry in it. Laura took the drink and started to gulp it down.

She wasn’t actually a fan of Rum and Cokes: she had ordered one the first time she went to a bar because it was the only drink she could actually think of. She had continued to drink them because she had been too shy and too awkward to ask about other drinks, and before long everyone she had ever been to a bar with assumed she just loved rum and Cokes, which she also felt bad about correcting.

She gulped it down, which was not going to contribute any evidence to the contrary. Chris was talking to Jenna, amicably, shouting over the music, like everything was normal. The ice clinked in her glass. She looked at Rob, who was smiling. He reached over Chris’s arms and took the glass from Laura’s hand. “I’ll get you another,” he mouthed.

Laura stood there, the very heavy dose of rum going to her head, heart pounding, feeling foolish and like she needed to do something. She was annoyed with Chris, who was laughing at whatever Jenna kept leaning in to tell him, and even more annoyed that he wouldn’t look at her to see that she was annoyed.

Rob was back in a few minutes, and he handed the second Rum and Coke to Laura.

She tried sipping cautiously, but emptied it in minutes, while they stood and chatted. Jenna left to greet more people, Rob and Chris started talking about boats, and Laura fumed. Then she went to the kitchen to make her third drink.

Which, the way Rob and Chris had made the first two, was really more like her sixth.

She was good and drunk about twenty minutes later, and the party was starting to pick up. The music had gotten louder, the people had gotten louder even when the music was off, and a few people had started dancing. Chris was talking to a group of guys from work, and it was probably business. Laura found herself sitting on the stairs, trying to be alone, because her drinks and her guilty conscience were making her morose. But some of the girls from work had clustered near her and included her in a conversation without her really having to contribute much.

She stared through their legs at the dance floor, where Jenna was dancing by herself, occasionally dragging someone – women, men, she didn't care – out to dance. Everyone eventually defected, but that didn't stop Jenna.

Her drapy cape slid off her shoulders, and now her tight white shirt showed off her splendid breasts and her hard nipples. Even Laura couldn't help but admire her curves. She admired the way Jenna danced, too, the way she was so alluring, so carefree, so confident. She didn't care who was watching, and everyone was.

She meandered back into the kitchen to make herself another drink.

And then Jenna came tumbling in. "There you are!" she exclaimed. She came to stand next to Laura, a little winded, her skin damp with sweat. A line of silver sweat glistened just above her upper lip, and her cheeks were flushed. Laura's eyes skimmed her figure quickly as she looked back at the drink she was making.

"I was going to come and rescue you, I promise," Jenna said. "Let me guess, Cathy is complaining about the lunchroom."

Jenna took a piece of ice and placed it on the back of her neck, then started to roll it over her skin. Laura stared at her as the ice melted, and vaguely pornographic drops of water beaded and dripped into the crevice between her breasts.

"I was at Bourbon and Feast," Laura blurted, though her voice came out barely louder than a whisper. Almost a croak. The back of her throat stuck together, and she took a quick swallow of her drink.

Jenna was still rubbing the ice over her skin. If the statement had affected her, she didn't show it at all. She hadn't even reacted.

Maybe she hadn't heard.

"Jenna," she said.

Jenna looked at her.

"I was at Bourbon and Feast. Last... on Saturday."

Jenna was looking at her, face unchanged, and she continued looking at her. The expression changed from neutral to slightly confused. Her lips twitched and she cocked her head slightly.

"And...?" she finally prompted.

Laura's eyebrows shot up.

Jenna was wearing such a genuinely *normal* face, that for a moment Laura wondered if she hadn't gotten things all wrong. Maybe the woman she had seen just looked incredibly like Jenna, and this was all just a huge mistake. For Jenna was standing there just really looking for all the world like a person who wanted the other person to finish a half-complete sentence.

"And..." Laura squeaked. "I saw... I saw someone who... I think..." Her head was reeling.

Jenna turned her head ever-so-slightly to the side. It was a small, micro movement, as though she just wanted to edge her right ear a centimeter closer to hear Laura better.

But recognition was creeping into her features.

Laura took the plunge. "I thought I saw you there...Saturday. Last Saturday," she said helplessly. "But it, maybe it wasn't you, maybe it was... all a mistake."

As soon as she said this last bit, she could feel hope flaring inside of her.

Yes. That would be perfect. It *wasn't* Jenna at all. Then she could set aside all of the bad feelings, and think about that man's hand between Jenna's – *not Jenna's, a total stranger's* – legs, and she could enjoy the image -

Jenna was thinking. She looked up at the ceiling. She stuck out her lower lip and screwed up her eyes.

Laura started to feel relief. If Jenna was guilty of having an affair, surely this conversation would have affected her somehow. No. Instead,

Jenna was just trying to think of where she was on Saturday. She would tell her in a moment. And this would all be cleared up.

Jenna suddenly bloomed. She had it, she had the answer. She reached for Laura's hand, and her eyes were glinting merrily.

And then she opened her mouth, and said:

"Oh! Was I with a black guy?"

Laura's entire body froze, as did every cell capable of thinking. Her jaw went slack, her eyes went wide. "Uh..." she said.

Jenna returned to making drinks. Then she looked back up at Laura, a spoon turned upside down on her tongue. Like she had just asked Laura about the color of a car, or a sweater they were both discussing.

"Um," Laura repeated. "I..."

"Yeah, sorry," Jenna plowed ahead, tossing the spoon into the sink. "I just didn't really know the actual name of that bar. I call it Berbs. What were you doing there?"

Laura could feel her face going white.

What the *hell* was going on?

She tried to get control of her thoughts, which were in a very wild tailspin. Flailing, she reached for the only question she felt she could actually answer.

"I was... out on a date... with Chris."

Jenna took a sip of her drink, frowned, and reached for a lime.

"What'd you think of that place? This chick at Rob's work recommended it, and we went there once for dinner, but the food was totally crazy." She looked at Laura again while she squeezed the lime into her drink. Taking Laura's expression for agreement about the food at Bourbon and Feast, she nodded. "Sheesh. I could have saved you the bad experience. Now I *only* go there for drinks, and *only* because I know the bartender."

Laura's jaw was still hanging open, and she could not figure out how to move it.

Jenna was drinking, looking over the rim of her glass at Laura, like any ordinary person waiting for an ordinary conversation to continue.

"But you... you were with that guy..."

Then, suddenly, Jenna's eyes got wide, and a flash of understanding broke across her face. She tipped the drink forward, the ice clanging, and

laughed, covering her mouth. She wiped her lips and reached for Laura's forearm. "Oh, shit. You didn't know."

Laura did not know what there was to possibly know, so she just shook her head.

"It's fine," Jenna said, shaking her head slightly. "Rob and I are into the lifestyle. That's a guy I see pretty regularly." She leaned close to Laura. "You can see why, amirite?" She slammed her drink. "Mmm. Oh, man, I'm sorry, I thought for sure you knew... all about this. Anyway..."

Jenna poured herself another drink in silence.

"Let me know if you want his number," she purred. "He is *totally* into geeky white women like you. Gotta go dance."

And just like that, her round bottom swinging, her hair everywhere, Jenna was gone.

CHAPTER 3

“What does that mean, ‘the lifestyle’?” Laura exclaimed, waving her hands in front of her in the cab.

She looked at Chris, who was so drunk he could do little more than smile. He had evidently forgotten how annoyed he had been when Laura had dragged him away from the party and insisted on going home.

“I think it means they’re swingers,” he repeated, for the fourth time.

“Swingers, swingers?!” Laura exclaimed. She was also good and drunk, but unlike Chris, she was agitated. She held her head, which was already starting to ache. “What does that *mean*? Swingers? That they just... have sex with whoever they want? How is that... how does that even work? I thought swingers were like, made-up, something from the seventies, they don’t even exist anymore.”

She was exasperated, because it was clear to her now that, even if she had really thought this, which she had, it had been a silly thought, because Chris had been totally unimpressed by this information, in spite of the fact that it had been new to him.

Laura looked at Chris again, and he shrugged, and shook his head.

God, he was too drunk, he probably wouldn’t remember any of this the next day and she would have to explain it all again.

She looked out her own window.

Swingers.

The image of Jenna with her “boyfriend,” or whoever he was, fell over her eyes like a curtain, and she shifted in her seat, that very uncomfortable feeling returning. Only now, she really couldn’t figure out what it was, not at all, because she was too drunk.

She looked over at Chris, and actually found herself regretting that he was too drunk to have sex with her. Her pussy throbbed; she could feel that her panties were damp. This confused her further: she was *scandalized* by what she had just found out. It made her uncomfortable, she wished, sincerely, that she didn’t know about it... and yet... her body seemed to be betraying some other feeling about it.

She sighed loudly, and brought her knuckles to her lips, trying hard to focus on the mailboxes and the streetlamps, and keep her thoughts within those familiar boundaries.

By the time the cab pulled into their driveway, Chris was asleep, and Laura knew she'd be lucky to get him into the house. His phone was buzzing intermittently in his pocket, and Laura was embarrassed as she patted him down for his wallet to pay the driver, then had to cajole him into getting out of the car. The driver, evidently believing none of this was his problem, stared ahead at the garage door and offered no help.

Thankfully, Chris managed to step out of the vehicle and sway up to the front door. Laura let him sit on the couch and hurried to the bathroom to pee, before creeping upstairs to see if the kids were okay.

They were on their tablets, staring into the blue screens. "Hey," she said. "We're home. Everything go okay?"

They grunted in reply.

She sighed and went back downstairs to cover Chris up with a blanket. Well, at least the kids didn't know how wasted they were. Chris was snoring softly. She nudged him, but he was down for the count.

Chris was like that: after he had about five drinks, he was fine until he sat down, at which time he would promptly – almost unbelievably – fall asleep.

She was restless. She poured a glass of water, and drank it staring at the liquor cabinet, contemplating having another Rum and Coke.

She slammed the water on the table, impatient with herself, and stomped into the living room. She was really very drunk, she realized, as the room spun almost as fast as her whirring of thoughts and her body began to do things she hadn't really thought through.

She took the phone out of Chris's shirt pocket.

There was a message from Rob. *Where did you go?*

A missed call, a number not programmed into the phone. She called it back, not really sure what it was she was hoping to hear, or not hoping to hear. A toneless voice recording told her that the number could not answer her call.

She went through his messages, not sure why she was doing it, or what she was looking for. She was frustrated, for whatever reason, that Rob

had sent only the one message. That Jenna had not called *her*, or texted *her*, to provide her with...

What?

More information? More details?

The phone number of the guy she was “dating?”

An explanation for her bad behavior?

Laura pushed her hair from her face and rolled her eyes at herself. In doing so she stumbled slightly and cracked her shin on the table. “God, whatever,” she said. Jenna didn’t owe her any explanations. Jenna could do whatever she wanted.

“*Whoever* she wants,” she said softly, aloud, continuing the conversation with herself.

She went back to the kitchen and made herself a drink, then took it upstairs and shut the bedroom door.

It was a bad idea, she thought. The Rum and Coke, the other bad ideas she was having. She pulled her own phone from her back pocket, where she had tucked it at some point in the evening. Nothing. Zilch.

She was really drunk, feeling very uneasy, and she opened her messages to Jenna and let her thumb hover over the letters. What did she want to say? What did she want to ask Jenna?

“Go to bed,” she told herself, but her thumb was swiping.

The first word was so unintelligible that auto-correct was mirthlessly without suggestions. She snorted and took another drink. “Oh, God,” she sang to herself. You really shouldn’t drink and text, she thought. It’s ALWAYS a bad idea.

Sorry I was so weird tonight

She managed to type, finally. Her stomach was cold, cold with the fear that she might send this text and regret it. Half of her mind – perhaps a half that was sober or smarter than the rest of it – was telling her to put the phone down. She was after something that she wouldn’t care about once she sobered up. She was unsettled by something that wouldn’t unsettle her tomorrow.

But her thumb had already sent the message. She stared at the text bubble, the permanence of what she had just done creeping through her.

It was just a lot to take in

She typed quickly.

Then:

omg i'm so drunk please ignore me

“Fuck,” she said, staring at her phone. Her vision was so blurry she saw two of them. She lay down on her stomach, and stared at the wall. And that was how she fell asleep.

*

“Man,” Chris said, pinching his nose. “That was a real bender. Sorry about that.”

He looked over at Laura when she didn’t say anything. She was staring at her phone. “You were pretty toasted, too, if I remember correctly,” he added, hoping to draw her into the conversation.

She looked up at him. She had something she wanted to say, and it was obvious on her face as it always was with Laura: she couldn’t hide her emotions at all.

“Are you still thinking about that?” he asked.

There was no need to define what “that” was.

“I just can’t *believe* it,” Laura said. “I mean, they seem like such... regular people. You know? I never would have thought.” She was shaking her head. Her arms were folded defensively across her chest.

Chris wasn’t sure how to take any of this.

Personally, he didn’t find it all that shocking. At least not the Jenna bit. He thought it was weird, probably hard to manage, and he didn’t really understand it. But it had failed to unsettle him as much as it obviously had Laura.

He was about to say something because she seemed to want him to, when she started up again. “You know she just *sees* that guy? Like, they go *out*?”

She looked at Chris, and because she seemed to want him to be scandalized, he made a face. But he could tell it was not the reaction she wanted because she frowned at him. “What? You think there’s nothing weird about that?” she snapped.

Chris brought his mug to his lips. “Why are you so worked up about this?” he asked before taking a sip. He swallowed, staring into the coffee. “It’s the perfect ending to that problem. Everyone is cool with it.”

“You know she asked me if I wanted his number?” Laura snapped back.

Now this – this had his attention. Quite suddenly, and completely. He wasn’t sure why. A warm sensation started agitating in his groin.

Logically, of course, he knew it to be a joke. Jenna’s idea of a joke, and she had many. And anyway, Laura was *not the type* – just look at her stewing.

The image of the black guy’s hand between Jenna’s legs resurfaced, and he leaned against the counter to get an idea of whether his suspicion that he was getting an erection was true or not.

“And I take it you don’t plan on taking her up on it?” he asked, swirling his coffee and looking up at Laura.

He had been expecting to catch her rolling her eyes, or scowling. What he caught, instead, was a moment’s hesitation – an unexpected nanosecond of an expression that was not revulsion, or eye-rolling, or irritation, or any of the reactions he would have expected his wife to have.

She shook it away with a blink. “Of course not,” she spat.

Just a tad... unconvincingly.

He stared at her.

Her cheeks flushed, because she had caught the same, unexpected hesitation in her own voice. “It’s so... I cannot even believe these people are the same people who we’ve been friends with all this time. I mean, I never thought for a *second*... did you?”

Chris held her gaze for a moment. “I don’t know,” he said casually. “Jenna *is* pretty...”

He made a meaningless circular gesture with his hand.

Laura chewed on her fingernail and stared at the floor.

“Honey,” Chris said. “This is like... not your problem. Okay? It’s not *a* problem. It’s just... people do different things. Right? They’re adults.”

“How do you think that *works*, though?” she said, plowing ahead. It was clear she wasn’t listening to him. “I mean, how do they not have problems because of it? I don’t see how they wouldn’t.”

Chris rubbed his face. “They have it worked out. I don’t know. Ask Jenna. Ask Rob.” His head was pounding.

Laura snapped her eyes up to his. “*You* think it’s crazy too, right? Like, you would never be into that sort of thing?”

There was a pause, just a little longer than he himself expected, before he said quickly:

“You know I wouldn’t. Don’t be silly.”

A silence.

A cloud descended on Laura’s face suddenly. “Wait,” she said, a sharp edge of accusation in her voice. “You didn’t *know* about this before, did you?”

Laura had this particularly irritating habit of being obsessed with other people being “in” on betrayal or secrets behind her back, to the point that she became quite a conspiracy theorist about it. It plucked a particular chord of irritation in Chris, because he had never been – and never intended to be – anything but honest with Laura. No matter how many pains he took to avoid this accusation resurfacing, it somehow always did.

“Laura, that’s really annoying,” he snapped, his voice irritated.

Laura’s face grew stormier. “What’s that supposed to mean?”

Chris held up his hands. “You know what? I don’t have time for this conspiracy shit. You know why it’s annoying? Because you were right there, across from me, when we saw Jenna at the restaurant. You know perfectly well I was just as shocked as you were.”

Laura’s expression lost its resolve.

“You always do this,” Chris continued. He was getting really fired up, and he couldn’t figure out how the conversation had become so contentious so quickly. Who even cared about this? It had nothing to do with *them*.

“Do what?” Laura shot back.

He threw his hands up in the air. “God! This. *This*. Start a fight about something that isn’t even... isn’t even *our fight*. There is no problem here. There is no conspiracy here. Your friends are swingers, it makes you uncomfortable, I don’t care, and somehow this has all come around on me, and you’re accusing me of lying to you about something -”

“I am not accusing you of -”

“- or keeping secrets, or whatever!”

They were practically yelling now. Chris snapped his mouth closed and folded up the paper he wasn't reading. Laura was flushed, and he felt a little bad for letting her get under his skin. There was an awkward silence for a few moments.

“I have to go to the grocery store,” Laura said abruptly. “Take an Ibuprofen.”

“I took a Tylenol.”

“You can take them both.”

Chris shrugged, and Laura snapped her purse from the counter and walked out.

*

Jenna had never written back to her. Laura stared at her text messages for the third time, parked in the grocery store lot.

What was bothering her so much about this?

She squinted into the sun.

There was an obvious answer, one she reached for because it was easy and it didn't make her nearly as uncomfortable as the less-obvious answer: she was upset that Chris didn't think much of Jenna and Rob's “lifestyle.”

This was easy, like a sugary drink: her husband *should* be upset that two people who were married were... doing whatever Jenna and Rob were doing. Husbands should not want other men to sleep with their wives. That went against everything marriage was supposed to be about, and not only that, it went against everything she'd ever believed about how men were “supposed” to feel about women. Wasn't he supposed to be possessive? Wasn't he supposed to *not* want other men touching his wife?

Chris shouldn't think it was no big deal. He definitely shouldn't imply that *he* would be interested in such a thing.

Laura stared at her phone again, for the umpteenth time.

That was an easy answer to the “why” of her unease.

But she knew it wasn't the real answer.

The real answer was complicated, and not something she felt like delving into. The real reason she was upset had to do with *her*; had to do with the fact that she saw a door opening to possibilities that she entertained for all the wrong reasons.

She put her phone away with a sigh of irritation for herself, dug her grocery bags out of the back of the car, and marched into the grocery store with a face set so rigidly upon power grocery shopping that she caused more than one person to move out of her way as she frowned at the state of the produce choices, like a woman about to come completely unhinged.

She wasn't going to go there.

*

Laura enjoyed playing out arguments with herself in the car while she was alone. Real ones, imaginary ones, ones there was only a twenty percent chance of having, arguments she'd already had and won but had not made the point as clearly as she wanted to. It was a bad habit, and she disliked this propensity in herself. Half the time, her intended audience didn't even care about the argument after she got past the first sentence.

But she enjoyed it in a very perverse way.

All the way home from the grocery store, she prepared herself for any argument with Chris. She wanted to defend her position that it was *wrong* to have extra-marital affairs, even if everyone knew about it. She wanted to explain to Chris why she'd gotten so upset: it bothered her that he wasn't upset about this stuff.

But, while arguing with "Chris" in her mind, she came around to the realization that the argument she was having was not with Chris at all: it was with herself.

She was trying to convince herself of all these points, when she didn't feel the way she thought she should.

She pulled into the garage, and, as often happened when she got her argumentation rocks off alone, she didn't feel as strongly as she had before she left.

Chris was in the bedroom they used as a home office, gym, and junk room, sorting through some papers and making sounds of irritation.

“Hey,” she said, and an apology was on the tip of her tongue. Deeper down inside of her, the desire to confess some of her secret thoughts was stirring. Or maybe lurking, cold and too large, moving inside of her like a slow beast.

Chris was on his knees and popped up from behind the untidy desk. “Have you seen a binder marked ‘Taxes, 2012?’ It’s red?”

“Uh... no. Why do you need it?”

“It has a paper I need for our mortgage refinance...” he was back at the bottom of the cheap IKEA bookshelf they shoved everything into.

“I’m sorry about this morning,” Laura said.

Chris didn’t answer. He probably didn’t hear her.

“Chris?” she asked, feeling the will to apologize fade, pressed down by the heel of daily life.

“Huh?” he asked. “I could have sworn it was... right.... You didn’t try to clean or something, here?”

Laura sighed.

The moment was gone.

“No,” she said. And then, to get out of the room: “I’m making some coffee. You want one?”

Chris didn’t answer. So she went back to the kitchen. The moment was lost, like so many other moments in their marriage.

*

Time went on. Weeks.

Laura couldn’t tell if anything was amiss from her interactions with Jenna at work. It was entirely possible – and normal – for them to go weeks without running into each other in the sprawling, one story office, a maze of cubicles and bland meeting rooms in neutral, corporate tones that unfolded over two suburban blocks of an industrial park.

Sometimes there would be a burst of activity or meetings, or chance encounters in the lunchroom, and Laura would see Jenna every day.

Two weeks passed with no Jenna sighting at all, and she started to feel like she should approach her and say *something*, though she didn’t know what, and she suspected she was just going to make things more awkward between them than they already were.

Chris thought Jenna wasn't thinking about any of this at all, and he didn't seem to be giving it that much thought, either. Laura wanted to press him to talk to Rob about it, but it didn't seem to be on his priority list the way it was for her.

She thought about it way, way too much. And the most annoying thing was that she couldn't decide *what* she was thinking about. She didn't want to judge her friends, but she suspected she probably was, she didn't want to be jealous, but she thought she might be, she didn't like the arousal that crept through her when her mind wandered too far from the rigid thoughts she wanted to have.

Sometimes, she even let herself go so far as to imagine that she and Chris had the same kind of relationship. That she was bouncy and sexy like Jenna, that men hit on her all the time, and that she could say to them that she'd love to go out on Saturday night...

Laura usually tried to stop herself right there. Thinking those kinds of things was not as bad as doing them, but she wouldn't want Chris thinking about other women that way. And she didn't want to betray him, or be a hypocrite.

Jenna came slinking toward her on a Tuesday, almost two weeks after the party. A sheer, nude wraparound dress clung to her and moved as though alive against her curves as she strode through the cluster of cubicles belonging to underwriting. A long red necklace was draped several times around her neck, and the pendant disappeared into her cleavage. High red heels completed her stunning outfit, and her hair, as always, was loose and wavy. No one moved as she strolled over to Laura's cubicle, but the energy in the office had changed, as it always did: everyone, male and female, was acutely aware of Jenna's presence.

She pushed aside a pile of folders and sat on Laura's desk, crossing her smooth legs and waving her red shoes in a sensual circle. "So, the boys are all going to some... dumb thing or another... sports!" she said, dismissing pleasantries as she always did. "And so, we're having a girls' night. It's on Friday. And I think..." she let the sentence hover, unfinished, in the air. Did Jenna always do this? It was like a teasing brush of the lips just before a kiss.

"...we should go dancing," she finished, with a raspy, suggestive tone that caused a ripple in the room.

“Um,” Laura said. “When... what? I mean, yeah, sure, that’s... okay with me. On... where?”

Jenna put her fingers to her neck and grinned at Laura. “What is *with you*? Yes, Friday, yes, dancing, at this new place downtown.”

Laura cleared her throat. There was nothing odd about this invitation, nothing odd about going dancing with Jenna – she’d done it before, for similar reasons. There was no reason for the insecurity that was clutching at her chest to be overtaking her.

“Uh... okay... where is it? What’s it called?”

“Studio.” Jenna had a twinkle in her eye. “I think... you’re going to really like it.”

Laura nodded. “Yeah, okay. Great. Sure.”

“Jenna. Oh. Hi. Uh...”

Pete Olsen, who was twenty-seven years old, had appeared as though from nowhere to stand inside Laura’s cubicle with a pile of folders in his left hand.

Jenna leaned back on the desk and extended a foot toward Pete, without touching him. “Petie,” she growled. “How’s Trix?”

Laura spun slightly in her chair. Pete, like any guy in a two-mile radius of Jenna, had a stupid look on his face.

It occurred to Laura that this had always been the case with Jenna, but there was a very sinister aspect to it now that she knew what she knew. Her eyes fell on Jenna’s seductively twisting ankle, her sexy red heel, the proximity of Jenna’s foot to Pete’s crotch, the... suggestiveness of it all.

“Pete. What?” Laura said dryly. She took the folders out of his hand. “Are these them?”

“Yeah. Just, uh, run them back when you’re done,” Pete said vaguely.

Jenna smiled at him as he left.

“He’s pretty cute,” she said, tipping her head to one side.

Laura whipped her head around. “He’s... twenty-seven!” she exclaimed.

Jenna grinned. “Okay, ma.” She leaned over. “He’s not my type, anyway,” she said, her eyes twinkling. “Okay. I have to get back, just out for a stroll, it is *brutal* boring over there right now.”

And she sauntered away.

Had Jenna always been like this? Laura wondered. She had always been the office's sexiest woman. It was in her nature to be flirtatious. It had never seemed so... *real* before. But now, knowing that Jenna actually acted on her impulses if she wanted to, Laura felt a peculiar nervousness around her. In some ways she wanted to avoid her now, avoid the dangerous feelings that Jenna inspired.

And in some ways, she felt the same kind of flutter in her stomach as when she was much, much younger, the kind of excited, anguished drop that came with seeing a boy she had a crush on. It had been a long time since she had felt anything like that.

And now she didn't know if she hated it or loved it.

CHAPTER 4

It wasn't a lie that Chris hardly ever got the chance to talk to Rob during the day. At least not to have the kind of conversation that Laura seemed to want him to have, about the details of Rob's sex life, or "lifestyle," as Laura kept insisting that he call it.

He *hadn't* been all that interested in the particulars at the beginning. The news that Rob and the overflowing, flowy-haired, sexual, sensual Jenna were up to something a little different in their marriage hadn't surprised him in the least, and the fact that the "something" was sexual had surprised him even less.

But his interest had been piqued because *Laura* seemed so unable to let it go. Ever since she'd seen Jenna in the restaurant, there had been a noticeable change in Laura's behavior. There was the wild night at the hotel, of course. But she was always *thinking* these days, daydreaming, off in her own world about something.

Or maybe he was just paying more attention.

Either way, Laura's obvious discomfort, interest, revulsion, attraction – whatever it was – to the subject had gotten him to thinking about it a lot more than he had at the beginning. There was just never any chance to sit down with Rob, and Rob alone, to talk about it.

And Laura was acting *weird* about Friday night, which should have just been like any other game night, but was quickly turning into some kind of big deal. The girls were going out dancing – nothing new about that – but now that they knew about Jenna and Rob, it seemed a little...well, *dangerous*.

It had been so long since he'd had the prickly breath of jealousy on his neck that he'd almost forgotten what it felt like. How long had it been? Laura was just so tightly wrapped, so conservative, so uptight and non-flirtatious, so awkward in the way she dressed, that most guys didn't really react to her in a way that made him worry. Sure, guys were always up for *anything* with *any* woman, at the end of the day, but if guys made passes at Laura, it usually went right over her head.

When she'd gone dancing with Jenna before, he'd always envisioned it as Laura (maybe) dancing awkwardly in something kind of frumpy, while Jenna's magnetic, sexual powers drew all the attention to herself, and then they went home. It had all felt very safe and boring, but now it had an *edge*.

He kind of liked it. A feeling of danger, a sense that Jenna might draw more attention than only she could handle, the idea that Laura might flirt with someone or find herself in a compromising position because Jenna was, actually, free to do whatever she wanted. He liked that his wife seemed to be thinking about that very idea herself, secretly, maybe waking up to some possibility she'd buried long ago.

"You cool?" Rob said, taking a swig of his beer, eyes on the court. "Fuck!" he said, to the game.

Chris didn't answer.

Rob looked at him. He knew what was on Chris's mind, and that was evident on his face.

Chris coughed, leaned forward, and stared into his beer.

"Come on guys!" Rob yelled. "Ref, what the fuck?"

Chris waited, building up the courage to take the plunge. This was a weird conversation to be having; he didn't even know what he wanted to ask.

"So, look man... I – this is more because Laura wants to know, than anything. But... what's the deal with you guys?"

Rob grinned at him. "What, me and Jenna?"

Chris took a sip of his beer. "Yeah."

But Rob was already talking. "You thinking of trying it out? Laura is some little number, that'd be pretty hot."

"What? No... no... just, well, I mean, first of all, Laura is so not into that -"

"You sure? Because she seems pretty interested in it to me. Or at least that's what Jenna says."

Chris took an uncomfortable sip of his beer. Then he laughed, more theatrically than he wanted to. Rob's comment was burrowing deep in his psyche, mostly because it seemed to him that Laura *was* pretty interested in whatever it was that Rob and Jenna had going on here. "No way," he said, trying as much to convince himself as he was Rob. "If she's... it's more of

an intellectual exercise for her I think. She just... wants to know, like, how it works.”

Rob clapped his hand on Chris’s back. “It works like it works, man. Jenna fucks other guys, and sometimes she lets me watch, and it’s hot as fuck.”

Chris tipped his beer too hard and let some of it spill over his mouth. “Wait... but you, like, you also -”

Rob shrugged, and opened his mouth to say something. A bad call had him on his feet screaming at the ref before he got around to it.

He sat back down. “Where’d they get this guy?”

Chris waited, looking expectantly at Rob.

“Look, buddy. It works for us, okay? You know how, when you first met Laura, you weren’t 100% sure if you were gonna score with her or not? And it was kind of like a hunt, that feeling it gave you? *That’s* what’s missing after you’ve been married for so long, right? So Jenna hooking up with other guys, it’s to keep that feeling going.”

Chris made a face. “Aren’t you worried? That she’ll fall for some other guy, or... man, I don’t know. Seems really... risky.”

Rob had his eyes on the court, and for a moment he seemed to have forgotten about the topic. “Get the fuck...” he murmured, in response to the game. “It’s like an adrenaline rush. You know? What’s more fun, skydiving or bouncing on a trampoline?”

To be honest, Chris did not get a kick out of either of those things, but he could see Rob’s point – especially for a guy like Rob, who lived for adrenaline. He shook his head. “Laura would never be into anything like that, anyway,” he said, quietly enough that he wasn’t sure Rob heard him.

Rob was on his feet again, screaming at the ref. Chris stared at the moving players and thought only of Laura, out with Jenna, “interested” in swinging as an intellectual exercise.

“Man,” Rob said, out of nowhere. “You may be right. But girls like Laura,” he tipped his beer cup in Chris’s direction, with a wink, as though they shared some secret information between the two of them. “Better watch out for that. It’s always the ones you least suspect.”

The crowd erupted in a standing cheer as the home team scored. Chris could not bring himself to stand. Mike and Trey, more Rob’s buddies than Chris’s, were on their way back from the concessions stand, yelling loudly

in their excitement. No one paid him any attention as he stared, slack-jawed, into the crowd.

The last ones you suspect of *what?* he wanted to yell.

Rob's words were churning in his mind: *Jenna fucks other guys, and sometimes she lets me watch...*

and sometimes she lets me watch...

and sometimes she lets me watch...

The image of the dark hand between Jenna's legs surfaced in Chris's mind again. This time, to his horror, instead of Jenna, it was Laura, staring right at him, her features painted, her eyes fixed in an almost triumphant stare, the man's fingers edging closer and closer to her pussy as the corners of her mouth turned up in a defiant smile.

Even more horrifying, he was so turned on by the image, he had an erection.

"Here's your beer, man," Mike yelled. He scanned Chris's face. "Yo, you all right?"

Chris took the beer and nodded. "Just tired."

But Mike was already yelling toward the court about another bad call.

He wanted to talk to Rob some more, but at the same time, the conversation was awkward. How do you ask a guy for details about his wife's extramarital affairs?

Instead, he looked out onto the court, seeing almost nothing, while his mind churned away, recycling the same two ideas: the image of Jenna (sometimes Laura) with a man's hand between her legs, and Rob's voice, repeating over and over:

...sometimes she lets me watch.

*

"I guess it's just us," Jenna said, swiping a message on her phone. She dropped it into her purse and pressed her watermelon-glossy lips together as she flung her hair over her shoulder. "Oh well. More for us."

Laura was profoundly uncomfortable. She had let Jenna talk her into wearing a skin-tight black dress, which was not overly short or overly revealing on her (it was scandalous on Jenna's curvy frame, but long on Laura's thinner one). She was wearing heels, which she rarely did, so she

towered over most of the women in line. Her hair was down, straightened, and driving her crazy by falling into her eyes at every turn. She had no idea how Jenna put up with this all day.

Jenna herself was looking sexier than ever in a white halter dress, barely suspended by fragile spaghetti straps that promised to – but never did – break, and reveal what was beneath the shimmering gauze-thin material. Her thoroughbred legs looked miles long in the white, satin-covered platform heels on her feet.

Jenna had also talked her into a shade of red lipstick that made her feel like her mouth was a railroad crossing in the middle of nowhere: blinking, blinking, the only thing to look at. She also had a *ton* of black mascara on, and it clouded her mind with the persistent worry that it was smudged.

The evening, so far, had gone nothing like their usual “girls’ nights,” which had usually consisted of Jenna and Laura drinking margaritas at Dos Rios, waiters smiling at Jenna, and then an Uber home. Wild. Twice they had gone dancing, but at a place called Charlie Brown’s, where the dance floor was more about nostalgic dancing for married women who wanted to dance like no one was watching, because nobody really was.

Instead, Jenna had made drinks at her house and decided to give Laura a makeover, because Studio was not a club where no one was watching. The drinks had been hard, Jenna had lit up a joint, and now Laura was freezing in a small dress and high heels downtown, and it was almost midnight.

There was also the matter that *everyone* in line was about ten years younger than them: glittery and fresh-faced, and definitely not the kind of people who had to be home by twelve for a babysitter. The scent of pot hung heavy in the air, everyone was in a good mood and full of robust, young, flirtatious energy.

Jenna lit a cigarette and tipped her head back to let the smoke float up into the cool night air. Laura stared at her. “I didn’t know you smoked. Cigarettes,” she said.

Jenna smiled and leaned forward to whisper in her ear. “I just do it to piss off all these little i-Gen twats,” she whispered, and then blew a cloud of smoke into the hair of a girl in front of her.

“Hey, hey, hey, baby,” a smooth voice said behind them. Jenna’s face broke into a wild smile, and very suddenly, she was embracing, in turn, three very tall, very good-looking guys. Two of whom were black, Laura noted, and then felt immediately bad for noticing it (because at the same time she “noted” this, the image of Jenna’s date with his hand between her legs surfaced in her mind).

“Where’s Tony?” Jenna squealed. She let her right hand, with its lit cigarette, fall to rest on Laura’s shoulder.

One of the guys had already turned to Laura, and his eyes were traveling up and down her body.

It had been a long, long time since any man had given Laura that brazen of an eye-walkover. She could actually feel his gaze as it traveled over her body, and when he sucked his lower lip in what seemed like approval, a wave of heat flushed over her cheeks, and right at the bottom of her abdomen.

An intrusive, unbidden thought flashed through her mind, of a large black cock, and her cheeks reddened to the point that she knew the guy could see it. Her eyes felt like loose doll’s eyes, she had no idea where to put them, so she smiled a ridiculous smile and looked at her feet.

She could still feel him looking at her, though. Jesus, *so aggressively*.

“Who’s this little hottie?” she could hear him saying.

Jenna’s laugh rumbled through a steady roar in Laura’s ears. Her stomach was twisting uncomfortably.

“This here is Laura.”

Her hand was being lifted by something muscled and warm, and Laura’s eyes drifted down to her fingers to watch them as they rose in the air, suspended by a large, strong black hand. Another wave of heat rippled over her burning face as she refocused her eyes beyond her hand, on the intense brown eyes that were looking right into hers, then the puffy, cherry-purple lips that were nearing her hand.

Hot, dry, and soft, his mouth was on her fingertips, and the sensation traveled right down her arm and straight into her pussy, where it reverberated in her hard clit.

She had stopped breathing.

“Enchanté,” he had said, but Laura was spinning too wildly in outer space to decipher what that meant. She was burning with shame for acting

like a total idiot, for wanting desperately to drop her hand and let it brush over his package, for the way her hand seemed to be connected to her pussy by a coiled string that only this guy could pluck, and for thinking – this was the worst by far – about black cock like a... racist, crazy... what was she doing?!!!

She was married for Christ sake.

“Why don’t you lovely ladies pop inside with us?”

“Ooooh,” Jenna said, putting her hand against the other black guy’s chest. The first guy still had Laura’s hand in his, and his thumb was making a little circle on the back of her hand, and he could have actually had his thumb on the face of her clit for the way it was stirring her up. “You guys are on the list?” Jenna cooed.

“We’re on the list,” the man who held Laura’s hand rumbled. His voice was so low she felt it rather than heard it. His eyes were on hers and she looked away, unable to take the intensity. She wanted to move her hand, wanted a second to press pause and get herself together – she was acting like a twitterpated, unmarried teenager or something – but she couldn’t seem to summon the strength to do any of that.

He gave a jerk of the head, and at last her hand was released, the spell broken, the touch of his hand and the heat of his gaze turning away from her. Her mouth was open, her pussy throbbing, her stomach a bed of knots.

Jenna linked her arm in hers. “See, I told you you’d like it,” she said, as they stepped out of the line, over a red velvet chain, and walked toward the door.

A voice in Laura’s head was screaming: *time to go home*.

But her feet kept walking her toward the entrance.

*

The club was dark and sexy, full of people writhing like fish in a barrel and just as close to each other. Jenna put her fingers in the small of Laura’s back and pushed her through the crowd behind whoever-he-was, and soon Laura was covered in a sheen of sweat and slipping between hot-bodied, good-looking people who were also damp.

The floor opened up, Mr Enchanté looked back at her and sent another lava-like roll of heat downward in her abdomen, and she followed

him, up some steps and into a smaller, quieter area with a low table and wide white leather couches bathed in blue light.

Jenna was still pushing her or she would have been unable to walk. She looked behind her to see Jenna leaning back against the white guy, her arm slung up around his neck, her mouth dangerously close to his lips.

Laura looked away quickly.

Enchanté was smiling at her, taking her hand again, leading her to a couch.

She needed to get out of here.

The idea filled her head as though someone had set off a fire alarm. She shouldn't have even come in here, but now she definitely needed to leave. Things felt way, way out of control, and Jenna was clearly not going to be of any help in drawing some kind of line with these guys.

She was sitting down anyway, because she didn't know how to get out. Her thigh was against his thigh; she could feel the expensive material of his suit and the hard muscle underneath it.

Really, really hard muscle -

REALLY? She screamed at herself.

Okay, she thought, smiling blandly and tucking her hair behind her ear. She would just excuse herself, go to the bathroom... there she would... do what?

Call an Uber.

Go home.

She looked desperately at Jenna, who was smiling at her and taking a glass of what looked like champagne from a tray that had magically appeared, along with a waitress, right next to them. She beckoned Laura with a finger to lean in close to her.

Mr. Enchanté slid his arm behind Laura at that moment, and his iron-hard forearm slid over Laura's shoulder blades, making her face hot as she leaned gratefully toward Jenna.

"I know these guys from Tony, you know, my date? They get in *everywhere*, we're so lucky we ran into them." She leaned in to yell-whisper in Laura's ear. "They pay for *everything*, we're going to have so much fun tonight."

"Jenna," Laura said, but her voice was swallowed up by a sudden blast of music and a shriek of laughter next to them.

“Jenna!” Laura repeated.

Jenna leaned back in toward Laura, and Laura could tell by the expression on her face that Jenna was not going to take any objections to what they were doing seriously. “I think Jay here really likes you,” she said, winking.

And then she turned her attention back to the white guy, leaving Laura stranded on the edge of the couch, heart pounding, certain she should go home.

Like, yesterday.

Her eyes drifted to her right, where Jay’s enormous thighs were hanging off the couch, spread open in that very dominating, space-consuming way some guys sit. He had leaned forward, elbows on knees, but had his head turned to the waitress, hands together, fingers extended while he gave her instructions.

Another series of thoughts – all of them so primordial Laura could hardly believe they were in her head: size, muscle, dark skin, phallic images, percolating curiosity about what thighs that large and hard would feel like under her own thighs -

She closed her eyes.

When she opened them, Jay was looking at her. He wet his lips, leaned close to her ear, holding her captive with his eyes, and rumbled:

“What you want to drink, little thing?”

Laura was unable to speak. Half of her mind raced ahead, imagining herself doing the right thing at that moment: telling Jay she had to get home, thanking them for a good time, pushing her way out through the hot, slippery bodies in the club, getting into an Uber and going home, then *never* going out with Jenna again...

But the other part of her brain, and apparently the part that had control of her right now, moved her mouth:

“Uh, Rum and Coke.”

Jay seemed amused by this, but turned to the waitress to evidently order it, while Laura clutched her purse and overheated in her shrug and tried desperately to will herself to get out of this situation.

Whatever it was.

“I got you something else I think you’ll like,” Jay was growling in her ear.

Laura had reached out for Jenna's knee, but Jenna was too busy listening to something that the white guy was telling her which was evidently making her laugh spectacularly. Jenna held up a finger and turned her attention back to her man, who was not-so-casually stroking her knee.

"So how you know Jenna?" Jay said. The music died down suddenly just before he spoke, almost as though he had willed it to.

Laura could feel herself almost shaking. Jay was looking at her so intensely, and she could hardly believe it because he was looking at her *hungrily*. For some reason the words stuck in her mouth, and she was hesitant to say them – hesitant, she realized, with no end of guilt, to put an end to Jay's attention by saying the words "my husband" out loud.

"She's...we... we work together," Laura said. And then, guilt rushing in like water to a sinking ship, she added, clumsily, "she's, also...we, my, our husbands work together, too, they're...we're all really... good. Friends."

God, she was an idiot. But there it was, on the table, now he knew she was married and he would hopefully...

But Jay smiled, his gaze unwavering, still searing right through her with its lust. "Oh, yeah," he said. "Y'all *real* good friends, then?"

He had his fingers on her fingers, and she hadn't even noticed them moving toward her. She could feel the pads of his fingertips rolling around on her ring finger.

Rolling her wedding ring right around her finger?

"Oh!" she almost shouted, and whipped her head to Jenna to look for help. "Oh, no, yeah, not like... no, not like that."

She dropped her eyes to her ring finger. The sensual rolling of her ring in his fingers had moved through her hand just like his kiss, and even though she was absolutely scandalized by it, it had made her pussy well up and overflow. She was throbbing when she pulled her hand away and balled it into a fist. Her breath caught in her throat. "Not, um... not like that," she said again.

Jay smiled. "Gotcha."

Jenna was leaning toward him now. "Go easy on her, Jay, we're really just out for a girls' night," she said. She shook her head at Jay, meeting his eyes.

Jay smiled again and sucked on his lower lip, a superior grin on his face. He folded his hands together. "I see, that's cool," he said. But his face

indicated that he saw something quite different.

“*Really*,” Laura squeaked for emphasis, but she felt sure no one could hear her over the music.

She got the sense that Jenna and Jay were communicating something that was about her, and over her head. This was the kind of thing that would normally have angered her. It made her uncomfortable but she could feel, lurking around somewhere inside of her, that she was excited by it as well. It was almost as if there were some red line out there somewhere, and she was getting her kicks stepping a little closer to it, and then a little more.

She should know where that red line was, she thought guiltily. She should get that straight with herself right away. Was she already there? Would Chris want her doing what she was doing right now? Sitting in VIP section with a great-looking guy very obviously hitting on her, with Jenna, the... well, *swinger*...?

She took her Rum and Coke and brought it to her lips. She wasn’t *doing* anything, though. She was just sitting here, hanging out with Jenna and some of her friends, having some drinks. She didn’t have any intention of doing anything else.

And she would *not*.

Jay’s fingers were inexplicably brushing over hers, taking the Rum and Coke from her hands.

“You always drink Rum and Coke?” he asked her.

Laura could feel her face getting hot, and her hands fluttered to her neck. The inclination to burst out laughing was stinging at the back of her throat, and her eyes were watering with the effort to keep it back. She covered her eyes with her hand.

Laura was mortified by this aspect of her personality. She coughed. “I...no, well, yeah, it’s like...” she put her hands at her side and shook them rapidly, nervously, like a bird, before she even realized what she was doing. “I just... I don’t drink a lot and I don’t really know what else to order.”

Jay’s smile was widening.

“So... I mean, I don’t even really like Run and Coke.”

Jay lifted his head and bared his white teeth in an expression of delight, slapping his hands on his knees. Laura brushed her hair from her face. And chewed on her thumb.

“Yo, Jenna, where did you get this girl from?” he yelled at Jenna, placing his hand on her knee. Laura stared at the sizable, wiry fingers gently massaging Jenna’s white skin, and a pang of lust traveled through her.

Jenna smiled at her, then slapped Jay playfully. “I know,” she said. “She’s like a hot librarian or something.”

Jay sucked on his lip and leaned on his knees, hands together again. His eyes traveled over Laura’s body, and she adjusted her hair again, almost helplessly. “That’s what it is,” Jay said. “That’s too much. Hot librarian, here you go, I’m gonna have you try this drink,” he leaned backward to pick up a glass of dark, red-tinted liquid on ice, with an orange swizzle hanging from the side.

“Uh...” Laura said.

“Don’t worry, it’s sweet, not too strong, you’ll like it.”

Laura took the drink, and held it up to inspect the color, prompting Jay to laugh.

“It ain’t gonna kill you,” he said. “Just try it.”

So she did. It was sweet, with more layers of flavor to it, and she liked it. “It’s good,” she said, smiling.

“It’s a Negroni,” Jay said. “Order that shit instead of these Rum and Cokes, girl, Jesus, it’s not 1984 anymore.” He clinked his own glass to hers, letting her know that he was joking kindly, but Laura blushed anyway.

“Dance,” Jenna said loudly from her right. She was standing up, putting her hand on Laura’s shoulder.

Laura shook her head. “Oh no, I’m...” she held her drink up.

“Slam it,” Jenna told her.

“Take it easy, librarian here is tryin’ to enjoy her drink,” Jay said. “Just stay here with me, little lady,” he told Laura.

Maybe this was the red line, Laura thought. Jay’s thigh was pressing against hers again, and his arm was slung behind her on the couch. He wasn’t giving the impression that this was as far as he intended to go, as far as physical contact went.

Laura took a sip of her drink, buying herself some time. What the fuck was she doing? She didn’t really want to get on the dance floor with Jenna, because she could see that things were going to get quite a bit closer than was wholly appropriate. And she didn’t think sitting on the couch with Jay was wholly appropriate, either.

The most appropriate thing to do, she well knew, was to go home.

The back of her throat burned pleasantly with the drink Jay had ordered. The music got louder.

Somehow, while she was buying herself time by drinking, everyone had become distracted, and Jenna was laughing and falling back onto the couch on the lap of the white guy. “You didn’t *say* that?” she was yelling.

Laura looked at Jay, who smiled and shrugged, and sent another wave of heat through Laura’s torso.

She could just finish her drink, couldn’t she? Maybe stay half an hour longer, then make an excuse, maybe say that Chris was calling her, that there was something she had to do at home... and she could go.

But it wouldn’t hurt to stay just a little longer, right?

After all... she hadn’t done anything terrible.

The only person who knew what she was thinking – and boy, was she thinking some pretty racy things – was her.

The beat of the music was building up, everyone was laughing, she felt hot and young and alive for once, and the burn of the drink was traveling through her whole body.

If Chris had really been worried about it, he never would have let her go out with Jenna. He would have said something besides “have fun,” when she had called to tell him they weren’t even out yet at eleven.

Laura relaxed back into the couch. Another young, good-looking guy was slapping Jay’s hand in some kind of elaborate handshake, looking sideways at her. “Hey, this is Laura, she’s a hot librarian,” Jay said. “This is Troy.”

Laura, for whatever reason, held her fist out, and Troy laughed appreciatively as he fist-bumped her. Wow. She was being funny. She was getting a high out of all of this excitement. How long had it been since anyone had flirted with her, or she had even talked to a guy she hadn’t known for five years already? Why was it so enticing?

Jay leaned over to her, and his lips were just a hair-width away from her ear as he growled against her lobe, setting the hairs of her neck deliciously on end. “Troy has a librarian fantasy, so don’t get too close to him.”

And then a smile for Jenna, and his hand dropped against her shoulder blade, and he turned back to her. The heat of his fingers on her shoulder

radiated down her arm, joining all the other “innocent” times he’d touched her in a collective, liquid pool in her belly. “Don’t worry, I’ll protect you from these perverts.”

He was handing her another drink, and Laura was thinking about how far over the line she was suddenly, but she was smiling, and her body felt like cement in one way – she couldn’t move – and light as a feather – she was floating outside of it – all at the same time.

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How many more drinks did she have? What did they even talk about? Who suggested that they get out on the dancefloor?

Probably Jenna.

In fact, it *had* been Jenna, because Laura distinctly remembered going to the ladies’ room with Jenna and sitting on a round, red couch in the middle of the bathroom while they waited for a stall. She remembered fingering her phone with her hand in her purse, watching a couple of girls rubbing their noses as they came out of the stalls laughing, and Jenna talking about how big Jay’s cock was in her left ear. She remembered thinking then, as she had already thought hundreds of times, that she really, really needed to go home, that she was in over her head, and that Chris would have a fit if he knew what she was doing.

Then they were out on the dance floor, just her and Jenna, and it was fun, like it always was. She was sweating, the music was weird but good, Jenna’s enormous smile was flashing in front of her, her hair was slapping against her back, wet with sweat.

When did the guys get there? It was hard to know. Images of Jenna between two guys, dark arms against her midriff, hands on the back of her white dress, fingers snaking under her shirt.

A firm, muscled chest against her own back. Hands on her own hips, on her waist, moving up. She squirmed away, but Jay came back, again and again, and there were times when she fell into dancing with him, her bottom against his pelvis, his arms around her arms, his hands in... not *purely appropriate* places.

She had turned to him and shouted in his ear. “Hey! Don’t forget, I’m married.”

And he had smiled. "I'm not."

With a grin that was more devious than anything else, which should have sent her running, but instead intrigued her, warmed her on the inside like another drink.

She pushed his hands away so that he never got to placing them right on her breasts – at least, as far as she could remember. She was sure that she had felt the outline of his cock against her back. She had a memory of Jenna yelling something at him, something to do with her and him fishing in some other waters, right before Jenna had pulled her into the bathroom again.

She had tried to call for an Uber, and found it incredibly hard. Jenna had laughed and slapped the phone out of her hand and told her she'd get them home in about five minutes.

The party had kept going from there, back out on the dance floor, and then the club was closing down. They were still drinking in the VIP lounge, Jay had his hand on her knee, Jenna was making out with a guy who seemed completely new to the scene.

And it had hit her all at once: she had gone past the red line, way, way past it, and things were about to go very wrong.

"Jenna," she said sharply. "I gotta go home."

Jay looked at her imploringly. "We were just gonna go to the after-party... Troy has a nice place with a hot tub."

"I'm married," Laura repeated. "I have to... seriously, I have to go. Jenna!"

She stood up, and Jenna let her head fall back to groan lightly. Her legs were crossed and she was sitting on the guy's lap, her hands up his shirt. "Guys," she said. "I gotta get this girl home."

There were protests, more talking, stumbling to the door, Jenna laughing and dropping a glass, cigarettes outside in the cold, Jenna making out again, Jay tugging gently at her hand, Jay holding her inside of a coat while they waited for their car, and finally, finally, the two of them slammed the doors shut and the silence of the Uber enclosed them.

Laura exhaled.

"Jesus, those guys are hot," Jenna exclaimed, after giving her address. "You sure you don't want to -"

"I gotta go home," Laura said firmly. Her vision was blurry and she could feel guilt coursing through her with every beat of her heart. She

looked at her phone. “Jesus, it’s four o’clock,” she said.

She didn’t know how she managed to give her address to the driver, or what she said to Jenna when she got out of the car. She remembered her head lolling to one side on the back of the seat, and saying, “I feel bad.” She had been talking about feeling guilty, for flirting, or letting Jay flirt with her, and touch her shoulder, and grind with her on the dance floor – and for liking it, even if no one would ever know that.

Jenna snorted. “I had about ten drinks too many,” she agreed, obviously having the single regret of drinking too much.

She was relieved when she closed the door behind her, and the darkness of her own home swirled around her.

“Never,” she whispered, stumbling as quietly as she could to the downstairs bathroom. “Again.”

When she got upstairs, Chris was asleep, the phone in his hand. Laura wiggled out of her clothes, wiping whatever was left of the lipstick off with the inside of the dress, and crept quietly into bed.

When she closed her eyes the room spun.

Nothing had happened that she had to worry about, she thought.

The only really bad things had taken place inside of her own mind.

She looked over at Chris, who appeared in triplicate through her drunken haze.

What would she tell him? Did she have to tell him anything? It wasn’t like she had done anything but dance a little close to Jay, and stay out a little late.

And one thing was for sure: she would never, ever, go out to a club with Jenna again.

CHAPTER 5

Laura was in bed next to him when he woke up at seven. What was it about getting older that made it impossible to sleep more than five hours in a row?

Laura's arm was strung up over her head, her hair messy and smelling faintly of smoke. The scent of sweet alcohol rose from her skin: not boozy like a man, but citrusy like she had just spilled it on herself. Her eyes were dark with smeared mascara, and her lips were cherry red, with a streak of red on her upper lip.

Wow. He lifted her hair and kissed her on the ear, but she didn't stir.

A pang of irritated jealousy gripped him briefly, and then he let it go, deliberately, and with some difficulty. Laura had every right to go out and have a wild night. She hadn't done that in ten years, and he should have known, when she had called him at eleven, that it was going to be a late one.

He peered over her slender curves, unable to stop himself from tracing the edge of her black underwear with his fingertips along her hip bone. A skimpy piece of black fabric was heaped on the floor.

He moved his fingers up her torso, getting the idea that possibly he could awaken her with some frisky business, but she growled at him and flipped onto her stomach, turning her head away.

Probably best to try again later, he decided.

Downstairs, the door was slightly ajar – she had tried to shut it with the deadbolt still open.

Her shoes were strewn along with a shrug, on the living room floor, along with her keys (at least she had taken them out of the door), and some other random items from her purse, which had made it to the kitchen.

He put things away and made coffee, grappling with the annoyance he felt.

He reminded himself that he had gone out with the guys and come home pretty late once or twice, and had lost his keys and had to wake Laura up by calling the landline repeatedly, because he had forgotten his keys.

But this seemed different to him, somehow.

Maybe because of Jenna, who didn't seem as trustworthy of a person for his wife to be out with anymore. He wondered what time they had gotten home. It had to have been after two-thirty, because that was the last time he remembered looking at his phone.

He gave Laura, who was not a sound sleeper most of the time, a little shake, but she didn't stir. He smelled alcohol, a faint residue of cigarettes. A sort of red-hot fury built up inside of him, but he tamped it down. His wife was a grown woman. She was entitled to be in a bar and have some drinks occasionally.

He headed to the kitchen, determined to master the espresso machine. Laura usually made the coffee, something about the machine annoyed him. It was too complicated.

"Dad?" a voice interrupted, just as Chris was fiddling with the machine. "Mom said she'd drive us to Mitchell's?"

He turned to see Chris Jr. leaning against the door.

"Uh..." he said. "Yeah, okay, I'll take you, she's feeling a little-"

Liam appeared in the doorway and laughed, the kind of careless, adolescent, laugh that boys his age were so fond of. "Hungover?" he asked. He reached across Chris Jr. to grab something out of the bag Chris was holding. "I went to bed before mom."

Chris looked at them, wanting very much to ask what time that would have been and investigate some more, but opting instead to keep the kids out of... whatever this was.

"Got your stuff?" he said, almost too cheerfully. "I'll take you now."

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Laura was up when he got back, sitting at the kitchen table with her head resting on her arm.

"That bad, huh?" he asked, as she sat up to smile at him.

"I'm never going out with Jenna again," Laura said, and it sounded surprisingly less like a complaint about drinking too much and more like a serious declaration. "You took the boys? Thanks. I totally forgot about it."

He raised his eyebrows. "What time did you get home?"

Laura looked down at her coffee mug, and flickers of the same unreasonable, hot jealousy he had felt earlier that morning ignited again.

But the sensation was almost pleasurable. He moved closer to Laura, pressing in on her, almost wishing...

...what? That she would have something to say to justify his jealousy? It was almost as if he were hoping he had caught her at something.

"I think it was like, four," Laura said quietly. "But it's not even *that*."

That same image, of Jenna's white legs with another man's hand between them, and an almost sing-song memory of Rob's voice – *sometimes she lets me watch* – started to percolate again in Chris's mind. He pulled out a chair and sat down.

Laura was tapping the handle of her mug with her long thumbnail. She liked to keep her nails tidy and short, but for some reason her thumbnail grew faster than all the others, so it was occasionally quite long. She made a face, pulling back her lips and grimacing so that her nose was scrunched up. "It's... Jenna is like, way out of control," she said. "Now that I know about... you know... she's like, I don't know, a completely different person."

Chris leaned his head on his hand. "Like what?"

Laura rubbed her face. "Like... I don't know, we went to this club downtown, and everyone there was *really* young, and there were like, all these guys, and we sat in the VIP section, and Jenna was making out with one of them, and..."

She still had her face behind her fingers. She was rubbing her temples with her fingertips.

"VIP lounge, huh?" Chris said, suspiciously. This was getting under his skin, but he wasn't sure exactly in what *way* it was getting under his skin.

Laura didn't say anything.

"So what did *you* do in the VIP lounge, while Jenna was making out with this guy?"

Laura paused for just a little too long, and then she folded her arms over each other in front of her, as carefully and slowly as though she were handling museum pieces. "Uh, I mean... nothing really, but that's kind of the thing. It was... really, *really*, uncomfortable."

She was looking at the tops of her arms.

Chris's interest was piqued; he leaned forward, wanting to extract more detail from his wife, oddly aroused, excited by the prospect that there

was something more to her story than just “discomfort.”

“So, what, you were just sitting there, watching Jenna make out, uncomfortable? Or what? What were you doing?”

Laura lifted her head and looked at the ceiling. Then she looked back at her arms. “No, that’s it, you know, there were all these guys, and this one guy was sitting there next to me, and not like, *hitting*- hitting on me, because I told him I was married and not... you know, not like Jenna. But, um... I don’t know, it was a little bit awkward.”

Chris raised his eyebrows again and looked at Laura until she lifted her eyes. She couldn’t hold his gaze.

Huh, he thought. Interesting. Was he imagining things, or was Laura hiding something?

“That’s it? You hung out with some guys?”

Laura shrugged. Then she put her hands up to her face, palms together, making a wedge toward her nose. She exhaled. “Okay,” she said, and his stomach twisted because she sounded like she was about to make a really profound confession. “I think... I got pretty loaded, and I didn’t really know how to get out of that situation, and I guess, I made some bad choices.”

Chris’s heart was beating faster. “Bad choices like what?” he asked, probing his wife with his eyes. She was staring at her fingertips, which would have been comical because she almost looked cross-eyed.

But it wasn’t comical, not when they were at the cusp of a revelation that was so... seedy.

“I just... like I was dancing with them, and it was pretty, you know... not *waltzing*.”

Chris’s heart felt like someone had a fist around it and was squeezing it. The sensation coursing through him was strange, and not what he expected. He should have been angry, jealous, disappointed in his wife – and he supposed that he did feel jealous, cold and hard in the center of his chest.

But his blood was pounding and he was almost embarrassed to admit to himself – let alone Laura – that he actually felt thrilled. It was less anger than excitement coursing through him now. Maybe Rob was right, maybe Rob and Jenna had it all figured out: it was *fun* not knowing what happened with Laura, fun sort of... chasing her.

“What, like, tango,” he pressed. “Or something else?”

Laura folded her hands in her lap and looked at the table, contrite. “I don’t know, like kind of, grind-y dancing. I guess.” She reached up quickly to brush her hair from her face. “The thing is, I didn’t really know how to stop things once they got rolling in a certain direction, you know? I know that’s not a good excuse, and that I should have just... I should have not put myself in that position, and come home, but it was like, we’d just gotten there, Jenna had been planning this forever, I didn’t want to be rude...”

She sniffed.

There was an awkward silence. “I’m sorry,” she added. Then she looked up at him, distraught.

Chris was still fixated on the phrase “grind-y dancing.”

“Grinding, huh?” he said. “So... what happened, exactly?” Chris asked.

She gave him a strange look, and then shrugged. “I mean... just that, just dancing, and this guy was, you know, hitting on me all night, we were sitting really close...” her voice trailed off, her eyes questioning. She didn’t seem to believe that Chris wasn’t angrier.

“Did you kiss him?”

“What?” Laura almost shrieked. “God, no! What is-? No! Nothing like... that.”

Chris’s insides twisted again. “Did you want to?”

The breath was literally sucked out of Laura’s mouth with a gasp that seemed to come from outside of herself. Her mouth snapped open and then shut, and her eyes went black for a moment as her pupils enlarged. Was she afraid? About to tell a lie? Or did the idea just enthrall her that much? “I... Jeez, Chris. No, of course not.”

She was looking back down at the table.

He knew he should probably drop it, but he had an erection, and the blood was pumping, and he was driven by a very new, very exciting urge. He put his hand on Laura’s. “So you didn’t actually *do* anything,” he said, and waited for her to shake her head in agreement. “I’m just asking, if you *wanted* to...?” He moved his thumb on the back of her hand.

Laura’s mouth was open again, and she was staring at him.

He put his free hand on her knee, under the table. “There’s nothing wrong with *thinking* about it,” he said. “Come on. Was this guy good-

looking?”

Laura's face colored, and her eyes dropped again. “Chris...” she said.

“I’m just *asking*,” he continued, and he actually could not believe himself. That he was pressing this hard, this interested in making his wife say something like, *yes, he was hot, he was hot and I wanted to fuck him...*

How fucked up was it, that those words were the words he most wanted to hear from her right now? How fucked up was it that he wanted to push her to say them? What was he getting out of this?

Laura folded her arms across her upper belly and shot him a look. “You know I wouldn’t...” she began. Her head shook quickly, but her tone was losing its steam of conviction.

He moved his fingers over her arm. “I know you wouldn’t, and I trust you that you didn’t. You have a really adorable habit of telling on yourself about everything.” He was pleased to see that the fine hairs on her upper arm were rising slightly with the excitement on the surface of her skin. “I’m just asking, out of curiosity, if the guy was attractive at all. If, in another world where you weren’t married, you’d be into him. You can tell me *that*.”

Laura pressed her lips together.

“So he *was*,” Chris said.

Laura's cheeks turned scarlet, and he lifted a finger to them. Her skin was hot, and the truth was in her expression. She studied the table fiercely.

“It’s okay with me if you thought he was good-looking,” Chris said. “I don’t know, I kind of get what Jenna and Rob have going...”

Laura shot him a look.

He left his fingers on her arm. “You know she’s the only one who sleeps with other people?” he asked her.

This caught Laura's attention. “What?”

His fingers were traveling up her arm, to her shoulder, then back down again. “Mm-hmm. I guess he just likes to watch.” He felt another pang of arousal, a throb in his pants. “I think he likes to watch her.”

Laura's mouth fell open again and the fading blush on her cheeks grew hot and red for the third time. She knew what he meant, all right.

“This is... wow, this is...way, way... outside of my... you know...” she babbled.

Chris smiled and leaned back, but kept his fingers on her arm. He turned her arm over and it flopped out straight toward him, so he drew his

fingertips along the pale, soft underside of her forearm. She stared down at what he was doing, her chest fluttering quickly, her lips parted.

“Outside of your comfort zone?” he asked. He moved the hand on her knee up her thigh a little, and felt her tremble beneath his fingers. “So? It’s pretty fun, don’t you think?”

Between her legs, her skin was damp and hot. He could practically feel the wetness of her panties before he even reached them. Laura was frozen in place, letting him explore her body, her chest the only part of her moving. That, and the electrifying of her skin, the goosebumps traveling along her arms and shoulders and neck in waves.

“Was this guy black, too?” he said, taking the plunge. “Jenna’s guy? *Your* guy from last night?”

He had already ferreted out Laura’s secret, the one she probably wasn’t even able to admit to herself. He had seen it that night at the restaurant, but he hadn’t put it together until now, until her skin had turned hot and bright pink when he talked about it: Laura had a thing for black guys, too.

And for some reason, he wanted to explore that.

“Chris,” Laura said quietly. “That’s so...”

He pushed his hand between her legs, and they fell open with little effort. Laura’s eyes dilated as his fingers found her soaked panties, and then slipped beneath the hem and into her gushing cunt, exploring for her clit. She almost jumped out of her seat when he stroked her.

“It’s just me and you here,” Chris said. “I’m just curious.”

He rubbed her clit, and she closed her eyes, her lips parting in pleasure.

“So?” he said, pushing her chair with his other hand so that it turned and she was facing him. “Was he?”

Laura nodded, and he pushed hard on her clit to give her a little jolt.

“You like that?” he asked, dipping his fingers into her pussy. “You do, don’t you?”

Laura’s eyes flew open, and he could see that her sense of propriety was surfacing, ready to claim her. He pulled his hand out from inside of her and grabbed both of her legs by the knees, pulling her toward him.

Laura was frozen, her face gathering into an expression of shock. Beneath the skin on her neck, her pulse was visible: rapid, strong, sexed.

He pulled her legs up and toward him, forcing her to push herself up and hop onto his lap, legs spread, the scent of her arousal faint and sweet.

What a naughty little girl, he thought.

He pushed his fingers back beneath her panties and explored the soaked velvet lips of her pussy, her clit squirming in her juices and folds, pulsing when he touched it. Her breath cut in and out with each flick of his fingers against her clit. He sank three fingers into her pussy with ease, his thumb rolling over her clit.

She was tight around his fingers, and his cock pulsed hard as he thought about how tight she would be around another man's cock. Another man's thick, black cock. Was that the appeal for her, the size? Would she even be able to take it? And how would she feel, to another man, a bigger man, if he sank into her pussy and stretched it wider than it had ever been stretched?

These thoughts fueled his need like gasoline on a fire. He reached up with his free hand and grabbed her loosely by the hair, pulling her head back to kiss her neck and draw his tongue along her skin up to her earlobe. When the words left his mouth he felt no compunction about it: "I want you to think about that guy while I fuck you. Think about his big, black cock inside of you..."

And his Laura, his sweet-faced, awkward, geeky, loyalty-and-honesty Laura, rippled from the inside, her pussy gushing around his fingers, pulsing as though she had just had an orgasm. A gasp escaped her mouth.

Wow. It really was the girls you least suspected.

He pushed Laura back onto her chair and somehow got them both onto the floor, the floor of the kitchen of all places, but he wasn't thinking clearly anymore. He rose up on his knees, straddling Laura, whose hair was tossed behind her and cheeks were flushed, her lips parted and her eyes wide as saucers with lust.

He opened his fly and wriggled his pants down, cock in hand, hard and dripping precum. Several filthy ideas struck him at once, and for a moment he wasn't sure which one to enact, how far he could push his wife with this game they were playing.

But then he remembered the gush of her pussy, the clenching around his fingers, and he just went for it.

“I want you to imagine that this is your friend’s nice, big, black cock,” he breathed, and edged closer to Laura’s mouth.

He reached for her hair, to pull her head close to his cock, but Laura was already in the game, lifting herself up to put her lips on the head of his dick. She reached up with one hand to clamp her fingers around him, and her tongue, wet and hungry, slipped between her teeth to lap at the bead of precum pooling in the center of his crown.

He watched the pearly white bead disappear between her lips, and then she opened, and her mouth was closing around the sensitive silk of his cock. Hot, slippery flesh enclosed his cock and he bounced in her hand as she hungrily licked and sucked on the bulbous head, her eyes closed, her mind clearly at work on the very thing he had ordered her to imagine: a big, black cock for her to suck on.

He was so stunned that for a moment it was all he could do to stare at his wife’s mouth working on him – how long had it been since she had given him a blowjob? Years? He tried try to keep from blowing his cum right into her mouth at that moment. He looked up at the ceiling, sucking in, trying to keep from overloading on the filthy ideas that swirled in his head, the images he was creating, the real image he was seeing, and the hot, hot mouth that was sliding further and further down his cock.

And she wasn’t doing it the way she usually did it, like it was a chore... she was slurping and sucking and *feasting* on his cock. He looked down at his wife, her eyes closed, her mind obviously at work on the idea of sucking on black cock -

He pulled on her hair, because he could feel himself getting very near the edge and he wanted to make sure that he felt Laura’s pussy quivering around his cock. He pushed her back onto the floor, yanked her panties down with her sweat-short pajamas, and pushed her legs up as he fell toward her red, glistening pussy.

He wanted to dirty-talk her some more, but Laura’s eyes were unfocused and her thoughts were obviously already where he wanted them to be: imagining what it would be like to spread her legs for another man, for a dark, heavily-endowed man, who would split her pussy open like a juicy fruit. So he said nothing, and imagined it for himself instead.

He didn’t have to work on his wife long: her body arched from the floor and she ground against his pelvis, wrapping her heels around his torso

and digging them into his back to pull him deeper and harder inside of her. He felt the muscles of her cunt spasm and roll like waves around his cock at the same time that she filled with hot liquid, and then he arched his own back and yelled as he dumped his seed inside of her.

They lay on the floor, panting for a while, their skin sticking together. Chris could feel their mixed juices between his legs and hers, smell the scent of sex. Laura's pussy throbbed around his cock. How long had it been since they had done anything like this? It seemed like an eternity ago since they had even had sex on a regular basis.

Laura's eyes fluttered open. She pushed herself up on her elbows, causing Chris to roll off to the side. She looked at him, her smile a mixture of amusement and her typical unsureness. "What the heck?" she said nervously.

Chris smiled. "What? We just had really hot sex."

Laura chewed on her lip and lay back down with a sigh.

Chris leaned over her and played with her damp skin beneath the silky camisole he had crumpled in his haste to get inside of her. She flinched – pleurably – when he brushed his fingers over her nipples. They were hard and swollen, and her body reacted with desire. "What's the problem?" he murmured into her neck.

Laura gave a nervous laugh. "I mean... it seems so..." her voice trailed off, and Chris lifted his head to look at her.

"Wrong, right?" she finished.

Chris rested his head on his hand. He continued to stroke her beneath her camisole. "I don't know, Laura, is it wrong? We haven't been this close for years. I'm having a good time, you're having a good time – why is it wrong?"

Laura's face contorted into an expression of horror, but he could tell it was very put-on. "But it's... it's because we're thinking about, I'm thinking about...or, well, you too, but... another man. That's... you know, not right."

Chris rolled onto his back with a sigh. "I mean, says who?" he asked the ceiling. "Why?"

Laura was back on her elbows, sitting up, adjusting her shorts. "Are you telling me you're not *bothered* that the only reason we had good sex is because we're talking about another guy?"

Chris waved his hands at the ceiling. "Laura, good sex is good sex, you can't ask a guy if something about it bothers him, that's -"

"*I* am not cool with what Jenna and Rob do."

"Oh, really?" he asked sarcastically.

Laura popped up to standing. "You are?" she demanded. "Like, you aren't even bothered by the idea that I would do something with another guy?" She waited, and then she added, before he could answer. "Because I am not cool with us just sleeping with... whoever."

Chris sat up. "Look, can we talk seriously about this for a second?" he asked. "First of all, I'm not sleeping with, or flirting with, anyone. This is... so Rob and Jenna, they have a different thing going on than what you think. It's just Jenna, sleeping with other guys. I talked to Rob about it at the game. And... I don't know, the way he explained it to me... I guess I can understand it."

He almost added, "maybe even get into it," but he wasn't quite ready to say *that* aloud just yet, not when he couldn't read what Laura was thinking exactly.

Laura was quiet. "You *understand it*? Like, how?"

Chris looked up at her. "Laura, I'm having a hard time understanding your reactions, here. We just had a really nice time. Don't try to tell me you didn't like it. And now, I just want to talk about it, that's all."

Laura folded her arms defensively. "We *are* talking."

"Well, without you getting so mad."

She dropped her arms. There was an uneasy silence.

"Why *are* you getting so upset?" Chris asked her. "I just want to talk about this stuff. It's not like we have to *do* anything."

"I just don't... I don't know. I don't know how to feel, that you're just like, turned on by the idea of me having sex with some other guy."

Chris folded his hands. Now they were getting somewhere. "Okay," he said. "That makes sense. I think it's... I don't know how to explain it, Laura. Rob sort of explained it best, it's kind of like going back to a time when everything wasn't so... predictable, you know?"

"Oh, now I'm predictable!" Laura said.

Chris stood up, and took her by the elbows. "Laura, come on. Are you going to actually try and tell me that we aren't predictable? That things haven't gotten dull?"

She looked at her feet, and he could tell he'd hit home with the question.

"And then, are you going to try and tell me that the times we've had sex since... you know, Jenna and Rob's little secret... haven't been amazing?"

Laura said nothing.

"And that all those times, you're going to tell me you weren't at least *thinking* about another guy."

Laura had a hard time hiding her reaction to that one. She shifted, and while her face didn't visibly color, he could tell he'd hit home.

She was silent for a moment. "It's just... it seems like it shouldn't be that way. Like, this can't be a *good* thing for our marriage."

Chris sat on a chair, not giving in to his desire to point out that Laura had, essentially, just admitted to thinking about other guys while they were having sex. Because he could feel that he was close to breaking down another, more important point. "Why's that?" he asked, in reference to her comment. He put his hands out and pulled Laura to him. "I mean, really, think about... why you think that."

"Chris!" she said. "Come *on*, it's like, the number one thing about being married. Not *sleeping* with other people."

"Laura, it isn't like you're some kind of old-fashioned Bible-thumper," Chris pointed out. That much was true: Laura might be *reticent* to do illicit things, but it certainly wasn't a religious sentiment holding her back.

"What difference does it make, if the two of us agree about it? We're both consenting adults," he pressed.

Laura pushed a loose strand of hair from her face. "I just don't get how.. how you could be okay with that."

Chris put a hand out to her leg and stroked the back of her knee, which he knew drove her wild. "It's sort of the point," he said. "That I'm not okay with it, so I get jealous and I want to win you back. Or something like that."

He let this sink in for a little bit, pretty happy with himself for having found the right way to explain it, a way that he felt would sound better to Laura.

Chris pulled her by the back of her knees gently toward him. "Listen," he said, letting his fingers travel up the back of her leg. "I'm not trying to press the issue or anything. I don't want you to do anything you don't want to do. I'm just putting the idea out there, letting you know... you know, maybe it's something to think about. It's exciting. It's... it's giving us something to talk about, bringing us closer together. Don't you think?"

Laura made a funny face, looking from side to side, which was her way of agreeing with something she didn't really feel like admitting to.

He kept moving his hand up the back of her thigh. He was turned on again, and even though he knew the chances of getting Laura to have sex with him again were about one in a million, there was no sense in not trying.

"It's been kind of fun," he said, suggestively. "Wouldn't you say?" Laura was still, letting him move his hand further and further up her shorts, where he could feel the cooled stain of cum that had dripped into her panties, the dried juices on her inner thighs. He looked up at Laura, and saw that she had the parted lips, the dark-eyed stare, the face she made when she was excited.

And her eyes were on his cock.

She brought her fingers to her lips and smiled beneath them, and he stood up without thinking about it, and walked her back to the bedroom.

*

The second time they had sex that day, Laura let herself give in to her fantasies. She let her mind wander to all the places that felt so taboo: after all, Chris had pretty much given her permission to think about other guys. About having sex with other guys, maybe even *really* having sex with other guys. So she didn't feel guilty indulging in that fantasy while her husband fucked her. In fact, the idea blossomed in her mind, thinking about Chris watching her, feeling jealous... it turned her on. She came twice in their second tumble in bed, her chest on the sheets and Chris fucking her from behind. With her cheek on the bed she could think about whatever she wanted to: about a chiseled, feral man fucking her with a cock she'd never felt before, stretching her out, while Chris stewed and watched and felt the sting of jealousy.

The part of her fantasy she did *not* feel free to have, the part she still felt uncomfortable with, was the very specific physical characteristics she gave to her male protagonist.

And why? She thought dully, lying on her side while Chris took a shower. Why did she feel bad for having that *particular* fantasy, that particular... was it a fetish?

After all, this was all just fantasy. She was never going to actually *do* anything like this.

Her mind kept wandering back to the club she had gone to with Jenna, to the hand on her knee. The black hand. And from there, her mind just kept going, and going and going, to what it would feel like to get on her knees and take a whole, veined, dark cock into her mouth. To the way his trunk-like legs would feel against the back of her thighs, as that whole huge cock slammed into her pussy. It was a short ride from there to picture herself bouncing on his lap, dark meat between her thighs like she had seen once in a porno in university – another image that had never really left her mind.

She opened her eyes. It seemed almost unbelievable that her pussy was throbbing the way that it was, that after everything that had just happened with Chris she could be turned on again. And the things she was thinking about – not just fucking some guy but doing really twisted, filthy things with him, letting him manhandle her, picturing a cock so large it made her pussy sting. What the hell? It was so racist, so dark, so taboo... she didn't want to have these thoughts.

And the last thing she wanted to do was tell Chris about them.

She sat up when she heard the water turn off. Chris embraced her as she walked by, naked, on her way to the bathroom. He was certainly right, this fantasizing had injected new energy into their sex life, and she wanted him again, which she was sure would have stunned him.

"I'll go make a big breakfast," he said, cheerfully.

Laura sank towards him, thinking maybe he would get the hint and take her back to bed, but they had had so much sex at that point that Chris seemed satiated. He walked into the closet, smiling.

Laura got in the shower, and tried to focus on the hot water, on thoughts about something else, to calm her body down. But inevitably, every thought led to a man like Jay, to picturing herself on the bed like she

had just lain for Chris – but with a dark man behind her, her pussy stretched wider than ever before, and thick inches of cock pressing on places inside her that had never been touched. The ache between her thighs only got deeper, more insistent.

So when she felt the floor shake with the vibrations of Chris's retreating steps, fading away to the kitchen, she didn't hesitate to reach up and pull the showerhead out of its cradle. She switched it to pulse, and had only to lower it to her slightly parted legs for the pulses of hot water to hit her engorged clit. She put a hand on the tile, to hold herself up, while she opened her mouth and imagined that dark fingers were intertwined in her hair, pulling her head toward the smooth, dark skin of a man's pelvis, bumpy, musky cock forcing her jaw wider, filling her throat. She would take it all, and he would push her until she did, and then she would feel the bitter hot cream of cum splashing against the back of her throat, and he would tell her to be a good girl, and swallow it all -

Her eyes flew open as she had her fourth climax of the day, one that made her shudder from head to toe and almost lose her footing in the shower.

With her legs shaking, she put the showerhead back into the cradle, and turned around slowly, panting, to stare at the tiled wall.

This part of her fantasy, she thought guiltily, she definitely needed to keep secret.

Jay flashed through her mind, then Jenna's date from Bourbon and Feast, then Jenna herself.

She could always talk to Jenna about it...

She tipped her head back and let the water roll down her body and her face, between her legs, where her slick cum and Chris's slid, still hot, from between her thighs.

Some things, she concluded unconvincingly to herself, were best left to fantasy.

CHAPTER 6

“Hey man,” Chris said, walking toward Rob’s truck at a job site on a Wednesday. He’d wanted to talk to Rob some more about... whatever he wanted to call it – since the Saturday he’d made progress with Laura, but the opportunity had just never come up.

Rob and Jenna just seemed to be going on with their regular lives, which of course made sense – this *was* their regular life, evidently. But it sort of irked Chris, because for him the past few weeks had been weeks of obsessive fantasizing, or thinking almost constantly about his wife sleeping with other men. They’d had some really hot sex – at least, it was hot on his end and it seemed to be for Laura, too. But he didn’t know if Laura was as obsessed with this fantasy as he was, or if she was just playing along, or what. He was a little afraid to break the spell they were under by starting another conversation about it, but waiting for Laura to bring up the subject was driving him crazy.

So the next best thing would be to talk to Rob.

“Listen, you think you could work in some time to go have a beer or something, man?” Chris asked. He was trying to sound casual.

Rob tied off some lumber with a fierce tug and gave a wry smile, as if he already knew what the topic of conversation was going to be. “Sure, man,” he said. “When’s good for you?”

Chris scratched his head. “Well, tonight, if -”

“No can do, buddy. Jenna’s got a date tonight and...” he paused and leaned on the side of the truck. “Actually,” he said, “that’s what this is about, right?”

Chris felt an urge to act like it wasn’t, but it passed quickly so he just nodded.

Rob shrugged. “I could probably ask Jenna if it’s okay if you meet me at wherever she’s going...”

Chris’s eyes went wide. “You mean, like... watch, uh, her, or...?”

Rob hit him on the shoulder. “Relax, buddy. I just like to watch her flirt with these guys sometimes. This is some new guy from Tinder so, you

know, it might not be her thing. But if you come along, you can see what the deal is. That is what you want to have this beer about, right?"

Chris swallowed dryly. The idea was incredibly enticing. "Yeah, well... okay..." he said.

Rob threw the rope across the bed of the truck and started to take out his phone. "Let me just check with Jenna," he said, thumb moving over the screen. "I'll look less creepy this way, so she'll probably approve."

Chris fumbled with his phone and typed to Laura, not waiting for the answer.

Going for a beer after work. Be home a little late. That okay?

He stared at the message. Something about it made him feel like he wasn't being honest. He typed back and inserted: *with Rob*.

There. Surely Laura would know what that meant. Was it dishonest to go watch Jenna pick up some other guy without telling Laura that was specifically what he was doing?

His phone buzzed.

[Laura]: *funny you should say that. I was just making plans to go out with Jenna.*

Chris's heart felt as though it had come to a complete stop in his chest. His whole body turned into a deliciously icy block.

[Laura]: *can we get a sitter*

He stared at the phone. Rob let out a laugh from the other side of the truck. He held up his phone. "I think your wife has the same idea you do." He smiled. "That's encouraging, man. But you guys should probably talk more." He shook his head and looked down at his screen. "Jenna wants to know if you guys are fucking with us or what."

Chris wasn't sure what to do.

He typed:

[Me]: *I thought Jenna had a date tonight.*

He sent it, and then, re-reading it, it seemed kind of harsh. He sent a smiley face blowing a kiss, which seemed childish as soon as it appeared on the screen.

There was a long pause, while Rob typed on his own phone and chuckled, and Chris waited for Laura's response, staring at the bouncing periods that indicated she was typing. It seemed like an eternity passed. He looked over at Rob, who must have caught him in the corner of his eye, because he looked up and nodded, smiling. "Fun, isn't it?"

His phone vibrated with an incoming text signal, and he was almost panting when he looked down to read it.

[Laura]: *She asked me to come with her to the bar. Before she meets the guy.*

A chill traveled through the center of his body. Laura wasn't lying to him, but she wasn't really giving him the whole story. And he liked something about it.

He typed:

[Me]: *Okay, well Rob wants to go and watch her pick up this guy, so he invited me. I kind of want to see what it's all about. So I'll be there.*

His stomach twisted. He wondered in what capacity Jenna had invited Laura. Was it really just to keep her company before her date? Or had Laura, like him, wanted to talk to Jenna about her lifestyle?

Or – and the thought was so enticing and so dangerous that he could barely stand thinking about it – had Jenna arranged for *Laura* to go on a date as well?

His mind filled with images of a threesome, which he dismissed out of hand as too far, especially for Laura.

But hot.

His phone buzzed.

[Laura]: *I have to confess. I asked Jenna to let me come along for the same reason.*

He stared at the screen, and just as he started to type his next lame sentence, because he was totally unsure of how to react to Laura's confession, and his heart was beating so wildly with excitement that his hands were shaking, another message came in from Laura.

[Laura]: *I'm glad you're coming*

He typed, and retyped, and deleted several messages, not wanting to send the wrong message, sound creepy, or make Laura change her mind. Inside, he was flying with excitement and could only hope that Laura was not going to suddenly snatch from him this unexpected moment. He settled, at last, on:

[Me]: *see you there*

Rob was still typing to Jenna (or at least, Chris assumed it was Jenna), and shaking his head. He finally looked up. "You guys plan this or something?"

But the question seemed more rhetorical than anything, which Chris was grateful for.

"Okay. I gotta run home and change. You want to meet me at my place or the bar?"

Chris shrugged. "Uh..."

Rob shook his head and smiled. "Don't overthink it. Go home and I'll swing by and pick you up, Laura can drive you home."

Chris held his hand up as Rob drove off.

Sure, he thought.

CHAPTER 7

Laura wasn't entirely sure how it had happened, but now that it *was* happening, the way it was happening, she couldn't settle down at her desk long enough to wrap up the last hour of work. She was getting behind on her work, and had a few claims and issues sitting on her diary that were starting to blink with urgency: she really needed to concentrate on getting them done.

But she couldn't focus.

At lunch, she'd seen Jenna swiping away at Tinder. Not that she knew exactly what Tinder was or how it worked, but she'd heard enough discussions about it and references to it in TV shows and movies to get the gist. It was enough information to intuit that Jenna's left-and-right swiping of hot guys' profile pictures was, in fact, the fabled Tinder.

For quite some time, she'd been looking for a way to start a conversation with Jenna about her "lifestyle." Laura hadn't been able to get the swirl of thoughts – racist, crazy, feral thoughts of sex and men – out of her mind. She definitely didn't want to go *through* with anything, or actually admit to being attracted enough to black guys that she was masturbating almost every day to thoughts of fucking one while her husband watched (or didn't). But *talking* to Jenna about it was like dipping her toe in it, or standing very close to the edge of a huge cliff. She could get a little thrill, without actually having to *do* anything.

So she had leaned over the table and tried to appear curious and somewhat scandalized as she asked Jenna: "You use *Tinder*?"

Jenna had looked at up her and smiled. Laura felt both a little judgmental, and a little jealous, of the fact that Jenna was completely, totally, unashamed of what she was doing. She flipped the screen around to Laura and smiled. "Yeah. I just started this. There are... literally like a zillion guys out there..." she sucked in her breath and fanned herself when she turned the screen back. Then she put her elbows on the table and started to tap on her screen with a smile on her lips.

Laura lowered her voice, which was more for herself than for Jenna, who didn't seem to care that anyone could walk into the lunch room and see

her on Tinder at any moment. And she had her big, fat wedding ring on the hand she was using to swipe with!

“Do you... uh, I thought you went out with just like, guys you knew from...” Laura trailed off. Where had she thought Jenna got her guys? She didn’t really know, but she realized she’d concocted some kind of strange story in her own mind and now she realized it didn’t really make sense.

Jenna put the phone down and leaned on her arms. “What?” she asked, confused.

Laura felt stupid. She rubbed her nose. “I just thought... like, you haven’t been using Tinder for like, your other dates, have you? Or...” Laura grew exasperated. “Okay,” she whispered, making Jenna smile. “How do you, you know, do it?”

Jenna fluffed her hair. “So Tinder’s new. That’s... I wouldn’t be doing that if I didn’t have a lot of experience with this already,” she said. “So, you know, if you’re thinking about -”

Laura shook her head. “No, no. No, no, no,” she said, and she realized she sounded ridiculous.

Jenna grinned and rolled her eyes. “Aaaaaanyway, let’s say you ever *do* think about it, don’t start by going out with some guy off Tinder.”

Laura furrowed her brow. “Why’s that?” she asked, genuinely curious.

Jenna slid around the table. The lunchroom, was, thankfully, totally empty. “Look, Tinder is basically like, a meat market. All these guys just want to hook up and have sex. So that’s great, because that’s what I’m looking for, but it’s also, like... you have to be ready for that. To go all the way, not have any conflict about it. And also,” she waved her hand in the air. “I take this off,” she said, indicating her wedding ring. “These guys are not in the game, do you know what I mean?”

Laura wanted to say yes, and she started to, but then she shook her head.

Jenna leaned on her hand. “So, you know that there’s like, a whole community of people doing this, right?” She said this matter-of-factly, as if she took it for a fact that Laura did know that there was a whole community of people doing “this.” She didn’t know that, but she just nodded, so Jenna would keep talking.

“So that’s how we started. You know, with a bull. *These guys*,” Jenna said, waving at her phone, “are like, I don’t know, boss level or something. Don’t start there.”

The word “bull” was bouncing around in Laura’s head. She wanted desperately to ask Jenna what she meant by that, but she didn’t want to sound like an idiot. Jenna was already conferring way more... whatever it was, sexual sophistication?... on Laura than she possessed, which felt sort of empowering. Like some of Jenna’s confidence was leeching off of Jenna and onto her.

“So you’re really thinking about this, huh?” Jenna cooed. She was smiling.

Laura looked away quickly, which made Jenna hit her playfully on the arm. “Hey, it’s totally cool. I get it.”

Laura pressed her lips together. Then she took the plunge. “Okay, look,” she whispered, even though there was no one in the room but them. “I sort of want to know more about this, I mean, not to *try* it, but just, like, I don’t know, I’m curious about it...”

Jenna was smiling. Laura covered her face. “I’m curious about... something specific...”

Jenna picked up her phone and started typing a response to a message. “You like black guys,” she said, matter-of-factly.

Laura was stopped dead in her tracks. Her mouth moved, but she couldn’t figure out what to make it say.

Jenna, unperturbed, finished her message and set her phone down. She looked Laura up and down. “There’s nothing wrong with that,” she told Laura.

“I don’t -”

“O-kay,” Jenna said, rolling her eyes. “I must have just *totally misread* the way your panties were obviously creaming for Jay that other night.”

Laura’s mouth fell open.

Jenna smiled. “But whatever, maybe that isn’t your thing.”

Laura stabbed her salad.

“If it *is* your thing,” Jenna said slyly, “I could point you in the right direction...”

Laura pressed her lips together again, staring at her salad. But she couldn't help smile a little. "I'm just curious," she said resolutely, "how the whole thing works."

She wasn't quite ready to be so open to Jenna, because she still really couldn't believe her own obsession. She wasn't quite ready to admit it to herself yet, let alone someone else.

Let *alone* actually get Jenna "working" on something for her.

Not yet.

"Hey!" Jenna said suddenly, slapping her on the arm. "Why don't you come out with me tonight?"

Laura almost jumped out of her seat. "I – what? Um, no, what are you talking about? I don't actually want to *do* anything."

"I know that," Jenna said. "But I'm meeting this guy at the Red Room and I don't have time to go back home and then back downtown in this traffic, and anyway that kind of kills it for me, so I have like two hours to kill. We could go shopping and then you could keep me company until he shows up and then, you know, watch, or go home, or whatever."

Laura was staring at her, her fork dangling in mid-air.

She was picturing the whole evening: going out? On a Wednesday? Not even going home first, keeping the distance between her house and her husband and this new, exciting world she'd stumbled upon? Having some drinks, pretending she was single and out with a single girlfriend? She could picture herself at the bar with Jenna, who would inevitably attract all kinds of attention her way... and some of that attention would inevitably go to Laura, even if she wasn't anyone's first choice when Jenna was around.

Laura's heart fluttered. It was enticing...

Too enticing?

Intellectually, everything about it seemed like a bad idea.

But physically, there was no doubt that she was pulled toward the idea.

"This guy," Jenna said, not waiting for Laura's answer, flipping the phone around to show a picture of a really ripped, really young, really *hot* dark-skinned man, who wasn't as dark as Laura liked to imagine her men, but a toffee-shade, and delicious -

Laura put her hands in her lap and cleared her throat. What the hell was she thinking? "Not as dark as she preferred?" Seriously?

“Uh, okay, let me, uh, see what... I have to see if Chris is okay with that...”

Jenna flipped her screen back toward her own face. “Gotcha,” she said, smiling. “Just shoot me a message so I don’t leave without you.”

Laura picked up her salad and her lunch bag awkwardly, and left the room, her skin positively tingling.

“Hey,” Jenna said, and Laura didn’t realize she was joking until later. “I’ll ask him to bring a friend.”

When Laura got the message from Chris, at around six-thirty, her heart picked up and started beating so fast she could hardly think.

“What?” Jenna asked, reading her expression over the screen of the phone. Laura had stopped dead in her tracks as they walked out of the office.

“Uh... it’s Chris, he’s grabbing a beer with Rob tonight,” she said. “Oh, I better-”

“Wait,” Jenna said, leaning in to read Chris’s messages. She looked up at Laura. “Dude, Rob’s supposed to be coming to watch me tonight. He’s going to Red Room,” she said.

Laura looked at her helplessly.

“I just confirmed it with him like two seconds ago,” Jenna said, her eyes moving as she thought. Then she broke out in a wide smile. “Oh, hey... great minds think alike, this is good news for you.”

Laura looked at her, perplexed. Jenna hit her on the arm again. “It means Chris has this on his mind, too. Go, tell him to go, and then just like, show up there.”

Laura slowly moved her head. “Oh, I couldn’t...”

Jenna shrugged. “He’d obviously like it. But whatever. Tell him you’re going with me, see what he says.”

And so Laura found herself headed out the door with Jenna, to the mall, to get a hot outfit for Jenna’s date, which she would be watching... and so would her husband.

She wasn’t sure how it had happened, but there it was.

*

Jenna shopped at a store called Lola, which Laura had walked by hundreds of times without even seeing, because everything on display in the windows looked like it belonged on a twenty-year old, and she hadn't ever dressed like that to begin with, even when she *was* twenty years old.

Jenna was turning around in the mirror, sizing up a black and white dress that clung to her body and emphasized the generous swell of her ass, and her huge breasts, but showed only the skin of her smooth, tan back. She was frowning.

"It's a really hot dress," Laura offered, feeling a little awkward and a little dumpy sitting on a bench at the end of the hall of mirrors, watching Jenna spin around. She had tried on three dresses, and now it was down to this one or a red one.

Suddenly Jenna put her hands on her hips. "You know what? This isn't emphasizing my best features," she said. "I need to show more tit. Also this isn't my style. Too... sharp of lines, or something." She stepped toward her changing room, and then stopped suddenly. She looked over at Laura. "You know who this dress would look hot on?"

It took Laura a moment to realize Jenna was talking about her.

"Oh no," she said, holding her hands up.

And yet... something was wavering in her voice.

She kind of *wanted* to try on the dress. She was wearing her work clothes, and she was feeling pretty plain next to Jenna.

"Yeah," Jenna said, as though Laura had already agreed. She turned on her heel and marched to the end of the corridor. "Miss," she called out. She turned to Laura. "This is perfect, this is like, your style. We'll get some makeup going – yeah, hi, can you grab a..." she poked her head back in to look Laura up and down – "A six and a four in this?" she said. Then quickly, "It's not for me."

Jenna was not a size six or four. She was an amply endowed eight, all curves. "Actually," she said. "Forget the six, grab a four and a two –"

"Jenna," Laura said.

"You want to really stuff yourself into it," Jenna told her, "it makes your ass look bigger, which is what black guys like, not that you're into that, but say you were... thank you."

Jenna thrust the dresses into Laura's lap. "Go. Try these on. Hurry up, I want to get some drinks before this guy shows up."

Laura paused only for a moment, before the excitement took over, and sent her into a dressing room to try on a dress she would *never, ever* have even thought of trying.

“Oh God,” Laura said. “It’s too... much.”

Jenna had snorted when she had come out of the dressing room wearing the four. The dress was tight to her skin, and the back was open in a teardrop shape that swooped down to just above her ass. She would have to go without a bra.

Jenna scowled. “Is that the four? Get back in there,” she said, turning Laura around, “and put on the two.”

Now she was wearing the same dress, only it was tighter, shorter, and she looked...

“I look a little slutty,” she said quietly.

“Yes,” Jenna said, approvingly. “But it’s also pretty classy.”

“There is no way I can wear this,” Laura said. But she was turning around, admiring her figure in the mirror. She actually did look pretty good. She was lean, almost model-thin, and tall. Squeezed into the super-small dress, her bottom did, in fact plump out more, and she even looked like she had a pretty decent rack – not as nice as Jenna’s, but then, she wasn’t Jenna.

“You look fucking hot,” Jenna said. “You look like an actress or something. Oh, buy it. Wear it. I’ll buy it for you, if you promise to wear it.”

“I can’t wear this...” Laura repeated. “I...”

Her voice trailed off, and Jenna crossed her arms and rolled her eyes. “Please. I’ll buy it, it’s too... oh, my God. Are those your only shoes?”

Laura looked down at her flats. She was 5’ 10” and already felt too tall to begin with.

Jenna shook her head.

“I always wear flats,” Laura said, defensively.

“WHY?” Jenna said, and she could tell the question was rhetorical.

“Heels are like, the easiest thing to get a guy’s dick hard.”

Laura blanched. “Uh... I mean, but I’m so tall -”

“So you won’t have any midgets hit on you. Did you want a short guy to hit on you? No. You want a big, tall, hot black man who looks like a basketball player to hit on you. Am I right?” Jenna shook her head and

pointed at Laura like a mother scolding a child. “You’re taking that, and we’re going to a shoe store.” She stomped away to get the sales attendant. “Leave it on, she’ll take the tag off in here. Miss?”

Laura stared after her and closed the curtain to her own dressing room with a sharp jerk. She stared at herself in the mirror. Really, Jenna had a lot of nerve. Talking to her like that, *as if* she really wanted some tall, hot, black guy to actually hit on her.

As if.

And talking to her like she had just... joined up with Jenna and her crazy lifestyle. When she had just told her that she wasn’t into it.

No. This was all a bad idea, and Jenna was getting too caught up in it.

She should just go home. Not buy this dress, not get any new shoes, for sure, and not go out with this totally crazy, dangerous friend.

Definitely, she thought, tugging the dress into perfect position. It really did look pretty good on her, even if she didn’t look anything like herself.

Jenna threw open the curtain without announcement. “Hers, here,” she was saying.

The sales clerk was saying excuse me, and taking the tag off the dress, before she knew it.

And the whole time, Laura stared at herself in the mirror, wondering what the hell she was getting herself into, but saying absolutely nothing to get herself out of it.

CHAPTER 8

At first, he didn't recognize his wife. He saw Jenna first, because Jenna was the kind of attention-grabbing woman who men often saw first. She had blonde hair, she made large, exaggerated movements, she had a big, luscious mouth and white teeth that were always flashing in this way that made you feel like you were rolling around in bed with her.

His mind registered Jenna – a skimpy black dress, her long legs coated in over-the-knee boots – and then registered that Jenna was accompanied by a very tall, lithe, good-looking friend with dark hair, who had bumped into someone and was talking to him. The guy was flirting with the friend, Jenna was turning around to pull her along to a table... and then Jenna moved to the side, the woman gave her brown hair a toss, and Chris felt like he was being kicked right in the chest.

In a good way, of course, the kind of kick that traveled to his nuts and gave them a little squeeze.

It was Laura.

It was Laura, except that it wasn't Laura: she had her hair down, her lips were red and glossy, her eyes dark and framed somehow differently (he would later learn it was black mascara that gave her the doe-eyed, bedroom-eyed look).

And then there was the dress.

The heels.

Rob set his drink down and let out a low whistle. "Dang," he said. "Laura cleans up real nice."

Chris looked over at him briefly. The two women sat down.

Red Room was a trendy hot spot downtown, too busy and too hip on a Friday for Chris to even think of setting foot in the place. The interior was, of course, all red – shades of red: red velvet damask wallpaper and red chairs and tables, different shades of red providing the contrast of the red paintings with red frames. Only the people stood out in the sea of red.

His wife looked as if she'd been designed into the scene. Wearing the black and white dress, with its thick geometric lines hugging the curves of

her body, and her very red lips, it looked like she was modeling clothing for an upscale magazine.

What was the most different about Laura, though, was the way she was carrying herself. It was almost as though Jenna were wearing off on her – although also, not quite. Laura was not the bubbly, laughing, attention-grabbing one. She was the serene, dark-haired beauty, the friend who quietly attracted.

It was her confidence: her straight back, her relaxed smile, that seemed so different. Chris watched her fold into a booth, cross her ankles with their sexy heels, let her hair fall forward as she read a drink menu, take Jenna's phone in her hand and look at a picture, smiling. It was like watching another woman, in a way.

Rob rubbed his hands together. "This is gonna be a good night," he said. He spun on his stool – they were seated at the bar, raised up on a platform with a separate entrance on the cross street. There, they had a pretty good view of the seating area with booths, where most people ended up congregating, according to Rob.

Even on a Wednesday, it was filling up in Red Room. A lot of young, pretty people were starting to get louder and drunker.

And Jenna and Laura were not going unnoticed. He watched as a waiter brought them some drinks, and Laura reacted with surprise. The waiter pointed at a table with two guys, an obvious indication that they had purchased the drinks.

Laura's confidence appeared to waiver; she wasn't sure what to do.

Jenna picked up her drink, turning around to wave her fingers at the guys, and Laura appeared to pale.

Chris felt his stomach drop. He didn't know what he had expected to happen, but up until now, everything had felt theoretical, fantastical. Now that he saw actual men, fully-grown men, men who were buying drinks for his wife and clearly had real, visceral intentions toward her, the whole thing felt much more real.

And frightening.

But also hot.

Chris started to take out his phone, intending to send a message to Laura, to let her know he was there in case... what? She needed him or something?

Rob put a hand on his arm, stopping him. “They’re big girls, man,” he said.

Chris wondered how he had known what he was about to do.

“Let it play out,” Rob said, picking up his drink and situating himself so that he was casually facing the booth where their wives were sitting. “Trust me. You’re going to like it.”

He knew that much was true – he could feel his cock thickening, threatening to become a full-blown hard-on.

The guys were getting up from their small table, and Laura was looking helplessly at Jenna, who was lifting a cherry to her lips and placing it suggestively between them. She looked up and gave them a warm smile, scooting into the booth so that a blonde guy could sit next to her.

Laura was not so quick on the draw, but Jenna must have told her to move or shot her a look, because she very suddenly was moving in, flustered.

And just like that, she had a dark-haired, younger-looking guy sitting next to her, his arm against hers, his mouth in a smarmy smile, his eyes hungrily taking her in.

Laura was smiling, but Chris could tell she was uncomfortable. She was looking around the bar, trying not to be too obvious about it. Chris boiled with frustration that she didn’t focus on the bar, almost as though the small walls at either end of the stairs made her feel like it was another location, not where he would be.

The guy was talking to her, smiling, and Laura turned to face him. Chris felt like a knife was plunged into his gut when her mouth broke into a wide smile at whatever he said, and she pushed her hair behind her ear.

Jealousy. It started to creep up from under his collar.

Rob was nodding. “Now,” he said, leaning over toward Chris. “That feeling you’re having, times about a hundred, when you watch her fuck some other guy.”

It felt like a traffic flare had lit up inside of his chest. Laura would never do that, so he would never know. No way Laura would ever let another guy touch her knee, put his mouth on hers, taste the plumpness of her lower lip.

No way she would let some other guy know what it was like to see her hair spread out above her like a halo, and her almond-colored eyes

open, consumed by her dark pupils, just inches from his face, her pussy wrapped around his cock and her body hardening beneath him as an orgasm boiled to life inside of her...

Chris scratched his neck. He was so hot, he wanted to take off his necktie, but he didn't want to be obvious.

Laura looked up at him at that moment, almost as if she had read his thoughts.

Relief fluttered over her face, then an almost apologetic expression. Then a twitch of a smile, and then, sending a poker of red heat through him, a look of devious mischief.

She returned her gaze to the guy next to her, leaning her head on her hand to face him and listen more intently.

Or pretend to.

He fumbled to get his phone out.

Rob shook his head, smiling.

What did he want to say to her?

"Tell her that's hot as fuck," Rob said, as though he, too were reading Chris's mind.

Chris typed, and stared for a moment at his message:

That's so hot.

Was he actually sending this to his wife?

He pressed send and stared at the screen.

Then he looked up.

If Laura had gotten the message, he didn't know: she didn't have her phone out.

The guy sitting next to Jenna was motioning for his friend to lean over to him.

Rob chuckled. "Heh. Probably Jenna just told that guy she's meeting someone here."

Chris felt a thrill, and then a sudden small fist of panic in his chest, as he played the scene out to its inevitable next steps: the guy hitting on Jenna was going to leave and go find another girl, but the friend, who had his arm on the table, close to Laura's, was not. He was going to stay with Laura,

keep trying to ply her... and what would Jenna do? Jenna was here for business.

Would she leave, leaving his wife with this guy?

The guy was turning back to Laura, his friend saying something to Jenna, but obviously getting ready to get up and leave.

Chris watched his wife's face as she listened to him. Nervousness, sure, a little bit. Her eyes went to Jenna, then back to Chris, but just as quickly back to her new friend.

What would she do?

Chris suddenly felt compelled to put an end to all of this. He hadn't talked about any of it with Laura, they had no rules, he had never really said she could *do* this.

He had never really thought that she *would*.

But here she was, obviously flirting with a guy, obviously not sending him packing, obviously not telling him she was married.

He squinted. He could see Jenna's hands, free of any jewelry.

Laura's left hand was hidden, she had it in her hair.

Jenna's guy was leaving. Jenna reached across the table and touched Laura's hand. She beckoned Laura close to her, and whispered something in her ear. She put her phone on the table and slid it across to Laura.

Laura nodded, looking a little confused. Jenna got up.

Chris stared at his wife, cooed up to a strange guy, clinking her glass against his.

Jenna stood up, straightening her short skirt, and flipped her hair around. She caught sight of Chris as she walked in the direction of the bathroom, and smiled.

"I wonder if she's going to go do that guy," Rob mused.

Chris tore his eyes away from his own wife. "Seriously?" he said, a little shocked.

Rob smiled and took a sip of his drink. "She might. She can be a real slut."

Chris felt his stomach drop again. He wasn't entirely sure how he felt about that: on the one hand, his cock was hard, but on the other, he wasn't sure how Rob could handle just watching his wife be an *actual* slut.

He put his eyes back on the table where his own wife was sitting with the guy. She had Jenna's phone in her hand and they were both looking at it.

Laura looked up and around the restaurant. As she did, she looked over at Chris.

It was his turn to have a moment of relief, as he read Laura's expression: she seemed to be checking to make sure he was okay with whatever she was doing.

He nodded, and Laura turned her attention back to the phone.

Chris felt another slip of control: what had he just nodded about? What was he giving his wife permission to do?

How far would Laura take this thing?

He looked at his phone, even though he could see for himself that his wife hadn't read the message or responded to it. Then he started to type.

[Me]: *how far are you going to take this?*

But his finger hovered over the send button.

Did he really want to know?

Of course she wouldn't take it all that far.

And if she did?

Did he want her not to? Or did he want her to do it?

He looked up at his wife. She was really huddled close to her new guy, and they were discussing something they were mutually looking at.

She was waving someone down now.

A guy. Another guy, a new guy, was stopping, leaning in to their table to hear them, they were talking excitedly, showing him the phone.

He was sitting down.

And Chris got it:

He was there. Jenna's real date.

Jenna was still in the bathroom.

Rob was smiling at him over the rim of his glass when he looked at him. Rob raised his eyebrows. What could he do? Jenna would do what Jenna would do.

Laura and her friend had clearly been entrusted with the task of getting Jenna's Tinder date to sit down and wait there with them. And Laura seemed to be throwing herself into the task with gusto.

Chris slipped his phone into his pocket without sending the message. He wanted to watch this play out.

But it was only a few minutes of watching Laura smile, and flirt, until he found his fingers pulling his phone out, and pressing send.

CHAPTER 9

After her third Negroni – her fourth drink, if you included the Cosmopolitan this guy had ordered her before coming over – Laura realized that she didn't know this guy's name.

He was dark-haired, very young, attractively fit. She didn't like his nose – it was too narrow – or the snarl of his lips. She didn't really like him much at all, not enough to do anything but flirt with him.

But she was getting a peculiar kind of thrill from doing just that while Chris watched her.

She could see him out of the corner of her eye. She could see that he was shifting on his bar stool staring at her, uncomfortable. At some point she had stolen a glance at her phone, seeing only his second message on her notifications:

how far are you going to take th...

How far *was* she going to take this? This guy, whatever his name was, had touched her knee twice.

Jenna had given them the assignment of waiting for her date. "I'm going to go fuck this guy real quick," Jenna had whispered just before her departure, and Laura had been just drunk enough that the statement took about a minute to work its way to her consciousness fully.

By then, she was able to control her face, and not look shocked.

She hoped.

She decided to keep it together by looking for the date.

Jenna wasn't *actually*, was she?

The hand on her knee was getting more insistent.

Laura felt like she had been thrown into an arena with a lion. The feeling came on quite suddenly, the danger of what she was doing, the fact that this guy was hitting on her and she would actually have to deal with that. She was going to have to tell him she was married, get him to stop. And she had been flirting with him shamelessly, but just for fun.

“Uh,” she said, as he moved his hand up to her mid-thigh. She pushed her own hand down to her leg. She leaned in close to him, so that Jenna’s date couldn’t hear. “I have to tell you something,” she said, in a low voice. “I can’t go there... I’m, uh, married.”

No-Name smiled. His hand stayed in place, his fingers moving on her thigh. “I saw the ring,” he said casually. “It’s not a problem for me.”

Laura pushed against his hand. “It’s a problem for me,” she said.

She wished Jenna would come back.

She suddenly wanted to get out of there, and at the same time, guilt was pouring right through her gut. Because the real reason she felt that way, if she was being honest, was not because she was married, not because she wanted to be particularly faithful.

The real reason was that she wasn’t attracted enough to this particular guy.

Jenna, to her relief, was coming toward the table. She was adjusting her skirt. Laura jerked her eyes toward her date, and smiled at him. “Here she comes,” she said sweetly.

“Marcus?” Jenna was saying, dropping into the booth as she leaned over to kiss him. “Hey, I hope you don’t mind, I ran into some old friends here, they were just leaving, though.”

Jenna looked over at her and winked.

Laura was temporarily speechless again, a state she found herself in a lot.

Then she saw her chance. She looked up at her husband, who was watching her from the bar. She pushed to the side, meaning to nudge the guy next to her gently. But she suddenly felt a little panicked and pushed harder. “Hey, get out, will you?” she said, “I gotta go.”

He got out, but he reached for her waist and tried to pull her toward him. “Hey, come on, have one more drink with me,” he said, as she wriggled, trying to get out of his grip.

Her phone which she was holding in her hand, began to vibrate. She looked at it. “Oh God,” she said, feigning being startled. “It’s... it’s him, I gotta...”

She trailed off, showing the screen of her phone to him. It read, “Hubby,” because they had entered it that way at the store with a jokey salesman.

The guy's eyes flitted across the screen, his disappointment registered on his face, with a flash of anger right before he shrugged and started to walk away.

She held the phone up to her ear. "Thanks for the drink," she called lamely after him, but it was so loud he probably didn't hear her.

"That was hot, now come over here."

It was Chris, but it was also *not* Chris: his voice had a commanding edge to it that sent a delicious electrical pulse through her body – one of those kinds that went straight through her core and into her pussy.

She looked behind her: the guy she had been talking to was headed toward the bathrooms, where his friend was emerging, smiling.

Wow. She supposed they would have a lot to talk about.

She hung up her phone and wriggled through the chairs and table to the bar, fairly relieved to be getting back to her husband.

She noticed Rob for the first time.

"Lookin' hot Mrs. Taylor," he said. "Want a drink?"

It was hard to believe Rob and Jenna. Laura rubbed her forehead. "I think I'm pretty drunk already," she said.

Chris slipped his hand around her waist and pulled her close to him. "I think we should go home," he said. He stood up behind her, and she felt the hard shape of his cock as it moved along her leg, against her ass, and then was snug against the swell of her bottom. "You look hot in those heels," he said to the back of her neck, through her hair. His breath moved over her neck, dragging the sparse, baby-fine hairs at her nape to attention.

Rob was smiling, rotating his chair to have a better view of his wife as she hit on her actual date. Laura couldn't help but stare at him a little: surely he *knew*, like everyone else, that Jenna had been in the bathroom for just the right amount of time to have gotten up to what she surely got up to?

And yet he not only seemed unperturbed by it, he seemed to be really enjoying himself.

Chris's hands were moving over her body, pulling her toward the door.

Maybe these things really did work out. Maybe a married couple really could live this kind of lifestyle and be perfectly content.

She spun around as she turned to let herself get pulled along by Chris toward the door. Jenna's foot was bare, her heels on the floor, and her foot

was already at work on the calf of her date. A man she had met on Tinder.

Laura turned away, and followed Chris, holding tight to his hand.

It was too much, what Jenna was doing. She didn't want to turn into a woman who had sex with two guys in one night.

Unease started to climb through her again.

"Where's the car?" Chris asked, turning around on her suddenly and pushing her into a brick wall to kiss her. His lips were warm, his mouth hungry, and she could feel that his cock was hard as he pressed against her: the passion in his embrace and his kiss was enough to make her not even feel the sharp scratch of the brick against her back, through the gossamer fabric of her dress.

He released her, and she dipped her hand into her purse to retrieve the keys.

She was too drunk to drive; she suspected he was, too. But she also knew that they weren't going to the car to drive.

*

"That was pretty wild," Chris said, his breath still ragged from the exertion of balancing on the edge of the passenger seat while pounding his wife like they were two teenagers out in a field with nowhere else to fuck. It had been an intense, quick, satisfying screw. His ears were ringing.

Laura smiled, pushing her hair from her face.

Chris looked at her. "Where'd you get this dress, anyway?"

Laura looked down at the dress. "Jenna... we went shopping..."

"It's hot," he said. "You looked hotter than Jenna when you walked in. I barely recognized you."

Laura looked over at him, her fingers against her lips.

"I don't know if I recognize myself," she said quietly.

Chris put a hand on her knee. "What do you mean?"

Laura shrugged.

"You still don't feel comfortable with this," Chris said. "Like, even tonight, where you just flirted with that guy?"

Laura looked out the window.

That wasn't it, not exactly. And she wished that Chris would home in on what it *was*, put it into words for her, say it so that she didn't have to.

“What?” Chris said, stroking her knee. Then he sighed when she didn’t answer. “Look. I don’t want you to do anything you’re uncomfortable with, Laura, for sure. It’s just... it’s kind of hard to understand because you seem... like, you seem like you like it. As much as I do.”

Laura sighed. “It’s not *that*,” she said, almost irritably. She was irritated with herself. Irritated because she knew what she wanted, but she didn’t have the guts to admit it or say it. Tonight’s problem wasn’t that she felt uncomfortable flirting with another guy.

He just wasn’t the right *kind* of guy.

“You feel guilty about it,” Chris said, as if he had discovered the answer.

Laura pressed her lips together. How could she tell Chris about her real desires: that she wanted to sleep with another guy only if he was a *black* guy? That she wanted to stray from their marriage for a very specific reason, and it was something that he couldn’t give her, because he just *wasn’t* black?

“Yeah,” she said, because it was only partly untrue. “I guess I still... it doesn’t sit quite right with me.”

Chris squeezed her knee. “Okay. Look. That’s totally cool, okay? Like I said, I don’t want you to do something you aren’t cool with. Okay? I’m just... I like it, I think it’s hot, I would be, you know.... interested in something a little more... real.”

He looked at her, and his face changed a little. Maybe he was surprised by the expression on her face.

“Anyway,” he said, his voice a little strange. “We don’t have to take it any further than this.”

Laura nodded.

“Not if you don’t want to,” he said.

Laura nodded again, and smiled, looking out the window.

He took out his phone and she glanced sideways to see that he was calling an Uber. She held her hand to her head. She was going to have a real snag in her day tomorrow, getting her car before work. She felt like she was back in college, out on a Wednesday, drunk, leaving her car in a parking lot.

Leaving her kids to make their own dinner and deal with all their own school stuff. Hoping the eldest really was old enough to be a responsible

babysitter.

So irresponsible.

“But if you decide you want to...” Chris was saying, typing on his phone. He looked over at her and winked.

Laura knew Chris was talking like that because he really believed that she wasn’t into it.

She looked out into the parking lot, a sinking feeling moving through her torso. Another couple was stumbling through the cars, laughing. Some of this felt so *good*, after so many years of housecleaning and handwashing and talking about children and soccer: having an adrenaline rush that didn’t come from watching a kid almost break his arm or run a fever of 104 or some cookies burn just before a birthday party. Being out, being drunk, being high on something *bad*.

She looked over at Chris.

How bad did he really want her to be? Really?

She knew she should tell him the truth. Tell him that there was no telling, if there had been a different *kind* of man next to her tonight, things might have gone further than they did. That if he really was giving her permission, there was a chance she might take it – if the right guy came along.

But how could she tell Chris that she was attracted to a kind of man that was nothing like him? How would he take that?

She had her mouth open, ready to start the conversation, ready to take the plunge -

“Oh. Wow. That’s us,” Chris said.

And then he was opening the door.

And one thing she wasn’t going to do was talk about how she wanted to fuck a black guy, with an Uber driver listening in.

By the time they got home, she’d lost her nerve.

CHAPTER 10

“You should cut your hair like this,” Jenna said, lazily turning the pages of a fashion magazine while Laura stood by the microwave waiting for her lunch to warm up. She was on a serious health kick after all the nights of drinking and partying – brought on by crazy Jenna – that she had indulged in recently.

A health kick, and a determined mind-cleansing kick, in which she refused to think about black men and sex.

She had gotten on this kick after developing a minor porn habit. Minor, she told herself, because she had never had one before and had been able to cut herself off. But in fact, she had been creeping out of bed in the middle of the night and watching hours of porn.

Searching for the images that satisfied her the most, which usually took her a long time to find.

In a way, it was kind of satisfying to discover, in the recesses of the internet, that there were a lot of other people out there who had the same fetish in their minds. Because it was an entire section, and there were thousands and thousands of videos dedicated to some variant of exactly what she wanted to see, wanted to imagine...

wanted to do?

... black men fucking the holy shit out of white women.

But no more of that.

No more drinking on weekdays, or going out with Jenna or Rob or any variation of that theme, no more hours in the middle of the night spent searching for black cock, no more.

But then Jenna would show up, like this. And even though she was talking about haircuts and fingernail polish, she was like a siren on a bad island, tempting Laura to head her way, just to look...

The microwave beeped. Jenna held up the magazine, to a picture of a model who did look quite a bit like Laura, sporting a shoulder-length, sassy cut with bangs that parted in the middle and tapered into the hair.

Laura opened the microwave door.

“That is so hot. That would look really hot on you,” Jenna said.
“It’s... look, this model even looks like you. You should do it. Let’s do it.
We’ll go after work.”

Laura shook her head.

“What?” Jenna said, rolling her eyes. “Oh, right. Health kick. Listen, I solemnly swear we just get haircuts. I have an appointment already, I’ll just *ask* if Pablo can sneak you in, he is so good. And you really... look at this,” she whined, holding the picture up again.

It *was* a sexy cut.

Laura did kind of want to look like that....

Chances were, there wouldn’t be an opening.

“Fine, see if he has an opening.”

*

Pablo, it turned out, *did* have an opening, and it was at the exact same time, which is why Jenna suggested that they take Jenna’s car and Jenna would drop Laura off afterward, on the way home.

A sensible, logical savings on gas.

Laura was torn when she suggested it: it was a bad idea, and she knew it was. She could see the whole evening unfolding, with Jenna suggesting they go here or there after the haircut, saying it was out of her way to take Laura back to her car, telling her not to worry, just go for one drink...

And all of that was a very bad idea.

But worse yet, Laura could feel herself already giving in. Already “reluctantly” agreeing. Already wanting to go.

So when she was in the chair, her eyes closed, scissors snapping around her head, and Jenna said, “Whoa,” and tapped some more, Laura was already bracing herself for the next sentence. Already anticipating what it would be.

She was not at all surprised when it started:

“Okay. Laura, I *know* you said ‘no fun!’ and everything, but you will never *guess* who just texted me.”

She could guess. She didn’t know why, but she could guess. It was Jay.

Laura let the cool ache in her abdomen settle. She gripped the chair, keeping her eyes closed. Maybe if she just sat here, the universe would solve this problem for her.

“Look at that,” Jenna said.

Laura didn’t open her eyes. She knew Jenna had the phone held out to her.

“He’s asking about youuuuu,” Jenna sang, undeterred. “He wants to know if we’re free.”

Laura was silent. She knew she should do something, say something to stop this inevitable train wreck. Call her husband, run to her car, *something*.

“Oh come *ooooon*,” Jenna whined. “Take your new hair out, he can put us on the list for Red.”

She should ask Jenna if she couldn’t just go by herself.

Suggest that she take an Uber, because Jenna always got so drunk she couldn’t drive. She could park her car at work and take the Uber from there, and then Laura could get her own car and go home.

Remind Jenna that she had nothing to wear.

Tell her it was too far away. She had to take care of something at home.

Laura opened her eyes. Pablo was wrapping the final pieces of tinfoil into her hair. He had convinced her to dye it with an ombre, which she expected would be a mistake even though he claimed it was subtle.

By the time he got done it would be 8:30 or 9:00.

“Hand me my phone,” she said to Jenna, who clenched her fists in excitement.

Laura scowled. “I just have to tell...” her voice trailed off. She was going to say, tell Chris I’m going to be later than I thought for my hair.

Because of my hair.

Her mouth said the following, and it was a while before she fully understood that her brain had been the one to command it to do so.

“I’ll just see if that’s cool with Chris.”

*

Chris put away his phone, his heart fluttering with unease and excitement. Laura out with Jenna again. Alone with Jenna.

His excitement and his unease, he told himself, were both unwarranted. Laura had made it clear that she didn't want to actually take things any further with another guy, and he was supposed to trust her – he *did* trust her.

He both wanted her to keep that trust, and to break it. Whatever that meant.

And Jenna had a way of getting Laura to do things that Laura wasn't naturally inclined to do. Jenna was a dangerous friend. Chris thought of this both with pleasure – it was ripe with possibilities – and with nervousness – it was also ripe with potential disasters.

How the hell did Rob deal with this?

Where the hell was Rob right now anyway?

He sent him a text message, and within minutes they had plans to meet for a beer.

Rob took one look up and down at Chris as he approached the bar, and then lifted his enormous mug. He had asked to meet at Thirsty's, home of the 64 ounce beer, which evidently was the largest amount they could legally serve.

"You look like a man who knows his wife is out with my wife," Rob said, taking Chris by surprise.

Chris didn't know what to say about that.

Rob smiled. "Jenna is not the best influence," he admitted. He did not seem too broken-up about it.

Rob cracked a wry smile when Chris said nothing. "I think you kind of like that, though." He slapped Chris on the back. "I know where they're going," he confided.

Chris looked at his fingers. "I trust her," he said.

"We could go there and see what they're up to," Rob teased.

Chris's stomach twisted into a knot. The idea was more than appealing.

"Nah man, I just need something to do."

Rob nodded, and sipped his beer.

But he kept pressing, and it didn't really take much because deep down inside, that's exactly what Chris wanted to do.

By 9:45 he had agreed. It was a very good plan.
They celebrated with a shot.

*

The club the girls went to was the kind of place Chris had never stepped foot inside, even when he was younger. Rob had fished a silky shirt with a funky pattern out of his car, and Chris looked good in it but felt strange, and he was sure the shirt and his age were what combined together to keep them out of the club for a good hour, standing in line.

Who were all these people who could go clubbing on a Thursday night?

The bouncer waved gaggle after gaggle of girls past Rob and Chris, to the point that Chris was ready to give up, seeing the error in his plan and finding fault with his reasons for being there as he waited.

But Rob attached himself very skillfully to a group of girls, and soon they were being funneled into the club. It was dark, crowded, and enormous. Chris felt instantly lost.

He followed Rob to the bar, had a drink, and chatted emptily with the girls they had come with. The time ticked by, too slow at moments, too fast at others. Soon it was twelve o'clock, and he was still scanning the sea of people for his wife.

He went to the bathroom, thinking he should go home afterward.
And then there she was.

He had seen her, and passed over her, several times, each time his brain had started to tick somewhere deep inside with recognition. But he had kept moving through the crowd, looking for the wife he had this morning: Laura, long brown hair, slightly awkward, married to *him*, wearer of clothes you would most likely see on a first-grade teacher.

The woman he kept seeing as he scanned the dance floor and the surrounding banks of sofas and tables, including the VIP section, had shoulder-length hair, dark at the roots and growing lighter with the kind of fashionable dye job you see on celebrities. Her eyes were dark, smoky orbs. She was wearing a silver dress, her firm breasts on display at the collar, her long legs splayed out in front of her at an angle that looked like it had been

borrowed from a fashion magazine. Clunky heels pushed her knees up, even though one of her legs was pointed out straight.

Her lips, full and pouty, were a faded color, like lipstick had been kissed off. Or worse.

She was hot.

She looked trashy.

And she was leaning against a large black man, one of her hands in his huge paws, and laughing at something he was saying.

Chris was sucked into the scene. Everything around him disappeared: the noise grew muffled by the pounding of his own heart, and the flashing lights dimmed as his vision formed a tunnel straight to his wife and the man she was sitting next to. His hand dropped, resting on her knee, and she let it stay there. She seemed, Chris realized, as though that hand were familiar, even if it was resting on the middle of her bare thigh.

She took a drink from a table next to her, and, still leaning on the black man – who had taken up conversation with a guy next to him – she turned her head to the side and stared into the opposite recesses of the VIP lounge.

The expression on her face changed, from the laugh she had been giving with a wide smile, to a vacant look. A look of worry, but no ordinary kind of worry. She was stunned, her eyes dull, and behind them she was fretting about something.

And just like that, Chris knew. The worn-off lipstick, the tousled hair, the vacant look, the way she didn't even seem to recognize that a hand was in her lap. He wasn't sure *exactly* what he knew. Not the details of it, not Laura's feelings about it, not even his own.

But at that moment, he was sure of it:

Laura had crossed the line.

*

How long did he stand there, heart beating like a trapped animal in his chest? The blood was so loud in his ears that he could no longer hear the music as anything but a dull, persistent thud, slightly lower and slower than the thud of his own heart. Ice water ran through his veins; his jaw was clenched. Somehow he traveled down some steps, onto the dance floor,

through the damp, hot, moving flesh and sticky floors, as the light changed from blue, to red, to yellow, to red again, all without taking his eyes off his wife.

The hand was still on her leg, moving occasionally up, occasionally down. As he neared, her face came into clearer focus: her eyes were dark beneath the dark makeup. It was slightly smeared. Her lips were slightly puffy, her lipstick was smeared slightly beneath her lip. Her hair was damp at the roots, and a strand of it clung to her neck.

She took out her phone, and looked at it, perturbed, before putting it back.

Chris came to stand at the barrier between the raised floor and the dancefloor.

He was there a long time, contemplating his wife, who took her phone out a few times and put it away after frowning at it. And then, her head rotating slowly, her eyes not really seeing much of anything because she was so evidently deep in a troubling thought, she scanned over the crowd on the dance floor.

She kept going at first, not seeing him, but it was clear as a bell the moment his image reached her consciousness. Her head almost snapped as she turned back to where he was standing, and she seemed to turn to stone. Chris himself could almost feel the ice-cold chill that must have overtaken her.

Caught.

It's hard to say what exactly changed about her, after all, she was only sitting there. Her face did not change expression, but her flesh went pale and her eyes went dark with the wild, iris-consuming pupils of a deer in the headlights.

It was the appearance of someone who had been caught doing something, even if Chris could not say why, or what it was.

For a moment, they just stared at each other. This was a further testimony to Laura's guilt: had she seen him unexpectedly in an innocuous situation, wouldn't she have widened her eyes, smiled, come to the barrier to meet him and ask him why he was there?

But Laura did no such thing; in fact, she did nothing at all. She just froze, and her pulse beat so wildly in her neck that she seemed to have a small bird trapped in her throat.

Chris, who would not have wanted to admit that, in his own perverse way, he was thoroughly enjoying this moment, just stared at her. Until finally, finally, Laura took the black hand on her thigh as though it were an accessory resting in her lap, and placed it on the man's knee. This caught his attention, they exchanged a few words, and Laura started to stand up.

As she did, the black man's gaze searched their surroundings for whatever had rattled his... his what? "Friend?" Target? Date?

Lover?

His eyes met Chris's, and another surge of adrenaline coursed through Chris's veins, red hot as he remained still and fought the urge to look away, or to move with all the pent-up energy inside of him.

A hint of a smile turned up the corners of the guy's mouth, and he lifted his hand to stroke the back of Laura's leg as she crossed in front of him. He met Chris's eyes again after she passed, and then, with a cross between a smile and a snarl, he made a movement of his head that was meant to imply indifference, and turned back to the man he had been talking to.

Chris turned and walked along the raised platform to where the steps emptied onto the dancefloor. Laura was already descending them.

He stood in front of her after pushing his way through the crowd.

She looked like she might be about to cry.

His heart sank to his feet. Anger, jealousy, and arousal were bubbling inside of him as such a confusing brew that his skin itched and he wanted only one thing, no matter what it was that Laura was about to tell him or not tell him, do or not do.

She took a final step onto the dancefloor. Her heels were so high it put her almost level with Chris, who was still standing, looking at her, with what he realized must have seemed like a cold stare. He moved close to her, sliding a hand around her waist. He put his hand between her legs, moving it upward, not caring that they were in public – no one could see, anyway, there were so many people now, and all of them were minding their own, similar business.

"What did you do?" he said.

He said it quietly, the music drowning it out completely.

But Laura must have been so expecting the question, knowing that it was the question she would have to answer for, that she didn't even appear

confused. She just pressed her lips together, and her eyes grew wet, and she tipped her head slightly to the side.

“I’m sorry,” he thought she said. As quietly as he had, but it was as if she had yelled into his ear.

His cock throbbed.

His fingers found her panties: damp, but not dripping wet. Had she fucked this guy? Or something else -

It came to him quite clearly: the smeared lipstick, the slightly puffed lips.

No.

Not Laura.

He reached for her lips with his free hand, and touched them. Laura stared at him, not moving, letting him tug on her lower lip, her eyes growing wetter, the story emerging with no sound and no admission from her.

The little slut.

She’d sucked his cock.

And to judge by the look of things, she’d done it recently.

Recently enough, he wondered, that some trace of cum was still on her lips?

Thoughts went through his head in flashes: not Laura, Laura didn’t like giving head, Laura would never swallow, though, Laura this, Laura that...

But the evidence was all in front of him, and he *knew*.

He moved his hand to the back of her head so she couldn’t escape. And then he pulled her to him, and enveloped her mouth in his.

Her lips were slightly dry, but her mouth was wet, cool as though she had just sipped on something cold. It turned warm as he pushed his tongue inside of her.

It hit him through his nose, then his mouth, as he pulled away to meet her eyes again. A briny, slightly bleachy scent: one odor in the perfume of sex, isolated, lonely in her mouth.

Cum.

Not strong, not as though he had really tasted it. But it was lingering there in her mouth.

She looked stunned.

He realized that he was smiling. He turned her by pushing on her leg, and then got her in front of him, his fingers on the small of her back. The dress she was wearing hugged her small round ass and made it look even hotter than it actually was.

Into a hallway that he suspected led to the bathrooms, a long corridor with people who were obviously up to nothing good or different than what they were doing, mingling and pushing past each other. Ignoring them, he grabbed her waist and spun her around suddenly. The music was muted, now they could hear the voices of other patrons, giggling, kissing, talking about nonsense. He pushed her against the wall, his hand working under the scratchy hem of the glittery skirt.

His mouth was next to her lips. "What did you do?" he repeated, but now he smiled so that she would tell him, so she would know that he knew anyway, that... perhaps unbelievably, even to himself, it was okay.

It was not okay, not completely, but he would sort that out later.

Laura was too stunned to move. He had his thumb at the center of her panties, the rest of his hand squeezing her thigh. Her legs were trembling slightly, and her body jolted when he rubbed his thumbnail over the soaked material of her panties.

"I didn't fuck him," she said plainly. "I... things got out of control."

"I can see that," he said. He used his thumb to pull her panties away from her pussy lips. The tip of his thumb was coated with a viscous glob of her juices. "Tell me what you did."

Laura was white again, her skin growing visibly paler even in the strange red light of the hallway.

"Did you suck his cock?" Chris pressed, and he realized, as he did, that he *wanted* to hear her say yes. For this to be really true. For his wife to have crossed the line, for her to have done it in such a bad way... for her to feel bad about it.

Because, he realized deliciously, and somewhere in the back of his mind – if Laura felt guilty then he could probably get her to do something else he wanted.

Her clit pulsed when his finger touched it. He pushed against it hard and her body rippled.

"Did you suck his cock, Laura?"

She nodded, her hair stuck to the wall.

She looked so different, he could almost believe it wasn't her, except for the feel of her pussy at his fingertips, the weight of her breasts, the shape of her legs.

He took in a breath and it burned like fire with anticipation. His cock pulsed against her body as he thought about his next words:

“Did he come in your mouth?”

He brought his hand up to her lips again, and pulled gently on her lower lip. Laura said nothing: she knew, as well as he did, that he already had his answer. He tugged her jaw down gently.

“Did you swallow?”

Her body shook again. His fingers sank into her pussy, which was so wet and hot he suspected that she must have come; maybe he had even fucked her.

Laura closed her eyes, and with that, her admission was complete. But she went further, and nodded, her eyes shut to his reaction, her filthy, cum-stained mouth open.

He started to rhythmically rub her clit, and she just stood there, against the wall, her legs falling slightly more open, her eyes closed, and let him. He could feel her abdomen spasming as her orgasm built up – very quickly, as if she had been left dangling by her man before, and Chris wondered if she had.

The image of the black man bubbled up in his mind, and staring at his wife's open mouth, the bleach-brine scent of cum grew – probably in his imagination more than anything – and he pictured her lips wrapped around the thick, veined meat of the man who had stared him down. He pictured his wife's throat open, white cum splashing against the back of it, welling up in her cheeks, dribbling down her lips as the long rubbery snake of a semi-flaccid, emptied cock slowly slid from her stretched mouth.

Laura's body shuddered, and her pussy spewed hot liquid around his fingers.

He wanted to fuck her right there, and for a brief moment he thought he could without anyone noticing. He kept pulling her skirt up, as though he were going to really do it.

But it wasn't possible, he realized, and he had a better idea as soon as he had that one.

He tugged her skirt down. “Where?” he said.

Laura's eyes opened, and she looked confused. "What?"

"Where. Where did you suck his cock?"

She looked at him for a moment, and they exchanged a moment of complicity: Laura seemed relieved, she seemed to get what he was driving at as soon as he said it. He thought he even saw the trace of a smile at the corner of her mouth.

So it was Laura who led him down the hallway, Laura who turned and then turned again. Laura who backed herself up against him and laid her head back on his shoulder, her hands on his thighs, in front of a closed door. "Just wait a minute," she said.

His cock throbbed against her ass, surely she felt it and that's why her mouth was smiling, at least as he saw it from the angle of his view.

The door opened after what seemed like an eternity, and several girls spilled out, giggling, sniffing, one of them rolling her eyes at them. Laura went into the room – a bathroom bathed in red light - and he followed.

She shut the door and locked it, and the music was further muffled.

She stared at him for a moment.

He was about to say something when she slid down, her hands on his jeans, unfastening the button, another hand on his hard cock through the material. She sat on the toilet lid; he looked down as she took his cock out, and she looked up at him.

And then, with her eyes still locked on his, she wrapped her lips around his cock, and took him deep into her throat.

He stared at her, his mind overwriting the image before him with only one major change: the dick between her lips was another man's. A black cock, thicker, making her gag as she was right now.

It didn't take long for him to feel the strain of his orgasm at the base of his cock, and he reached toward Laura, but she showed no sign of stopping: she took him deep into her throat, where he could feel the silky soft back of her throat, and her eyes fluttered open to meet his just as the spurts of cum shot against her throat and filled her with his own liquid.

He sucked in his breath and bucked as he felt a spasm around the tip of his dick.

His wife, swallowing his cum.

Another spurt, another spasm, and Laura's eyes watered as she slowly sucked her way up to the tip of his cock.

Her eyes on his the whole time.

Her hand was still balled around the base of his cock. He twitched as his crown passed over her puffy lower lip, and a final drop of cum oozed out.

He watched, trembling and spent, as his wife's tongue mopped it up from her lip.

She rose slowly, dropping her eyes.

Then she looked up.

"I don't know how it happened. I... Jenna... it seemed like, maybe you would be okay with -"

He put a finger against her lips. "It's okay," he said, because he could see that she was maybe going to cry. In truth, he felt unsettled, but he knew it wasn't entirely fair. He had wanted this, and he had sent her signals that he did. He had then relied on faith alone that his wife would not give into that. He also hadn't expected her – even if he had fantasized about it – to be such a slut. To suck a guy's cock – a *black guy's cock* – in a seedy bathroom.

The door boomed behind them with three sharp knocks.

"To be continued," he said and he kissed her.

A bleachy scent – his own, this time, met his nostrils and his lips. Bitter salt assailed his tongue.

He opened the door. Some obviously gay guys smiled and sneered past them to pile into the bathroom, a bag of white powder unabashedly waving around in the air.

He walked with Laura's hand in his, Laura behind him, in a daze, out to the dancefloor and through it.

Laura.

His Laura.

Sucking cock in a public bathroom.

Swallowing cum from a big, black cock.

Laura.

He gave his lower lip a sharp bite. Just to make sure this wasn't a dream.

Or a nightmare.

A coppery, even saltier taste drained from his throbbing lip into his mouth.

Nope.

It would appear this was real life.

CHAPTER 11

She was relieved, wasn't she?

She had admitted everything to Chris, and he had forgiven her.

He had liked her hair. He had fucked her brains out, and she had come harder than she ever had in her life. He was proud of her for doing something so wild, so unlike herself.

"I just didn't expect it," he had said. "After what you said at the bar..."

And she had confessed. Confessed that she was attracted to black guys. Attracted enough that she wanted to do this thing that Jenna and Rob did. She couldn't even remember what she had said, because she had been so nervous saying it. Her chest had been tight, the words stumbling from her mouth, her ears listening and almost unable to believe what she was saying, as if her ears belonged to one person and her mouth to another.

Then the wet ringing of silence.

Then Chris smiling. "Is that *all*?"

He had thought it was something else, something bigger, he was okay with this. Maybe they should set up some rules, be more honest with each other from here on out.

He said it was what they both wanted.

Or, at least, that's what she remembered from the conversation.

Relief had welled up inside of her, and was welcome, because she had been sitting in that club feeling like her whole life was probably going to come crashing down around her. She had no idea why she had done what she had done: it had all just happened. They were going down the hallway, he was pushing her into a bathroom, she was sitting on a toilet seat and she had the biggest cock she'd ever seen in her hands and instead of thinking about her husband or her marriage she had been staring at it, feeling it pulse under her palm, and thinking about how it was going to taste.

It had been dry, the feel of his skin hot and silky. He had smelled different: clean and soapy, manly and musky, but all of it in a much different way than Chris. The surface of his cock was bumpy with straining veins, all in different places. And it curved a little upward, which sent a

shiver of delight for the potential of such an instrument: the way it would hook inside of her, rub against the root of her clit.

Before she had known what was happening, or who instigated it, he had his cock in his own hand and her fingers were exploring the surface of his balls, the scratchy, Brillo-pad feel of his coarse, tightly curled pubic hair. And his cock was against her lips, sticking slightly to her lipstick, dragging it across her mouth, onto her skin.

A bitter, watery salt spread across her lower lip, draining into her mouth, a small taste of what was to come. The taste of cum was generally revolting to her: she never swallowed, and she rarely gave Chris head. But as soon as she tasted Jay's bead of pre-cum, even though it was just as bitter and salty as Chris's, she knew she was going to swallow it.

Her pussy had throbbed at the thought.

She knew, as Jay drew the fat bulb of his crown over her lips, back and forth, that she should be feeling guilty. She should have been seized by guilt as every second passed and it was clear that this was her reality, she had crossed the line, and another man's cock was on her lips.

Instead, she had moved her hand back to the base of Jay's cock, and subconsciously measured the girth of him. Her pussy had clenched again as she realized she had never felt a man that large. Her tongue explored the tip of his cock, the ridge and hole, the shape of a completely different man.

"Look up at me, baby," she heard Jay say, and the submissive humiliation of doing such a thing rolled through her first as a thought, and then as real life when she lifted her eyes and met his. He was staring down at her, his mouth half-open, his eyes consumed with dominance and sex.

But he never put his hand on the back of her head, even if secretly she had wanted him to. If he had done that, she probably could have told herself that what happened next was less her doing than it was.

She opened her mouth, and *she* pressed forward, keeping her eyes on his as her jaw stretched wide, so wide that she couldn't believe it. She imagined what she must have looked like, her entire mouth filled with black cock, and instead of making her ashamed, it turned her on.

Jay was just staring down at her, commanding her with his eyes.

His head hit the back of her throat, and her eyes watered as she tried to suppress a gag. She was unsuccessful, but when Jay's mouth turned up at the corners, she remembered all at once all of the moments she'd lived,

things guys had said in her presence, videos she had watched, articles she had read... and though she'd never really thought about it before, she realized: he liked it. He liked her gagging.

And for some reason, she wanted to do that. So she had gripped his cock and started to move her head back and forth, his cock stretching her jaw so wide it was sore. She could only take about half of him in her mouth on the first few tries, and then he would hit the back of her throat and she would gag. His mouth was still slack, his eyes still consumed, but pleasure raised the corners of his lips each time she emitted a cacking gag.

Each time, she tried to get further, to ease more of his cock down her throat. Inch by inch, his gaze and his cock humiliating her, her pussy pulsing with a pleasure she had never felt as intensely before. She was actually *craving* for him to push her head onto his cock, to feel it just pop into her throat further than she could get it on her own. While he looked at her, staring her down, dominating her.

Her jaw was sore and she pulled his cock from her mouth. A long thread of thick spit hung between the tip of his dick and her mouth, sinking slowly, like a heavy wire, until it collapsed on her lap. She was panting for breath, her eyes lowered to look at his cock.

As she caught her breath, he put his hand on the back of her head. It was heavy, and she tingled at the scalp thinking of the force coiled inside of it. He pushed her gently but firmly, down, down, past where she had gone, and then tugged her by her hair to pull her away.

His hand had cupped her whole head, as though he were palming a ball. He pushed her toward him, and at the same time had begun to move his hips. She had given herself over to it with undeniable pleasure. Again, she lifted her eyes, and again his bore into hers. His cock punched the back of her throat and she gagged with each thrust into her mouth. Her lips felt tight, like they could split, and her jaw ached. But she wanted to please him, wanted to be used like that: all of it was coursing through her straight to her pussy, where she ached for more.

When he came, he pushed himself deep inside of her. Still not all the way: she couldn't take him all. She gagged as his seed sprayed against the back of her throat, and his cum spluttered up and into her mouth, onto her lips, down to her chin. Another hard spurt against her throat, and another.

His hand firm on the back of her head, her eyes watering, a smile forming on his lips. “Drink it up, little girl. That’s it.”

Her pussy throbbed.

He had stepped back, his cock slithering out of her mouth, slightly softened, still twitching. He had paused at her lips to smear his cum over them, watching her as though he were creating a painting. Then he had stepped backward, cock still in his hand, and leaned against the door, watching her.

He hadn’t needed to say anything for her to know what he wanted, but she waited for him to jerk his chin and command her. “Spread your legs, touch yourself,” he said, his eyes between her legs.

And so she had. She had spread her legs, pulled her panties aside, and started to play with her clit.

“Wider,” he had breathed. “I can’t see.”

The sloshing of her pussy was audible over the throb of music from outside the door. “Wait your goddamn turn,” he had growled, when someone banged on the door, never taking his eyes off her pussy and her fingers.

It took her no time at all. The orgasm shuddered through her, gripping and violent.

It was the best orgasm she’d ever had in her life.

And it was also, strangely, unsatisfying.

Her eyes had fallen to Jay’s cock when she came, and she was thinking about how the thick ridge of his crown would catch against the cusp of her vagina, how the curve would rub against her clit.

And then they were getting dressed, and her pussy was so wet her juices were slick on her thighs.

She could feel it as she walked to the VIP lounge, lubricating the contact between her thighs. Jay’s cum was still salty in her mouth when she sat down and picked up her Negroni.

He winked at her, and put a hand on her knee.

And it wasn’t until that moment that everything suddenly came into focus for a second before blurring away: she was a cheating wife, and she had just given a man a blowjob in a bathroom, and he had treated her like a whore.

And she had liked it.

But now she hated herself.
And then, suddenly:
Her husband was standing in front of her.

*

Laura's relief, somehow, turned sour.

She had asked Chris more than five times if he was okay with what had happened. The conversation went as it typically did in their marriage when she needed reassurance about something: he began sincerely, became annoyed that she kept asking him about it, and then was tired of the question being repeated over and over again.

She was annoyed with herself for asking it over and over again. Why was she so weak that she needed so much reassurance from him? He had said he was okay with it, and she believed him. He had told her it turned him on, and she believed him.

It took a while, and then she finally realized:

It wasn't reassurance she was looking for.

She didn't *want* Chris to be okay with it.

That's what was bothering her. How could he just be okay with her sucking some guy off in a bathroom?

She was barely okay with it herself. After the buzz had worn off, and her high had gone away, and she and Chris had made love and she came down to earth, she was mortified by what she had done. Sucking a guy off in a nightclub bathroom? Masturbating in front of him on a public toilet? In the middle of the week? She was a *mother*; she was *married*; she couldn't be swallowing the cum of some guy she just met and gagging for his cock and *thinking* about him fucking her pussy as full of cum as he had filled up her mouth.

And her husband should be more... something.

*

"Jealous," Jenna said, simply, when Laura had finally decided to confide to her. She was putting on mascara, which Jenna managed to do without opening her mouth strangely like all women did. She put the brush

back into the container with a plop and carefully rubbed a tiny stray dot of the black goop from the corner of her eye.

Jenna, unlike Laura, had been unrepentantly excited that Laura had disappeared into the bathroom with Jay.

“So,” she had said, sitting on Laura’s desk in the late morning, flipping a manual closed and losing Laura’s place in her work. “How was it?”

Laura had not even bothered to feign innocence. There was no feigning anything with Jenna. Jay had probably told her everything, anyway.

Laura looked around, and her face got flushed. It was one thing to be a huge slut, and another to have Jenna loudly talking about it at her cubicle.

“Shhh!” she hissed, and unintentionally was louder than Jenna was, drawing some eyes over the walls of the cubicles. She waited until everyone was looking down at their work. Jenna laughed silently and looked down at Laura with her eyebrows arched expectantly.

“I’ll talk to you about it over drinks,” she said, looking around.

Jenna rolled her eyes. “But you did it, right? Tell me you did it.”

Laura focused on her screen, her face getting hot. The truth was, she *wanted* to talk to Jenna about it. She just didn’t want to do it here.

Jenna leaned over toward Laura. “Jay has *such* a good co-”

“Jenna!” Laura hissed.

“Okay, okay,” Jenna laughed, and she flipped the manual open – miraculously, to the right page – as she hopped off the desk. “Drinks, though. After work.”

Laura looked up at her to nod, and Jenna was making a c-shape with her hand, smiling, which of course Laura could not confuse for anything but a measurement of the girth of Jay’s dick. It seemed incredibly accurate.

She turned back to her computer, neck burning, and tried to focus on her work. There was no denying, however much she would have liked to, that even this brief and shallow discussion of Jay and what had happened had stirred her deep inside, and her underwear were wet, and her pussy ached for relief.

“Jesus,” she whispered.

CHAPTER 12

Chris had decided that he would let Laura take the lead with regard to their new lifestyle.

There were times when the thought of what she had done would strike him with venom. In the shower, driving to work, out of nowhere:

Laura.

His Laura, little miss honesty-and-integrity. Miss neat-and-tidy. She had done a very, very bad thing in a very bad place. Really done it.

In those moments, he would feel the closure of something around his chest, constricting him. Who was his wife? She was like another person, if he thought of her like that.

But then the familiar other feelings would creep in: his cock would get hard, his mouth would almost water, and his mind would piece together the scene as she had described it to him. And he would feel a similar grip on his chest, but this was the grip of desire.

He went in circles enough times about all of it to make him decide to make a decision. That was the kind of guy Chris was, and once made, he could free up his mind for other things. The decision was to let Laura decide what she wanted to do next.

And sure, in some ways he felt as though he had placed his heart under an anvil, or his balls in a vice that Laura had her hand on, but it was only fair that she be the one with all the power to decide what she wanted to do next. She didn't seem to want to take things any further, and that was as gratifying as it was frustrating.

A week went by, maybe two. Things between them seemed normal. They had sex more than usual, and he had no idea what was going through her head, but her pussy was wet every time before he even touched her, and he could imagine that same salty cum-taste in her mouth every time he kissed her. Their sex was wild, unbridled, and it was so fun that for a while he didn't even *think* about why.

Why had he started to become suspicious? He couldn't remember. Something about the distraction in her eyes. The fact that she fucked with them closed, as though she were thinking of something else.

She came home late from work one night. She seemed to not want to kiss him. She hurried to the bathroom and brushed her teeth, an odd variation on her usual habits, and one that fit in darkly with the dark thoughts he was having about her being out, sucking on Jay's cock again.

When he tasted her lips they were minty from the toothpaste. He pushed his tongue into her mouth to explore it, finding only the sharp sting of mint, the cool of the water she had rinsed with... and faintly beneath it, the burn of alcohol.

"Why were you late?" he had asked her.

And she had waved her hand dismissively. "Just some files."

But when he had pressed, cocked his head slightly, and then narrowed his eyes to ask her if she'd had a drink, she had looked up at him. She had met his eyes, the brown of hers glittering behind a thick helping of mascara, which was different as well.

"Oh, right," she had said, without looking away. Her full lips parted, turned up slightly in a smile that seemed a little wicked. "Well, I caught a drink with Jenna."

Of course, his neck hair had bristled and his skin had crawled, but he couldn't say anything to that. Not without sounding like a psycho or a middle-school girl looking for a fight. The fact remained, nonetheless: if she had gone out for a drink with Jenna, wouldn't she have said that? How does someone "oh, yeah," go out on a date with Jenna?

So it seemed like a lie, and something burned in his gut thinking about it. But he couldn't confront her about it.

And then came the text.

[Laura]: *Jenna and I are going out tonight. Don't wait up.*

Seven pm, on a Friday. He was already home.

It was fine, of course: there was nothing planned, the kids didn't need a babysitter, there was no reason she couldn't go out.

But it was so atypical of her to not even *ask*.

And with Jenna.

His groin went cold, his cock twitched to life.

With Jenna.

He typed:

[Me]: *going back for more?*

He had sent it before he could stop himself, and he stared at what he had written.

It was a joke, at least a half-joke, and he hoped Laura would take it as a joke and not get offended by what he said.

Or maybe she would take it as a hint to actually go back for more, which was fun to think about, even as he felt like he was in freefall.

The free-fall continued, amplifying, as the minutes ticked by with no response from his wife. It was almost half an hour before she answered.

[Laura]: *maybe something different*

He stared at her message.

Something different, like... sex with the same guy? Or something different, like a new guy? What the hell was Laura doing?

No, she couldn't be that devious, or mean any of those things.

He smiled.

[Me]: *Where you going? Maybe I can come watch.*

This, too, he would think later, he had meant mostly as a joke. He only half-imagined that Laura would ever take such a suggestion seriously.

Although she had done this very bad thing -

His phone vibrated, and a picture appeared on the screen.

It was the interior of a very crowded bar, one he had never been to. He squinted at the picture, trying to make something out in the small, blurred details, that would give him a clue where it was.

He scanned the bar quickly, searching for his wife, searching for what she was trying to tell him with the picture. But there was nothing there.

He read back through their messages. Was this the answer to his last question? Why so cryptic?

[Me]: *Where's that?*

He typed.

But there was no reply – at least not for about thirty minutes. So long that he stared at the phone, then set it down, then stopped looking at it, and even managed to leave it while he ran to the kitchen for a snack.

Still nothing.

And then, another photo.

He had to stare at it for a long time before he could figure out what it was.

The dark skin of a thick forearm was draped over white flesh. Fingers splayed, caught in the moment just before closing around something.

No, the hand- a man's hand, clearly, by the size of it and the squareness of its fingers, was already on the skin.

He had another wave of cold sink through him:

Her skin.

Laura's skin.

Another tide of cold jealousy rose and fell inside of him when he figured out that it was part of her thigh. Her thigh exposed almost to her panties, the black hand on the middle of it. Casually, as if he owned it, fingers about to stroke her soft skin just at the inside of her leg.

His feelings rose and fell, hot and cold and then back again, as he stared at her message. He wanted to ask where she was again, but he didn't want to give in to his desperate side, to the need to *see* this all for himself.

After all, this was Laura's choice. He had decided so.

He just hadn't expected her to *make* it.

Another long period of time passed, and he did nothing except careen from one bad idea to the next, taking no action. He was tempted to call her, tempted to text Jenna, tempted to text Rob to get to Jenna, to ask Laura again where they were... but he did none of these things. He waited. And waited.

And nothing.

He broke, finally.

After all, they had never *agreed* to anything at all. And he had never *told* Laura that she could take the lead in these new adventures, he had only thought about it.

He texted:

[Me]: *Is that Jay?*

But there was no answer.

This was when the thoughts began to run wild, and his blood pressure began to rise. What would Laura do? And who did she think she was?

He had a terrible feeling, one that he had felt at some other point in his life, a time he couldn't quite place a finger on. It was the sensation of holding onto something, thinking all was okay, letting your grip loosen, and then suddenly having everything flying through your fingers, out of control.

His options swirled around him, and he felt at a loss of what to do: stay, and wait, and enjoy his wife's story when she came home? He didn't want to be desperate, or a pussy, or really even stop what was happening.

And then, in the middle of it all, he had a sudden moment of clarity.
Phonefinder.

Within moments, the app was working on his phone, and a red dot with a large, possible area, glowed from downtown. A moment later he was doing a reverse address lookup.

And then he was numb from the inside out, taking his keys from the hook, saying he had to step out for a moment, climbing into the car, watching the garage door rise in the mirror behind him.

1200 Center Avenue.

The Center Avenue Hilton.

Accurate to 100 yards.

Which certainly meant that there was a chance she was eating a sharwama at Nick The Greek's.

But the chance was very slim.

CHAPTER 13

There seemed to be little doubt there was any mistake about it. The red glow on the Phonefinder screen had not budged in two hours. There was nothing nearby that could keep Laura there for hours, except the interior of the Hilton, and whatever she was up to behind its closed doors.

Parked across the street, in a fortuitous space that had opened up on his fifth turn around the block, Chris stared at the yellowish stone, the windows in neat lines on each floor, all the way up to the sky, the lights and leather couches of the foyer visible behind the tinted, full story of glass on the facade.

He wanted an exit from this new reality, but in his heart – which was sinking through the floorboard of his car about then – he knew he was in the right place.

It was three in the morning now, the bars were closing and there were no bars in the blocks surrounding this hotel. He had texted Rob as his desperation had mounted, and found out that Jenna had not come home. Laura was almost certainly with her. And this is where they were.

He searched his mind, the depths of his soul, anywhere he could think of, for a reason that his wife might be at a hotel other than for the one reason that he both wanted and hated to think about.

He was furious.

He was also desperate to find out where she was, desperate to see inside the room where she was doing whatever she was doing. He was pulled to stop her, to stop this, whatever it was, before it destroyed their marriage.

But he was also tempted to see how far they could push things. He was practically salivating, however wrong it might have been, at the idea of seeing Laura – smelling, hearing, feeling Laura – as she let another man fuck her.

Which one did he want more?

He had his phone out, and he was calling her before he thought any more about it. Now he was just reacting, just swinging wildly, and her voicemail was answering, and he was falling, falling...

He didn't leave a message, he just stared into the building.

Had she looked at her phone and shown it to him, and laughed along with her new black lover at his desperation? Had she recounted this story to her lover Jay, who now knew that he was a silly man who let his wife suck cock in a club bathroom and then let her go out alone, again? Was Jay wondering right now how one man could be such a fucking cuckold?

He didn't even remember getting out of the car, such was his tunnel vision. He was illegally parked, and the thought flitted through his head and right back out again. The phone was somehow still in his hand. He turned it face up, looking at it and for a moment unable to recall what it was, what he wanted to see on it, why he was staring at it in the middle of the street.

But then it all came back to him: because he wanted to know where his wife was. He wanted to know what his wife was doing.

With a black man she had sucked off weeks ago.

At a hotel.

A car blared at him and he walked slowly again, the driver screaming obscenities behind him. It barely registered: he was walking into the glass-encased lobby.

He was scanning it. There seemed to be a lot of people there, for a hotel lobby at three am. Dressy people. Couples. A lot of drunks.

But no Laura. Not his wife, Laura, of the slight frame and the almond-colored eyes. His wife, who had been only his until recently, who he had foolishly let out of his sight, let explore something he maybe shouldn't have.

What was he doing here?

He collapsed into a couch and called Laura again. Her voicemail answered.

Panic rose inside of him and fell.

Then excitement, in the same way.

Some glossy brown hair caught his eyes for a moment, but the woman turned and he could see from her jarring profile that it was not the sweet red lips of his own wife – lips that were wrapped around another man's cock right now, maybe – or her cheekbones – being stroked by a dark finger from above as her head slid across the sheets in thrusts, headed to the headboard, where it would tap against it until she put her hand up to stop it.

The lobby nearly emptied, and then it filled up again, somehow, inexplicably, as though people were passing through it on their way to somewhere else.

Emptiness again in the lobby. A hotel clerk frowned at him when he looked up.

He was crossing to the desk, and he could feel that his face looked wild. The clerk looked down, and then up, and then back at him, and her frown increased. Her features became set: she had dealt with someone who looked like him before, and Chris knew before asking that she would be of no help.

But he found himself talking. “My wife...” he began, and then he started over. “I think my wife is here, but I can’t remember her room number. Can you look for Laura Taylor?”

The clerk stared him down.

“I know you can’t tell me her room number, but you could call her, right?”

“I’m afraid I can’t do that, sir.”

“But you could call her, just ring the room, tell her I’m down here?”

The woman was looking down at his phone.

Another clerk, one who was obviously in charge somehow, stepped to the side of her own station and joined the first. “Sir,” she said firmly. “Our guest lists are confidential. I’m sure you can understand. We have a lot of celebrities stay here and our discretion is very important to them.” Her eyes fell to the phone in his hand.

“Why don’t you call her again, on your phone?” she suggested.

She said it in a sincere way, which made the seconds that followed even more awkward, as the first clerk buried her gaze in her computer, and Chris felt his expression falling apart. She went a little white. Of course his wife wasn’t answering, here in a hotel, and they all knew why a wife wouldn’t answer the phone call of her husband if he was in the lobby of a hotel and she was in a room he didn’t know the number of.

Chris turned and started to walk toward the couches again. He sensed the movement of the clerks behind him, and figured they would probably decide he was going to make a scene and ask him to leave.

He was resigning himself to that fate, curious about how it would be done, and thinking about where he would wait for Laura, where he would

catch her, how it would feel when he did.

Another group of people were filling the lobby. They seemed to well up from underground somewhere.

And then he heard it. Among all the voices, the laughing, the faint puff of salsa music that had escaped from somewhere else: Laura's nervous laugh.

It was unmistakably hers.

He spun around, and his eyes were immediately upon Laura.

Laura with her arm looped through the crook of a large black man's arm. The man, oddly familiar, but definitely not the same man from the club. Laura tottered on high silver heels, as though her feet were sore, and she was encased in the same, tight black and white dress she had gone to the bar with Jenna in. Her long legs tensed with thoroughbred muscle tone, and her new hair clung to her neck where her skin was damp. A sheen of sweat covered her. She was looking down at the floor, her mouth open wide in her nervous laughter.

Jenna was behind her, arms linked with two men, one white and one black and both as fit as Laura's man.

Laura's man. His body felt like it was on fire.

He had somehow gotten into a couch, and Laura did not see him as the fivesome strolled up to the hotel clerks and separated into two groups.

Laura leaned on the counter, smiling, teetering a little with her drunkenness. She obtained a room key: Chris watched as the white card passed between the clerk's fingertips and Laura's. The black man had his hands on her waist, was edging himself closer to her, putting his mouth next to her ear.

In the meantime, Chris was only vaguely aware that he was standing up. Vaguely aware that his pulse was raging, his cock was hard, and that he was staring at them wildly.

But he felt as heavy as concrete, as incapable of moving. He simply stared as his wife spun around, one hand in the giant paw of her black date, the other holding the key. They backed away from the desk, fingers entwined, the man talking to Laura in low tones next to her ear.

Laura smiling. The two of them walking toward the elevators.

And Chris, still concrete, turning back to the front desk where Jenna was hooting away about her credit card with two guys rubbing their hands

all over her. The clerk saw him, saw that he hadn't moved, seemed to shrug it off.

And then Jenna was turning, looking at her key, dropping her hand.
Her eyes on Chris.

Her mouth fell open in an expression of fun-loving shock. She walked toward him jaw open, the corners of her mouth turning up with a devious, pleased smile. "Well, well, aren't we clever?" she said. She plopped into a couch across from him, setting her bag on her lap and smiling in disbelief. "How'd you find this place?"

She didn't wait for his answer, just turned up to the guys standing behind her and held up a finger. "Just a minute, guys, sorry. One of you get me a drink, though?"

Her attention back on Chris, she seemed to be waiting expectantly.
Chris was unable to talk.

Jenna took out her phone, without saying anything else to Chris, and held it up as though she had just received a very sweet video about cats. She smiled and typed something into the phone.

Then she dropped it in her purse and looked at Chris expectantly again.

"So," she said. "How *did* you find us?"

Laura was upstairs, Chris was thinking. Upstairs right at that moment, probably sliding the straps of her dress down her shoulders, big hands clamping down on them and pushing her to her knees...

He said nothing, unable to move.

In the corner of his eye, he thought he saw him coming, but it made no sense and so he stared at Jenna, who typed another message, as the man approached.

When the man sat down on the couch next to Jenna, Chris rotated his head to look at him. The big lips, the high cheekbones, the cool stare. A smattering of dark, rough stubble on a square jaw. The long, thick limbs, folded when he sat down in a way that made him look like a grown man in a kindergarten.

Now Chris really had no idea what to do.

Jenna, surreally, was typing on her phone again, with a smile on her face.

And there they sat, as one of Jenna's loverboys returned with a drink and put it in her hand. "Thank you," Jenna said, and dropped her phone into her purse again.

She stirred the drink and looked from the large black man next to her, to Chris. She almost seemed to expect one of them to handle the conversation, but once she took another sip and the silence continued, she set her drink down and looked at Chris.

"This wasn't really the *plan*," she said. "And I feel like you would have had more fun my way, but whatever."

Jenna fished into her purse and took out a room key, which she played with in her fingers. Chris stared at the plastic with uncomprehending eyes, mostly because he sensed Jenna wanted him to look at it. The events of the evening were not adding up, and he could not work out what she would do next.

Jenna put her hand on the black man's leg. "Tony here, have you met him?" Jenna paused only enough to smile. "He's the perfect guy for you two to start with."

Chris looked at Tony, who smiled, and even if it was perfunctory, it cut through a bit – just a bit – of his hardcore exterior.

Chris was still too stunned – and frankly, confused, to say anything.

Jenna rolled her eyes and waved room key like a miniature fan.

"Look," she said. "You can take this room key, and go upstairs, and stay with Laura yourself. Orrrr...." she purred, her eyes slanting over to Tony in a seductive glance, "and I think this is much more fun... you can give this key to Tony, and he can join you right after me and Tony have a drink."

Jenna put her hand on Tony's thigh, and rolled into his groin, where the unmistakable outline of a very large organ, semi-hard, was outlined beneath the fine fabric of his suit.

Tony smiled at Jenna, then looked at Chris.

"I won't let him go to waste," Jenna said. "But we're all already *here* and I've got enough to handle."

Chris blinked.

Tony put his hands together and leaned on his elbows. "Look, man," he said. "I'm available any time. So, give me the key or keep it." He smiled, and licked his lower lip. "Sometimes a little patience pays off, so I'm cool."

"Just do it," Jenna said devilishly. "You know you want to."

Chris looked at the plastic card. Jenna was twirling it in her fingers, moving it up and down the length of her digits with a dexterous twist.

“Wh, what...what would...” Chris managed to say.

Jenna laughed. “Tony here is a bull, Chris. What do you mean, what, what? He’s going to put this -” and here Jenna’s other hand massaged Tony’s crotch, and Chris was helpless not to look at it as her hands found the sizable appendage and made it twitch beneath the suit, “big, beautiful cock in her pussy while you watch.”

Chris looked at Tony, who gave him a slow nod.

“Lau...Laura’s, uh, into... it...?”

Jenna flipped the card, smiled, leaned her hand toward Tony. “I think we all know the answer to that question,” she said.

The card was going into Tony’s hand. Tony was looking at Chris, patiently, and Chris could sense that if he asked for the card Tony would give it to him. Not because he was a particularly soft man, or a good loser, but because he seemed to know that if he just waited, he would have his cock sunk into Laura’s cunt.

“Tell you what?” Jenna said. And then she gathered up steam, her hand stroking Tony more fervently. “You text me that it’s good to go ahead. And I will... ahem, entertain Tony here in the meantime.” She looked at Tony, winked, and then leaned over to Chris. “That way he’ll last longer,” she whispered.

“I last plenty long,” Tony said smoothly.

Jenna shrugged. “It’s just for fun.” She waved at Chris. “Listen, I am doing all the work for you here. You had better get me a fruit basket or something. Now, go, go! Shoo!”

And she started in on Tony, pulling him by his expensive purple tie toward herself.

Chris could hardly believe that he was rising as Jenna had ordered him to do. Asking her for the room number. Walking toward the elevator, pressing the button for the twelfth floor.

Knocking on the door.

Staring at Laura.

CHAPTER 14

Jenna's plan had seemed solid, like a good idea, even. Test the waters, make Chris jealous, see if he would be capable of handling Laura actually sleeping with another man.

Make him feel the way Laura felt he ought to, whatever that was. A little bit more jealous. A little bit less blasé.

It had been hard to turn Tony away at the elevator bank. He hadn't been putting the moves on her *really hard*, he was part of the plan. But he had certainly tried a little.

"Last chance," he had said in her ear. His hand was on her hip bone, fingers sweeping over her mound, the electric shudder he gave her impossible to conceal. They had spent the whole night dancing at the salsa club in the basement of the hotel, Tony's hard muscles under her palms, against her back, his hands swinging her around and moving her hips, making her spin like a doll.

And the whole time she had been overflowing in her panties, thinking about all the things he could do to her in bed. Wondering about the contours of his cock. Absorbing the heat of his ebony skin under the red lights in the dance club.

"Next time," Laura said, and Tony had pressed his lips together and given her the look of a panther entertaining himself with his prey. "Next time, then," he had growled, and she was pretty sure her juices were going to start spilling down her thighs.

They were slick when they rubbed against each other, compressed together by her tight skirt, as she walked unsteadily into the elevator. Tony's hungry eyes were the last thing she saw as the doors closed.

She had been unable to wait, throwing herself down on the bed and sliding her fingers into her panties.

When her phone buzzed she thought maybe it was Tony, and so she stopped and grabbed the phone, her neck sweaty, her pussy throbbing. She would have thrown everything out of the window at that moment, she knew, and so she almost threw the phone away from her as though it were a hot coal.

If it was him, she was going to let him come up here.

She could only resist things so much, and now her pussy ached and her blood was pounding through her wildly.

So when she saw Jenna's text (the beginnings of it):

[Jenna]: *you will never guess wh-*

She stared at the words, finishing the sentence with all kinds of possibilities. She would never guess who Jenna just saw? Who was here? Who wants to come back upstairs?

Maybe Jay. Maybe Tony.

As she held the phone in her trembling hands, afraid to look at the message, afraid of all the things she might do, Jenna's next message appeared with a buzz, and it froze Laura solid in an instant:

[Jenna]: *Chris!*

Laura sank to the floor, leaning against the foot of the bed.

She almost locked herself out of her phone opening the messages. Jenna kept going, a superhuman typist, the phone buzzing repeatedly because Jenna also loved to send many small texts instead of one large one:

[Jenna]: *turned around and there he was, in the lobby*

[Jenna]: *I sent a mssg to Tony he's coming back*

[Jenna]: *so I am going to ask Chris what he wants to do*

[Jenna]: *don't worry I think he's going to do it*

[Jenna]: *but also he looks jealous to me*

Laura pulled her skirt down and arranged herself, looking in the mirror, frantically walking around the room. She had no spare clothes; the idea had been to make everything look as authentic as possible.

How had Chris found her? Why was he here?

Her phone buzzed again.

[Jenna]: *here he comes. Tony will be by in a few, here's his number if you change your mind*

[Jenna]: *but don't*

[Jenna]: *oh ps Im going to suck his cock so he can go a nice long time. you're welcome*

Laura dropped the phone on the bed.

It was all so vulgar. So filthy and vulgar, she couldn't believe she was doing it. Any of it.

And yet:

There was no way to quench the craving she had. It was out of control – she was out of control – and so she stood there, breathing wildly, doing nothing.

Until there was a knock on the door.

*

Their eyes met when the door opened. The expression in Chris's eyes was wild, and she realized, as it burned slowly through her, that it was exactly what she had been looking for. The desire that had been burning inside of her for Tony seemed suddenly weak by comparison for what she felt for Chris in that moment.

"I was never going to do anything tonight," she said quietly.

But he was talking over her. "I gave him the key."

His hand was beneath her jaw, pushing her backward, his eyes still burning into hers. They kissed, passionately. He pushed her against the wall and his hands shot between her legs, where he found her wet panties, pulled them out and inserted a finger into her sloppy wet pussy.

Eyes still locked, though in the small passage to the rest of the room the light was dimmer.

"Do you want to do this thing?" he asked, still kissing her. "You want him to come up here and fuck you?"

His pointer and middle finger were inside of her, so she could not have lied to him anyway: her pussy pulsed and she inhaled sharply.

"He was just going home," she breathed, in a tortured whisper. The truth was that Chris was consuming her; consuming her thoughts of Tony, and now she was pulsing with a different desire – to see this look on Chris's

face while Tony's hard cock pistoned in and out of her. "I wasn't going to do anything with him."

"Oh yeah?" Chris said, pushing deeper inside of her. "But you are now, aren't you?"

He pushed up against her, and fingerfucked her slowly against the wall. For how long, she had no idea: he was obviously doing it just to make her wilder and not to make her come. It was so erotic she felt she might burst in his hands from just the intensity of the *thoughts* about what was to come.

And then he slowly, slowly, pulled his fingers from inside of her. She slumped against the wall, disappointed, her ears ringing.

He pushed back from the wall and surveyed her standing there, his wet fingers tracing the hem and the collar of her dress.

He pulled out his phone. "So do we go ahead?"

But she knew that before she nodded, he was already sending the message.

He kissed her again.

"So what do I do?" he asked.

Laura could not believe it, not when she felt like she did, but her nervous and uncontrollable laughter erupted. This made Chris smile. "I don't know," she said. She shook her head. "I really... just have no idea."

The laughter broke apart the tension for only a moment, and they were just solidifying into it again when the phone in Chris's hand buzzed.

"He's coming now," Chris said.

CHAPTER 15

He couldn't remember where he had seen it, or heard about it – was it from Rob? Or down a rabbithole on the internet? Porn? Or erotica? He wasn't sure. But Chris found himself sitting in the retro yellow chair – an uncomfortable rounded thing that had almost no back – and waiting. That was where he was going to sit, in relative obscurity, while Tony came in and led the show.

Laura had giggled nervously again, but Chris knew her well enough to know that it was her nerves. He might have even felt sorry for her if he had not felt for himself how aroused she was: if this was something Laura didn't want, her body was telling the best lie ever told.

She looked around, unsure of where to sit, and stood up, sat down, and stood back up again. As the time closed in around them, Laura became less giggly, but she also seemed to shift her focus from Chris, to thinking about Tony. She barely looked at Chris as she absentmindedly felt for a nonexistent zipper at the back of her dress, then readjusted herself, looked down at her body, and frowned, as if trying to decide something.

Tony knocked – the way a confident man knocks, a little tune, a little arrogant – and inserted the card almost as soon as he did. The click of the door made Chris's heart give a matching click, a jolt, really: there was no taking things back now.

He was in the room, filling up the entire doorway, then the hall, headed straight to Laura.

The contrast between them seemed suddenly unreal: Laura tall, but thin, and her skin particularly pale next to his. He reached for her hair, let it sift through his fingers, a confident smile that was almost a smirk on his face. He wet his lips by pressing them together. "Turns out that wasn't your last chance after all."

Chris could see Laura shudder, and the erotic shudder trembled through his own body as well. He could feel himself being sucked in, no longer felt uncomfortable. He was watching, almost as though he were not even there.

Laura shifted her eyes, suddenly, in Chris's direction. Tony, smiling, his head nodding slightly as though he were the kind of guy who did this every day for a living, reached for her chin to keep it in place.

"Don't you worry about him," he said in a low voice. "I'll tell him when to jump in."

He took a step closer to Laura as he said this, and his hands were on the straps of her dress, pulling them down her shoulders.

The tight dress peeled away from Laura, revealing the toned length of her pale body inch by inch. It was tantalizing to watch Tony's dark hands skimming the surface of her body as she stood there to be unwrapped. Her pulse fluttered in her throat, and her chest heaved slightly in rapid breaths that made her pink nipples bounce slightly. They were hard before he touched them.

When the dress was down to her thighs, he pushed her hands down to the folded material so that she could keep going, and she obeyed his suggested command silently as he unbuttoned his shirt, staring at her.

He tossed the shirt aside – somewhere downstairs the tie had been removed, and Chris speculated it was Jenna. He watched as Tony's large, menacing hands unbuckled his belt slowly, while Laura shimmied her dress to her feet.

She looked down, and started to step out of it, when Tony reached for her shoulder and steadied her in place. "Leave those shoes on," he said. "Leave them panties on, too."

And then Laura was sinking, sinking because Tony was pushing her down, down to her knees.

Chris had a nice view where he was, as Laura fell to her knees: she was wearing a racy thong, the black cutting deep into her small rounded bottom. No bra: just the expanse of her pale back, then her silky hair, and the dark hand now meshed in it.

Tony dropped his pants, and Laura put her hands on his hips to pull his underwear down. For a moment, the scene gave Chris an almost comical impression: Tony's cock seemed to jump out of the underwear like a Jack-In-The-Box: the bulb was thick and purple, the length of his dick semi-hard and unfurling the top-heavy crown.

Tony took it in his hand, though, and pointed it straight at Chris's wife, ending whatever trace of comedy was there. The fat cock pulsed in his

hand, and Laura, whose face he could see only at a sharp angle, looked down at it, transfixed. It thickened in Tony's hand when her lips came into contact with it.

And then it was being fed into her mouth, and disappearing inside. Tony pushed her by the back of the head toward his pelvis, and looked down at her, his eyebrows raised with what seemed to be amazement as her face came closer and closer to him.

Laura put one hand on his thigh, and another on his forearm, and lifted her eyes – Chris could only see the flutter of her eyelashes from where he was – as she was pushed forward.

“That’s it,” Tony said to her. “You gonna take it all?”

Laura kept going, and Chris could hear as she struggled to breathe, and then even her nostrils ceased to expel air – as they would; by now Tony's snake of a cock was in her throat, blocking all passage of air. Chris saw her stomach convulse slightly, and even though he could not see it for himself it was easy to imagine how her eyes welled up slightly, easy enough to imagine how it felt when her throat closed down on her gag reflex.

“Look. At. That,” Tony said, and he lifted his eyes to look at Chris, only briefly, but the interaction was both terrifying and wildly arousing. “I usually have to work a long time to get all the way in. Fuck, yeah baby, take it all.”

But Laura needed to breathe, and so she pulled back, a sticky sound filling the air, a slight gagging cack, and Tony looked down at her while she gasped.

But she was back at it almost immediately, all the way to the root of his dick.

Tony's fingers closed around handfuls of hair, his attention was consumed by what he was looking at: Laura, eyes up tracking Tony's piercing gaze, on her knees, the fat girth of Tony's cock filling her mouth, stretching her lips, puffing her cheeks.

It was Tony who – begrudgingly – pulled Laura's face away from his cock. “Shit,” he said. “You're gonna make me come again.” He put his hand around his shaft. “Just lick it,” he told Laura. “Put on a nice good show. There you go.”

Chris's insides flipped as he watched Laura's pink tongue making swirls on the head of Tony's cock. She traveled down the length of it as far

as she could before hitting his fist, and then closed her lips around the crown. Fat, wet smacks echoed in the room.

Tony released his grip on his cock, suddenly, and used both hands to push Laura's face closer to his pelvis. Chris watched his dick disappear into Laura's mouth again, and then stared as Tony held her head in place and began to rock his hips back and forth, fucking his beautiful wife Laura in the face.

Now Chris's cock hurt: his balls were blue, and he wanted to fuck his wife's face, too. Anything to make the pain stop.

But he didn't move, because he couldn't. He could only watch and listen to the wild slurps as Laura took it all.

Tony looked up at Chris, his lips parted, his stare intense. "She like to swallow?" he asked him. "Or should I come all over her face?"

Chris stared, and shook his head. He wasn't sure what he meant by that answer: the question was so improbable in his own experiences with Laura. He didn't care what she did. The idea of Laura swallowing Tony's cum was as appealing as watching thick ropes of it fall all over her face.

Tony seemed to have lost interest in Chris's answer anyway, he grasped Laura's head and fucked her as the orgasm built up in his muscles: his neck strained and he closed his eyes. He pushed deep into Laura's throat and groaned, then pulled out, grasping his cock and jerking off the last spurts at her face.

Laura was panting, falling to her heels, looking up at him, as ropes of cum fell into her hair, onto her cheek, and then onto her tits.

Tony gave a final groan, and a last blob of cum fell onto Laura's lips.

He stared down at her. "Swallow that first spurt," he told her. "You must be good and ready to come now, huh?"

Laura stayed on her knees, starting to bring a hand to her lips, which Tony swiped away. "Nah," he said, "lick that off."

Something constricted around Chris's chest as he watched Laura hesitate, but only for a moment, before her tongue left her mouth and traveled along her lower lip, swiping up Tony's cum and then retracting it into her mouth.

Tony smiled down at her, beckoning her with one hand to rise up to her knees, which Laura did almost like a puppet. He reached for her hair –

sticky with cum and sweat – and pushed it back tenderly. “Good girl,” he said. “You ready to come?”

Laura may have nodded; it didn’t matter because Tony seemed to know that Laura would be ready for whatever he decided she was ready for. He was already nodding, saying, “yeah you are,” and moving toward the bed.

He situated himself at the head of the bed, leaning against the headboard, casually stroking his dick and staring at Laura as she rose without any uncertainty, following Tony with her eyes the way a dedicated dog follows its master.

“Get on up here,” Tony said smoothly. “Crawl over here.”

Laura did as she was told, climbing to the bed and crawling toward Tony. Tony reached for her hair and had it gathered in his hand in a ponytail before she reached him. He pulled it back, exposing her throat and her tits and tilting her head back as he commanded her to get up on her knees.

“Now slide those panties off, get them down by your knees.”

Chris watched Laura peel her panties away from her hips, over her bottom, the fabric rolling down her smooth skin while Tony rested his hands menacingly on her hips. His palms were so large and his fingers so long that he could almost encircle Laura’s narrow waist. He suspended her there while she strained to push the panties down to her knees.

Tony’s eyes took in her pussy, her bush, her navel, and Chris saw that his cock was slowly pulsing back to life.

Chris was surprised when Tony suddenly and without warning spun Laura around, scooping her legs out from under her and tossing them forward in one quick move. She came to rest on her bottom between his legs, which he was pulling apart, leaning back against his chest, facing Chris.

Tony’s dark hand crawled over her chest and then up to her neck, splaying across her swan-like throat and holding her head against him. His eyes met Chris’s as his mouth moved close to Laura’s ear.

Laura’s legs, prompted by whatever Tony was saying, fell open, spreading wider the longer he talked. All the while Tony stared at Chris, and before long Chris understood what Tony was essentially telling him to do.

Chris’s gaze moved to his wife’s pussy, which she had recently trimmed up to no more than a landing strip (no doubt Jenna’s influence).

Her pussy lips were bare and swollen, her vulva red and glistening.

Chris rose and went to the bed, and Tony gave a grin that was half-menacing and half-approving as Chris knelt on the edge of the bed and surveyed the large black arms and legs in which his wife was entangled. A shudder traveled through him as he thought of Tony's cock thickening against Laura's back, right in the valley at the very top of her ass, against her tailbone, filling in the soft flesh, pulsing with desire.

Laura could not really look at him, because Tony had her neck tilted up and her head resting on his shoulder. Tony's other hand massaged Laura's left breast and his arm secured her against him.

Chris put his hands on Laura's thighs, and lowered his face to his wife's pussy. The scent of her juices had been hanging in the air in general but was now strong, tangy and sweet, almost enough to make Chris high.

Laura's thighs tightened against his hands when he used the tip of his tongue to taste the slick juices that coated her outer lips. When he flicked his tongue across her clit, he felt her convulse in Tony's arms, and when he began to roll his tongue against her hard button, Tony's legs wound around her calves and held her frozen in place. Chris could feel her straining against his grip, hear her squealing and making sounds that she had never made before, and her pussy emitted a pulse of juice with each twist she attempted to wrench against Tony's grip.

Chris was enjoying his newfound power, looking up at the hand that cradled his wife's neck and the arm that strapped her to the chest of another man. He began to tease her, rhythmically pulsing against her clit as she moaned in Tony's arms, her voice working to a crescendo. Just when she seemed ready to burst, he pulled away, and watched as her pussy throbbed and her thighs pushed against his hands.

He did this again and again, and Laura's pussy became so engorged and wet he thought it might actually burst like a ripe fruit. He could barely touch her without her going wild, and he enjoyed the simple power of making her pant and strain, and then letting her throb as painfully as he so often did, craving and never being released.

"That's cold," Tony said at one point. And then he tipped Laura's head to the right and nuzzled her neck. "That's okay, though, isn't it? Let him get you nice and wet, because I'm gonna fill that tight pussy up and fuck you full of my black cum."

Laura's pussy welled up, and Chris's cock throbbed painfully. He heard a sticky slosh as Laura squeezed herself from the inside out, trying desperately to come. It was tempting to let her suffer, and yet he also wanted to see how hard she might come, and what would come next.

Finally, he hooked his hands beneath her thighs and pulled her toward him, burying his tongue in her folds, then bringing his lower lip to the face of her clit and squeezing it gently between his lips, pushing on it even as she pressed so hard against him that his whole face was buried in wet her pussy.

When Laura came, her body went so rigid she seemed to be made of another material entirely. Instead of screaming, she made the silent gasping sound of someone so emotionally overcome – by pain or laughter or orgasm – that they can't suck enough air in to make the sound they want to.

Juices rushed from her pussy, and she began to shake violently. At last the scream came, strangled, from her throat.

Chris let her shake and tremble around him, lapping at the juices that were covering his face, before sitting up. He was lightheaded, intoxicated by what was happening as much as by the physical forces inside of him that threatened to split him open. His cock was pressing painfully against his pants, and he could feel a stain of pre-cum spreading into the fabric.

Tony met his eyes again, a coolly triumphant smile on his lips, as Laura trembled against his body. His hand dropped from her chest to her pussy, even as he kept his fingers closed gently around her neck, pressing her against him.

His calves were entwined with her legs, so she couldn't really do much but squirm and squeal in a perverse agony of intense pleasure when Tony slid his fingers into her slit, and then worked three fingers into her pussy. They squelched as he finger-fucked her slowly, rubbing over her clit with each stroke.

Laura was making sounds that seemed like attempts at words, but she was unintelligible for a few moments. Tony was still staring Chris down with the smile on his lips, which was at once domineering and somehow friendly. And somehow, it conveyed to him that he needed to back away, to get back into his chair and watch as Tony had his way with his wife.

Finally, Laura managed to say something: "Oh! I can't! It's too much!"

But Tony turned and began to speak in his low voice in her ear. Chris stared at the fat bundle of fingers Tony was sinking into his wife's engorged and soaked pussy, unable to make out what he was saying until he caught: "...take it all. You ready?"

Although it seemed impossible that Chris's insides could be further wrenched than they were, he felt as though another cold punch had landed in his gut: this was really happening. The thick length of black cock now pulsing against the small of his wife's back was going to be fed into the quivering wet hole that Tony was now stretching playfully with his fingers.

Laura said nothing, just made a sound and continued to shake and shudder as Tony primed her again.

He shifted, and Laura dropped like a rag doll to the bed. Tony yanked her ankles, manhandling her a little but with the smooth control of a man who manhandles women regularly. He positioned himself between her legs, his penis erect in front of him, seeming bigger than it had seemed before, bobbing lightly with his own excitement.

Laura's eyes went directly to his cock, and her expression was one of awe. Her mouth fell open and she watched only Tony's cock as he pushed her legs up to her ears until her bottom tilted up from the bed and her pussy yawned open, inches from Tony's fat shaft.

Chris had to tear his eyes from her hypnotized expression to watch what he had wanted so desperately to see and to never see: the black, fleshy snake pressed against Laura's swollen pink gash. For a moment it looked like it couldn't possibly fit inside.

As wet as she was, Tony's cock bent slightly as he started to press into her, and Laura gasped. "It's too big," she whispered, still staring at it. She made a sound as Tony continued to press into her, until the pink edges of her inner lips peeked out from the sides of his crown like flames licking the bottom of an object they are about to consume.

Laura moaned and squealed as Tony's cock sank into her. Her pussy was stretched taut, and all those inches of cock seemed too many to be accommodated by the small width of her waist. Tony's big balls came to rest against her ass, and he was inside. He gave her a short thrust upward, to really drive himself in, and then he paused as Laura squirmed beneath him, making tiny movements to accommodate him.

“That’s it, get used to it, get comfortable, because you’re gonna have to take it for a long time,” Tony said.

Another punch landed in Chris’s gut.

Tony began to fuck his wife slowly, but after a few gentle thrusts he built up to hammering her so much that the mattress bounced lightly and Laura began to moan in bursts interrupted by her sinking further into the foam. Her ass bounced further and further up, as Tony leaned on her legs and almost curved her around.

Chris stared at the scene in fragments: Laura’s feet twisting in circles, Tony’s cock pistoning in and out of her hole, her tiny asshole being slapped by his balls on each thrust, her wrists and ankles encircled by Tony’s dark fingers.

Laura began to scream; it sounded almost alarming until she added, “don’t stop, don’t stop!” and Chris realized that her screams were of intense pleasure. She was going to come.

When she did come again, her pussy squelched with even more juices than before, and Chris could see that her legs were trembling and she was struggling against Tony’s firm grip on her ankles. But Tony did not stop, he just continued to hammer into her.

He slowed at last, leaning in and letting her legs fall down. Laura’s legs closed around him, her heels resting on Tony’s muscled buttocks. Chris watched as the sculpted black flesh of Tony’s body rocked gently on top of his wife, only vaguely aware that Tony was purring gently in her ear as though to soothe her.

But Tony’s intentions became clear when he rose up and slid his hands under Laura’s legs to close them around him as he sat back on his heels. Laura clung to his neck and allowed herself to be lifted until she was sitting on his lap and he was bouncing her slowly on his cock.

“I’m so... I can’t, I don’t think I can take any more,” Laura complained, her head tilting back and her eyes half-closed.

Tony continued to use her body like a meat puppet, lifting her easily by the upper thighs and dropping her onto his lap to slide her pussy up and down his column.

“You can take it,” he consoled Laura.

For several minutes Tony used her body like that, while Laura squealed and complained that she couldn’t take any more. After a few

minutes, something changed in her voice, and her body began to move of its own volition: Laura was hungry again.

And then it was suddenly Laura riding Tony wildly. The bull released his grip on her and leaned back on his hands to enjoy the show of her bouncing tits and her consumed expression of determination: the only thing on Laura's mind now was making herself come again. She needed no encouragement but Tony occasionally gave it to her anyway.

She threw her head back as she hopped wildly on Tony's cock. Her skin was wet like a well-run horse, her tits engorged, her mouth wet and open. Every part of her, in fact, seemed to be beautifully swollen and damp, and Chris could smell her scent from where he was. It filled the room.

She was starting to move faster, when she dropped her gaze to look at Chris.

Her eyes burned through him as she met his stare unflinchingly, and bounced hard on Tony's cock.

She pushed her wild hair up and away from her face. "I'm going to... come..." she panted.

Tony pushed her off his cock and drew himself backward in a quick and practiced motion. Laura was left on her knees, legs spread slightly, and her hands being pulled forward by Tony. She let a sound of disappointment escape her throat, her eyes wild and hungry.

Tony placed her hands on the bed, so that she was on her hands and knees, facing Chris. He moved to the head of the bed and started to fuck her from behind, no pretense, just Tony slamming into his wife again.

"You must be dyin' man," Tony breathed from behind her. "Get in there, have her suck you off."

He was in such a daze that he had no idea how he removed his pants and pushed down his underwear, but within moments he was holding his aching cock in his hands and pointing it toward his wife's mouth.

She met his eyes again as he fed himself to her. Her body rocked slightly with each of Tony's thrusts, her lips spread around him, her mouth was hot and wet, and, Chris reminded himself, still tainted with Tony's cum.

Her almond eyes blinked up at him for as long as she could, and before long he was enveloped in her mouth and throat and all of the tight, sweet, wet submission of her swallowing his cock.

Tony was pounding her so hard that she pushed and pulled along Chris's shaft from that motion alone.

He had only to look up from the scene of her mouth ramming toward his pubic bone, to see the black man facing him, grinning at him, shoveling his cock into her pussy, to feel his own seed boil up and overflow.

He looked down, and felt himself draining into Laura's mouth. She maintained her suction around his shaft, swallowing his load, massaging him with her mouth until he could take no more and shakily backed away to watch the final scene.

He collapsed into the chair, and Tony pulled Laura's hair gently to make her look at him. Her lips were swollen, her lipstick smeared, much like she had been that night of the club. Black mascara smudged her cheeks, and her tits swung between her arms.

"I'm gonna fuck a nice big load into your wife, here," Tony said, looking at him over Laura's slightly vacant gaze.

But he fucked the load into Laura later – nearly ten excruciating minutes later. He sawed slowly until the tone of her moans crescendoed to a high-pitched squeal again, and it was obvious she was going to come.

"Look at him," Tony instructed her, tugging her hair again. "Look at him while I make you come, and look at him while I fuck this load into your pussy." He looked up briefly at Chris, then back down again, his hands dropping to Laura's hips to get a better grip on her and slam harder into her.

"This pussy is so nice and *tight*," he said. "I just want to fuck this little thing until it's all stretched out."

Chris felt his cock twitching to life, and he looked at Laura, who was staring at him as instructed, but obviously miles away in her own mind as her orgasm built up and spilled over.

And then Tony slammed hard into her with five or six violent thrusts, groaning at the same, leaving little doubt that a fountain of his come was erupting inside Laura's pussy.

For a moment the whole scene was frozen on the bed like a tableau: the crust of cum hardened on Laura's chin and cheek, in her wild hair, Tony's fingers still entwined in her sweaty tresses and suspending her head so that she was looking at Chris. The sculpted muscle of Tony's body behind Laura, towering over her, his dick still inside of her where Chris knew it was throbbing. Only their heavy breathing made them seem real.

Tony's cock slipped out of Laura and flopped against his thigh. Tony looked at Chris while adjusting his cock, gave a final sweep of the scene he had created, at Laura's pussy, and her ass, and then he got up from the bed. "Gotta shower," he said blandly, and walked to the bathroom, unhurried.

Laura sat up, pulling some of the messed-up sheets with her. She seemed a little like a person waking from a deep sleep, looking around her as though wondering exactly how she had gotten there. Then she lifted her eyes to look at Chris. She looked almost sheepish.

Chris extended his finger and pointed in her direction, without lifting his hand from the armrest. "Drop the sheet," he said.

Laura let it fall, and sat there, somewhat unsure of what to do, as they waited for Tony to finish his shower. Laura might have felt awkward: Chris could see she might have, but he himself felt strangely relaxed.

Tony was drying his back, unclothed and unbothered, when he walked back into the room. He dressed just as unhurriedly, walked over to Laura, turned her chin toward him and kissed her. "You got my number," he said plainly. Then he shot Chris a neutral look, turned his collar up, and spun around to exit the room.

The door clicked shut and there was a silence.

Chris stood up, enjoying the feel of his rock-solid erection, which was keeping his dick pointed straight in front of him.

"You're not mad?" Laura asked, as he approached her. She leaned back to her elbows as he climbed onto the bed. He tugged on her knees and straightened her legs out, then straddled her at her knees and pushed her legs slightly open.

His wife's pussy yawned at him, still quivering, cum oozing from inside and dripping down her taint.

And then, slowly, he sank into her, and she shuddered around him and complained that she was sore, but he could feel after a few slow thrusts that she was warming up again. Her cunt was hot and so slick with cum that he could barely get any friction, but the images of Tony pumping her from behind were so vivid and fresh it didn't matter, it was a challenge to get her to come one last time before he added his load to the overflowing well of her pussy.

CHAPTER 16

In the end, Laura left it alone.

After Tony had filled her full of his come, and she had felt his hot seed spreading between his girth and the stretched walls of her pussy, reality had come creeping slowly back into her mind. It came through her daze in pieces, the way a sound incorporates into a dream, and then pulls you slowly to wakefulness. For her, it was the gentle tug of drying cum on her skin, the scent of her juices, the sound of the shower in the bathroom.

This was real. She was in a hotel and she had a pussy full of another man's cum, and her husband was staring at her from a chair.

She had pulled the sheets up to try and hide the whole thing, as if that would help. Her mind raced: had she really done this?

When Chris told her to let the sheet fall, she had started to worry. What had she been thinking?

He'll never be okay with this, she remembered thinking.

And yet, after Tony left, they had made love. No shower first, no hesitation, no remorse.

Lying on the bed afterward, Chris had told her that he loved what she had done. He was more talkative than usual, and as she lay there listening to his own confession she was silent. It seemed like the time to bare this one little secret, her attraction to black men, the way it made her prone to things that she didn't herself understand.

She had been so close to telling him, then. It was an odd little secret, wasn't it? The kind of secret that maybe it wasn't worth telling. After all, maybe it was obvious to Chris that she had an obsession with black cock, that it was purely sexual, and that she was out of control. Chris knew about everything she had *done*.

Was it wrong not to tell him everything she thought?

"Do you think we'll... I don't know, call Tony again?" he asked her, stroking her shoulder.

Laura's gut tightened, and her pussy throbbed with the memory of how full and stretched she had felt. The taste of him, the memory of the shape of his fat cock was still in her mouth.

What kind of person had she become?

She trailed her fingers along her husband's chest. She loved him more than ever now. In those moments, as they waited for Tony to leave, she had felt as though she had just destroyed everything. She could *feel it* – it had felt real, and she had known then how much she loved Chris.

The feel of those moments surged inside of her, and she decided it was best to leave things as they were.

Do you think we'll... I don't know, call Tony again?

"I mean, I guess, if you want to," she said, as though she didn't care.

There was a long silence, while her thoughts drifted off to the very carnal. She didn't really hear Chris when he said, "We'll have to wait and see."

They started to kiss, and she was burning hot again, ready to fuck wildly even though her pussy was sore. In those moments, as she rose to the heights of another mind-shattering orgasm, and her husband came for the third time, it was easy to believe there was no need to talk about any of it in further detail.

After all, everyone seemed happy, just the way things were.

*

When they left the room it was early morning. The car had been towed, which made Chris laugh. They called the kids but of course there was no answer. It was too early for them.

"We should really get home," Laura said, taking out her phone to call a cab. They were laughing, holding hands, and feeling young again. The blue early morning light – the kind you only see if you are out far too late, and which neither of them had seen for years – and the cold air made Laura feel invigorated, even after being up all night.

She was tapping on her phone when Chris reached out for her hand. "I don't believe this," he said.

"What?"

She looked up, out of concern, because his voice seemed urgent, almost manic. There was nothing to see but a few people walking through the shabby door of what looked like a dive bar.

"This place is open," Chris said.

Laura looked at the facade. “Ming’s House of Jade?” she said. She looked down at her phone. “It’s morning.”

The door was swinging closed behind some obvious patrons, there was an “Open” sign glowing at the window, and inside she could see quite a few people seated at tables.

“Humor me,” Chris said.

She looked back up at the awning, unable to understand why a Chinese restaurant was open this early. (They would learn later that the night shifts of several call centers came here after work).

“Humor me,” Chris insisted.

Laura looked out at the street. Another group of people opened the door, and the bell jingled, and she was reminded of another time in her life: when everything was fresh and new between her and Chris. Uncertain, exciting. When they had stayed up late, and gone to cheap restaurants with dusty red tassels hanging from the chandeliers and had the time of their lives.

It was all still there.

She started to look down at her screen, to say that they needed to go home...

It was all still there.

She stopped herself, looked up, and shrugged. “Okay,” she said.

Why not?

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

Working On Her Game

Will has landed a lucrative position at a law firm in New Mexico, but the transition to the slow-moving, scorching Southwest has been a strain on his marriage. His wife has surprised him by taking up a new sport to fill her time. But it isn’t long before the couple discover that Scarlett’s new

instructor can give her a lot more than just tennis lessons. Her dark, handsome tennis coach might have just the thing their marriage needs...

Game For More

Scarlett and Will are not finished with the adventure they began in *Working On Her Game*. Will gives his blessing to Scarlett to return to her physical relationship with her tennis instructor. At first, their sex life is re-invigorated and the affair seems to bring them closer together. But the young, Italian bull is always pushing the limits of Will's jealousy, Scarlett's comfort zone, and the strength of their marriage. Will things go too far?

Mixed Doubles

Will thought that Scarlett's affair with her tennis instructor ended months ago, but her strange behavior makes him suspect otherwise. As evidence of Scarlett's cheating mounts, Will discovers that he enjoys the thrill of Scarlett's now very illicit affair: the casual lies, the deleted texts, the sneaking around. But there is much more to Scarlett's renewed affair with Alessandro than meets Will's eyes, and she may be in way over her head. Is there any way to untangle the delicious mess Scarlett has made, while salvaging the trust in their marriage?

Romantic Hotwife Books By Arnica:

Hannah Gets Hot

When Hannah has a chance encounter with a younger man on a plane, Twitter goes crazy for their "budding romance." Her husband Mike sees an opportunity to seize on his long-hidden fantasies. While Hannah is attracted to the hot, young guy from the plane, she's far too loyal to her husband to have an affair... at first. This is a slow-burning story of wife-sharing for the first time, with a scorching finale.

A Taste For Teasing

Oren knows he's a lucky man with a hot wife: Monica is blond, stunning, and has a killer body. She was even a cheerleader in the NBA in her university days – and there are even more interesting jobs in her resume than that. But Monica is also a practical, down-to-earth, and happily married woman.

Things take a turn one year when they're vacationing with friends. Oren discovers that he has a taste for thinking about his wife with another man. And Monica has a taste for... well, something. Monica is becoming a hotwife before his eyes: but Oren can't be sure of *who* she's teasing. Is his fantasy coming true, or is it turning sour? Was there more to Monica's past than she ever let on? Is a hotwife really what he wants?

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Houseguest

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Body of Research

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a “hobby job.” Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's “hobby job” make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to is wife – maybe even himself?

Interracial hotwife books by Arnica:

Interracial Hotwife Bundle

Includes *The Tenant*, *Not Black and White*, and *Grand Slam* for \$5.99

Claudia Changes Tack

Mike is on his friends' luxury sailboat with his stunning blond wife Claudia, hoping for nothing more than to convince Claudia that sailing is enjoyable. It turns out that his friends are swingers, in the Caribbean for more than just

the sailing. And it turns out that Claudia has a streak of voyeurism in her. The couple embark on a mild adventure of exploration and sexual reawakening on the warm, beautiful beaches of the Caribbean, and it seems like the ideal vacation.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken. But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

Lisa Plays Her Part

Lisa and Luke married young because of an unexpected pregnancy, and Lisa never had much experience with other men as a result. But when a dark, handsome, wealthy man she almost slept with (and always wondered about) resurfaces in her life, Lisa is confronted with agonizing desires... and choices. Now that their nest is empty and they don't have the same reasons

to stay together, will Lisa and Luke reconnect, or will Lisa choose to make this the final act of their marriage?

Megyn For The Win

In Megyn's view, nothing could be sillier than entering a charity contest to win a "date" with the sexy black celebrity Max Riley, not even to raise money for underprivileged youth. (Un)fortunately for her, her friend entered her in the contest anyway.

When she wins, her husband Peter sees a chance to dip into a fantasy of his. But when this brush with fate turns into a very real, permanent job offer for Megyn – one that puts her in close and frequent contact with the famed black actor – the couple has a lot more to think about than just a winning a "date."

A romantic, interracial hotwife story with a win at the end!

Hotwife Suspense By Arnica Butler

Nila's Long Con

It began with a chance encounter with a man from his wife's past. Rich knew Tennile had some skeletons – of a sexual nature – in her closet, but he never dreamed they were going to come back to haunt them both. Before he can blink, the two of them are embroiled in high-stakes intrigue, with Tennile's reputation and career, their marriage, and a lot of money on the line. There seems to be no way out but to play the game, and Tennile's past might be game-winning asset. In the style of *A Well-Laid Trap*, this is a thrilling hotwife ride that will keep you hooked until the end.

A Well-Laid Trap

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

Fun Summer Swinger Titles:

Clothing Optional

Sy Price and his wife find themselves in an unexpected situation when their Belize vacation resort turns out to be “Clothing Optional.” They’re even more surprised to find out that “Clothing Optional” is code for quite a bit more. They decide to make the best of things and enjoy their vacation. But there are a lot more surprises in store for Sy when Jackie decides to fully embrace the hotel amenities...

A Summer Vacation

Poor Keith. He's been condemned to a campy cruise with his family and friends. Worse yet, he suspects something is going on between his wife and bad-boy Hank, the husband of a family friend his wife has invited along. Keith's in for a very big surprise – and much more naughty, adult fun than he expected on this cruise – when he finds out what's really going on.

Try To Have Some Fun

Helena and Steve's wealthy, sexy, swinger friends have returned to town. Helena has a child- and work-free stretch of summer ahead of her. There's nothing stopping her from spending her days relaxing by their spectacular pool. No reason not to borrow a tiny bikini, or to maybe sunbathe topless. Or skinny-dip at one of their wild parties. One thing, though, will probably lead to another...

*Explore **darker** themes by Arnica Butler:*

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.